





# Delhi’s disaster management staff get salary hike after 16 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has hiked the remuneration of disaster management personnel by up to 100 per cent, the first rise in more than a decade and a half.

Their previous salary hike was in 2009. The move will benefit staff working under the Delhi State Disaster Management Authority, including project officers, district project officers, and project coordinators.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the decision will provide these personnel with a remuneration increase of up to 100 per cent.

The chief minister described it as a long-overdue measure to deliver justice to officials who have served as the backbone of Delhi’s disaster management system since 2009, despite not receiving a single revision in their remuneration over the past 16 years.

The Chief Minister said these positions were created

in 2009 with the support of the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP). Since then, the monthly remuneration of project officers, district project officers and project coordinators had remained unchanged for 16 years.

During this period, inflation rose, disaster management challenges became more complex, responsibilities continued to expand and the scope of their work grew significantly. Yet, the monthly remuneration remained fixed



at ₹25,000 for project officers and district project officers and ₹20,000 for project coordinators. She further said

that these posts were never linked to any regular government pay structure or equivalent pay category. As a result,

the staff neither benefited from periodic pay revisions nor received Dearness Allowance (DA), unlike other government employees.

The chief minister said that, after taking all these factors into account, the approved remuneration structure provides for an increase of up to 100 per cent for these personnel. She said the revision is not an ex gratia benefit but a step towards establishing a fair and competitive remuneration structure that reflects their responsibilities,

experience, technical expertise and the demands of the present time.

The Chief Minister said these personnel perform far more than routine office duties. They discharge critical statutory responsibilities under the Disaster Management Act, 2005.

Their work includes preparing district-level disaster management plans, carrying out scientific risk assessments, assessing vulnerabilities in Delhi’s sensitive areas and among vulnerable pop-

ulations, formulating risk mitigation strategies, coordinating among various departments and managing Emergency Operation Centres (EOCs) during disasters while ensuring real-time coordination between the NDRF, SDRF, Fire Services, Police, the Health Department and other agencies. They also organise training programmes, conduct large-scale mock drills and play an important role in building the capacity of various stakeholders.

## Govt rejects AAP’s allegations of bicycle scam

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

BJP MLA and Delhi Government spokesperson Harish Khurana on Sunday rejected AAP Delhi convener Saurabh Bharadwaj’s allegations of a bicycle scam in the procurement of cycles for schoolgirls. Khurana said the procurement was conducted through a completely transparent process.

He further alleged that the AAP Government in Punjab purchased four lakh school bags from a Delhi-based company in party colours carrying the Chief Minister’s photograph, effectively shutting local Punjab manufacturers out of the bidding.

Earlier, the AAP on Sunday questioned the eligibility criteria and application process for the Delhi government’s Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, and alleged that the scheme’s 10-year resi-

dency requirement could exclude some women, objecting to the requirement of recommendation letters from MPs or MLAs.

Delhi AAP chief Saurabh Bharadwaj said the residency condition and the application process should be reviewed. He questioned why applicants under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana would need recommendations from MPs or MLAs. He urged Chief Minister Rekha Gupta to explain the rationale behind the requirement, saying women should not have to approach elected representatives to access benefits under the scheme.

Commenting on the allegations, Khurana said Bharadwaj had based his bicycle scam allegations solely on a complaint made by a private company and that the real objective was to divert public attention from the Punjab school bag scam and six separate exam

paper leak cases in Punjab, and to shield Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann.

On the bicycle procurement, Khurana said bicycles are available in a wide range of models and price points, with prices in the Delhi market ranging from ₹4,000-5,000 to ₹40,000-50,000 depending on the model and features. He said the variation in prices reflects the market and not any irregularity. He said there has been no bicycle scam in Delhi and the procurement was done transparently.

On the Punjab school bag allegation, Khurana said the Punjab Government designed tender conditions that effectively excluded all local companies in the state from the bidding, and then purchased four lakh school bags from a Delhi-based company for free distribution to Class XI and XII students. He alleged the bags were made in yellow and

blue, which he identified as AAP’s party colours, and carried the photograph of the Chief Minister.

Khurana said distributing bags in party colours to Class XI and XII students was comparable to an attempt to influence students who will become first-time voters after turning 18 ahead of next year’s Punjab Assembly elections. He said school bag manufacturers and traders in Punjab are upset because the government bypassed local industry by sourcing the bags from outside the state at what he described as arbitrary prices.

He said AAP leaders have always acted against the interests of Delhi and making baseless allegations reflects their longstanding approach. He said Bharadwaj is using a commercial complaint as political cover to distract from accountability in Punjab.

## LG tells DU freshers to cultivate intellectual curiosity

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Sunday shared highlights of his address at the Freshers’ Orientation Programme 2026 of Kirori Mal College, University of Delhi, underscoring the need to cultivate intellectual curiosity. He shared a personal reflection with the students, saying, “I am a product of Delhi University,” recalling that he had completed both his graduation and post-graduation in Delhi and had never studied abroad.

“Whatever I have been able to contribute in service of the nation overseas was built on the foundation laid at Delhi University,” he said, urging students to have confidence in India’s institutions and their own abilities.

Sandhu also inaugurated the Kirori Mal College Incubation Centre, quoting



Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s remark that “India’s university campuses are emerging as dynamic centres where Yuva Shakti drives breakthrough innovations”.

The inauguration took place during the college’s Orientation Programme 2026 at the Shankar Lal Concert Hall, University of Delhi. The LG also inaugurated the Science Block Lift. The event was attended by Kirori Mal College Governing Body

Chairperson Prof Vasuben Trivedi, Delhi University Registrar Vikas Gupta, Principal Prof Dinesh Khattar, faculty members, parents and students.

In a message on X, Sandhu said, “Addressed the Freshers’ Orientation Programme 2026 of Kirori Mal College, University of Delhi. For every student, this marks the beginning of a journey of intellectual discovery, personal growth and expanding horizons.

“Encouraged them to cultivate intellectual curiosity, a scientific temperament and independent thinking, while embracing the values of service, integrity and excellence. Wished them an enriching and meaningful road ahead, guided by a lifelong spirit of learning,” he said.

Sandhu said university campuses were emerging as centres where young people were driving new ideas and technological breakthroughs. He said the newly inaugurated incubation centre would support research and entrepreneurship among students.

The LG said whatever he had been able to contribute in service of the nation overseas was built on the foundation laid at Delhi University, and that his message to every student was to believe in themselves, have confidence in India’s institutions, opportunities, and their own capabilities, adding that the future was theirs to shape.

**PUBLIC NOTICE**

This is to inform to all concern that Mr. Bashir Ahmed S/o Mr. Abdul Latif R/o Vill- Sultanpur, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar U.P. who is the original owner of Residential Plot No.SP-01, Sector-132, Noida (U.P) Mr. Bashir Ahmed expired on 18.10.2015.

The WILL was executed in favour of Mr. Sushil Kumar S/o Sh. Jai Prakash R/o Village Soroka Zahidabad, Noida G.B. Nagar U.P. which is registered in Sub Registrar-III, Noida Bahi No.3, Jild No.683, Page No.45-56, Serial No.885 at dt 24.03.2015. So it is informed to all concern that the said Property Plot No.SP-01, Sector-132, Noida (U.P) is going to be transferred in favour of Mr. Sushil Kumar S/o Sh. Jai Prakash R/o Village Soroka Zahidabad, Noida G.B. Nagar, If anyone has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the Residential Plot Department of the Noida Authority within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. **Mr. Sushil Kumar**

**PUBLIC NOTICE**

This is to inform to all concern that Mr. Bashir Ahmed S/o Mr. Abdul Latif R/o Vill- Sultanpur, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar U.P. who is the original owner of Residential Plot No.SP-03, Sector-132, Noida (U.P) Mr. Bashir Ahmed expired on 18.10.2015.

The WILL was executed in favour of Mr. Amit Tyagi S/o Sh. Rajender Singh R/o Vill- Sultanpur, Noida G.B. Nagar U.P. which is registered in Sub Registrar-III, Noida Bahi No.3, Jild No.683, Page No.129-140, Serial No.892 at dt 24.03.2015. So it is informed to all concern that the said Property Plot No.SP-03, Sector-132, Noida (U.P) is going to be transferred in favour of Mr. Amit Tyagi S/o Sh. Rajender Singh R/o Vill- Sultanpur, Noida G.B. Nagar, If anyone has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the Residential Plot Department of the Noida Authority within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. **Mr. Amit Tyagi**

## CM reviews healthcare services at Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta visited Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital in Mayur Vihar Phase-II to assess healthcare services and hear directly from patients and their families. During the visit, she reviewed key aspects of the hospital’s functioning, including cleanliness, medicine availability

and the quality of medical care, while reaffirming the Delhi Government’s commitment to delivering timely and dignified healthcare to every resident.

During her visit, the Chief Minister spent time speaking with patients and their attendants, listening carefully to their experiences, suggestions and expectations. Stressing the importance of public participation in



improving healthcare, she said, “direct public engagement is the foundation of a better healthcare system.”

The interaction formed a key part of the visit, reflecting the government’s focus on understanding people’s experiences within public healthcare facilities. Alongside meeting patients, Rekha Gupta inspected several aspects of the hospital’s operations. She reviewed cleanli-

ness standards, checked the availability of medicines and assessed the quality of healthcare services being provided.

Following the inspection, she instructed the concerned officials to ensure that the required improvements are carried out without delay.

The Chief Minister reiterated that maintaining the trust of every patient remains a top priority for the Delhi Government.

सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया

Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "केन्द्रित" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

Regional Office Delhi (South)

3rd Floor, Sorabji Bhawan, 4/54, D.B.

Gupta Road, Karolbagh, New Delhi-110005

E-AUCTION

SALE NOTICE

(Under SARFAESI Act 2002)

APPENDIX- IV-A [SEE PROVISIO TO RULE 8(6) & 9(1)] SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) & 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower(s) and guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged / charged to the Central Bank of India (secured creditor), the constructive/ physical Possession of which have been taken by the authorized officer of Central Bank of India(Secured creditors), will be sold on “As is where is”, “As is what is” and “whatever there is” basis on date 25.08.2026 for recovery of dues to the Central Bank of India from below mention Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s). The Reserve Price and Earnest money deposit (EMD) is displayed against the details of respective properties.

E-AUCTION SCHEDULED TO BE HELD ON 25.08.2026 (15 DAY'S NOTICE)

| S. No. | Name of Branch   | Authorised Officer/ Branch Head            | Name of the Account       | Description of Property & Owner Name                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | Demand Notice Date & Amount Dues (in Rupees)         | Date & Type of Possession | In Rupees Reserve Price EMD Bid Increase          |
|--------|------------------|--------------------------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| 1.     | Narela New Delhi | Mr. Mahesh Choudhary<br>Mobile: 9711196480 | M/s S S ENTERPRISES       | Built Up Property Bearing No.2420 A, Land Measuring 174 Sq. Yards, First Floor with Roof Rights, Plot No.2, Out of Kharsa No.285 Min, Situated in the Area of Village Mamoorpur, Narela, Delhi-110040, Abadi known as Mandi Extension Part - I, (Opposite New Anaj Mandi), Main Bawana Road, Narela, Delhi-110040.<br>Owner: Savitri Devi                                                        | Rs.144.55 on 02.08.2022 + interest thereafter        | 06.07.2023 (Physical)     | ₹ 76,50,000.00<br>₹ 7,65,000.00<br>₹ 50,000.00    |
| 2.     | Narela New Delhi | Mr. Mahesh Choudhary<br>Mobile: 9711196480 | M/s S S ENTERPRISES       | Built Up Property Bearing No.2420 A, Land Measuring 62 Sq. Yards, Plot No.2 on Ground Floor without Roof Rights, Out of Kharsa No.285 Min, Three Shops bearing Pvt. Shop No.1 to 6, situated in the Area of Village Mamoorpur, Narela, Delhi-110040, Abadi known as Mandi Extension Part - I, (Opposite New Anaj Mandi), Bawana Road, Narela, Delhi-110040.<br>Owner: Savitri Devi               | Rs.144.55 on 02.08.2022 + interest thereafter        | 06.07.2023 (Physical)     | ₹ 47,70,000.00<br>₹ 4,77,000.00<br>₹ 45,000.00    |
| 3.     | Narela New Delhi | Mr. Mahesh Choudhary<br>Mobile: 9711196480 | M/s S S ENTERPRISES       | Double Storey Built Up Property at House No.2357T/4, Land Measuring 240 Sq.Yards out of Kharsa No.235, Situated at Village Pana Mamoorpur, Narela, Delhi-110040, Colony known as Shivaji Nagar, Bawana Road, Narela, Delhi-110040.<br>Owner: Rajinder Prashad S/o Mr. Jagdish Chander                                                                                                            | Rs.144.55 on 02.08.2022 + interest thereafter        | 06.07.2023 (Physical)     | ₹ 1,05,30,000.00<br>₹ 10,53,000.00<br>₹ 50,000.00 |
| 4.     | Okhla New Delhi  | Mr. Praveen Kumar<br>Mobile: 9205596548    | Mr. Narayan Bhattacharjee | Second Floor Pvt Bearing No SF-4, without it's Roof Rights, Portion of Property No.- H-1/55, Area Measuring 60 Square Yards i.e. 50.166 Sq Meter, out of Kharsa No 79/17/20 and 79/24, Situated in the Area of Village- Palam, Colony known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi- 110045, with one small Car Parking stilt Ground Floor, Owner: Mr. Narayan Bhattacharjee and Mrs. Jhumi Bhattacharjee. | Rs. 41,70,305.00 on 30.11.2024 + Interest thereafter | 12.12.2025 (Physical)     | ₹ 25,50,000.00<br>₹ 2,55,000.00<br>₹ 25,000.00    |

E-AUCTION DATE: 25.08.2026, TIME: 12:00 NOON TO 04:00 PM WITH AUTO EXTENSION OF 10 MINUTES

Last Date & Time of Submission of EMD and Documents (Online) On or Before: 25.08.2026 Upto 03:30 PM.

Bidder will register on website: <https://BAANKNET.com> and upload KYC documents and after verification of KYC documents by the service provider, EMD to be deposited in BAANKNET EMD wallet through NEFT/RTGS/Transfer / Generation of challan from (<https://BAANKNET.com> ). The auction will be conducted through common landing platform BAANKNET.com Portal (<https://BAANKNET.com> ). E-auction will be held “As is where is”, “As is what is” and “whatever there is” basis. Property shall be sold only above the Reserve Price. (All other charges/ dues to the property will be borne by the purchaser). For detailed terms and conditions please refer to the link provided in [www.centralbank.bank.in](http://www.centralbank.bank.in) in Secured Creditor or auction platform (<https://BAANKNET.com> ). Helpdesk: (+91) 8291220220, E-mail: support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com

STATUTORY 15 DAY'S SALE NOTICE UNDER RULE 8(6) & 9(1) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002

Borrowers/Guarantors/ Mortgagors are hereby notified to pay the sum as mentioned above along with upto date interest and ancillary expenses before the date of e-auction, failing which the property will be auctioned/sold and balance dues, if any, will be recovered with interest and cost.

DATE: 01.08.2026

PLACE: NEW DELHI

Authorised Officer,  
CENTRAL BANK OF INDIA, RO Delhi (South), New Delhi

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Vinita Pandey W/o Dhirendra Paratap Pandey, R/o- WZ-1322, Nangal Raya, South West Delhi, Delhi-110046, declare that in my Ration Card (No. 077004143057, allocation year 2014), my name has been erroneously written as Binu Pandey whereas my correct name is Vinita Pandey which may be amended accordingly. I, No.14667148Y Hav Jethva Rajeshkumar Balvantsang, R/o- VPO- Gadu, Teh- Bhanvad, Dist- Devbhumi Dwarka, Gujarat- 360590, have changed my daughter's name from Vaibhaviva to Vaibhaviva Rajeshkumar Jethva, vide affidavit dated 01/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. I, No.14667148Y Hav Jethva Rajeshkumar Balvantsang, R/o- VPO- Gadu, Teh- Bhanvad, Dist- Devbhumi Dwarka, Gujarat- 360590, have changed my son's name from Jayveer Singh to Jayveersinh Rajeshkumar Jethva, vide affidavit dated 01/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. I, Umesh Kumar, S/o JC-423429P Sub Sunil Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Rewali, Tehsil- Gandala, Distt- Kotputli-Behrur, Rajasthan- 301701, have changed my name from Umesh Kumar to Umesh Yadav, vide affidavit dated 01/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. I, Sukhbir, Father of No.16022956Y Hav Narender R/o- Vill- Chirwai, PO/Dist/Teh- Palwal, Haryana- 121102, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Sukhvir whereas my correct name is Sukhbir which may be amended accordingly.

I, Savitri, Mother of No.16022956Y Hav Narender R/o- Vill- Chirwai, PO/Dist/ Teh- Palwal, Haryana- 121102, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Savitri Devi whereas my correct name is Savitri which may be amended accordingly. I, Susma Devi W/o- No.15783082H Hav Vijay Kumar, R/o- Vill/Post & Teh- Obra, Dist- Aurangabad, Bihar- 824124, have changed my name from Susma Devi to Sushma Devi, vide affidavit dated 01/08/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. I, Vijaya Shankar Yadav, Mother of JC-857898X Sub(OF) Yadav Tatyaso Shankar, R/o- At Post- Tarukh, Teh- Karad, Distt- Satara, Maharashtra- 415103, declare that in my son's service record my D.O.B is wrongly mentioned as 01/07/1932 whereas my correct DOB is 01/01/1947 which may be amended accordingly. I, SUMAN SHARMA alias SUMAN d/o VIJAY KUMAR SHARMA and w/o ASHUTOSH SHARMA r/o A-13, Raj Park, Sultanpur Mazra, Delhi- 110086 have changed my name as SUMAN. I, Shri Bhagwan Sharma S/o Ram Kishan Sharma R/o D-401, Plot No. 48, Pochanpur Extension, Dwarka, Delhi declare that name of mine has been wrongly written as Jaibir Sharma in my Son's Deepak Kumar Bhardwaj School certificate. The actual name of mine is Shri Bhagwan Sharma which may be amended.

LOST & FOUND

Lost Original Sale Deed of Property No. XII/5658, in Gali No.2, Chandrawal, Old Subzi Mandi, Delhi-110007 duly executed by Sh. Sham Sunder in favour of Sh. Sant Singh vide Sale Deed duly registered as document no.4626 in Addl. Book No.1, Volume No. 1842 at Pages 01 to 03 dt. 18/05/1987, with the Sub. Registrar, Delhi vide NCR Lodged LR No. 502125/2026 dt. 01/08/2026. Finder's) Please Contact Sh. Baldev Nagi (M.9871199632).

PUBLIC NOTICE

Our client, Sh. Kamal Mohammed S/o Late Haji Sheikh Mohammed Adil S/o Late Haji Mohd. Muslim R/o H.No.- 495/2, Gali Tokon Wali, Choori Wala Jama Masjid, Delhi-110006 do hereby notify for public at large that he is registering the Will Deed of his father Haji Sheikh Mohammed Adil who expired on 11-12-2012, as per his Will Deed made on 09-11-2012 in favour of our client. Any person(s) having any objection/claim(s), interest for the proposed Will and Codicil Registration of aforesaid Haji Sheikh Mohammed Adil may contact the undersigned within 3 days from the Publication of this notice, failing which the claim of any such person waived and/or abandoned and the Will Deed shall be Registered with immediate effect.

ROHIT YADAV (ADVOCATE)

Ch. no. 402, Civil Side Tishazari, Delhi-110054

PUBLIC NOTICE

This is to inform to all concern that Mr. Bashir Ahmed S/o Mr. Abdul Latif R/o Vill- Sultanpur, Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar U.P. who is the original owner of Residential Plot No.SP-02 & SP-04 Sector-132, Noida (U.P) Mr. Bashir Ahmed expired on 18.10.2015.

The WILL was executed in favour of Mr. Sushil Sharma S/o Sh. Khushi Ram Sharma R/o Vill- Bhangel, Noida, G.B. Nagar U.P. which is registered in Sub Registrar-III, Noida Bahi No.3, Jild No.683, Page No.57-68, Serial No.886 at dt 24.03.2015. So it is informed to all concern that the said Property Plot No.SP-02 & SP-04, Sector-132, Noida (U.P) is going to be transferred in favour of Mr. Sushil Sharma S/o Sh. Khushi Ram Sharma R/o Village Bhangel, Noida, G.B. Nagar U.P. If anyone has/have any objection he/she may file his/her objection alongwith the sufficient proof in the Residential Plot Department of the Noida Authority within 15 days from the date of publication of this notice. **Mr. Sushil Sharma**

KONKAN RAILWAY CORPORATION LIMITED

(A Government of India Undertaking)

OPEN E-TENDER (SINGLE PACKET SYSTEM) INVITATION NOTICE

**Name of Work:** Supply, erection, testing and commissioning of 1500KVA, 11KV out put voltage, 3 phase, DG Set in the Projects being executed by Konkan Railway Corporation Limited. **Tender Notice No: KR/CO/EL/DG/T/15/26, Dtd: 03.08.2026. Completion Period: 12 (Twelve) Months. Estimated Cost: Rs.4,21,44,312/- excluding GST. EMD: Rs.8,42,900/- . Last Date & time for Online Submission of Tender: 24.08.2026 up to 15:00 Hrs. Opening of Tender: On 24.08.2026 at 15:30 Hrs. Amendments / Corrigendum if any, would be uploaded on IREPS website only. Submission of Tender Documents: Through IREPS. Manual Tender Documents shall not be accepted.**

ਪੰਜਾਬ ਨੈਸ਼ਨਲ ਬੈਂਕ

punjab national bank

(A GOVERNMENT OF INDIA UNDERTAKING) the name you can BANK upon!

CIRCLE OFFICE, EAST DELHI GROUND FLOOR, SCOPE MINAR, LAXMI NAGAR NEW DELHI-110092 Email: coeastdelgad@pnb.bank.in

BANK PREMISES REQUIRED

Punjab National Bank requires suitable ready built and well-constructed hall type building for Branch having Carpet Area including space for ATM (1680 sqft - 2100 sqft) on lease / rental basis premises should be preferably on Ground Floor and if in First Floor, lift facility at KAMLA NAGAR, NEW DELHI-110007. Premises offered should have all clearance certificates from statutory authorities. Interested owners / registered Power of Attorney Holders of such premises in the desired locality who are ready to lease their readily available premises on long term lease basis preferably for 15 years or more may send their offers in the prescribed format available on Bank's Web Site <https://www.pnb.in> or the same may be obtained from the above address during office hours. The complete offer duly sealed & signed and should reach the undersigned on or before 17.08.2026 till 2.00 PM at the above address. No brokerage will be paid by the Bank. Bank reserves the right to accept or reject any or all offers at its sole discretion without assigning any reasons whatsoever.

Date: 01.08.2026

CIRCLE HEAD



# Delhi’s CJP Clash: spontaneous outrage or scripted escalation?

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH  
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police are investigating the violence that erupted during the Cockroach Janta Party’s (CJP) “Sansad Chalo” march on July 20, looking into possible coordination and outside involvement. The protest began as a youth sit-in at Jantar Mantar over alleged NEET paper leaks and calls for Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign but soon turned into clashes near Parliament Street, Rail Bhawan, and nearby areas.

Both protesters and police reported many injuries, with official figures showing over 60 students and more than 100 security personnel hurt.

There are now about 13 to

15 FIRs, covering charges like unlawful assembly, rioting, assault on public servants, property damage, and in some cases, attempted murder.

Delhi Police believe the unrest may have been planned rather than just a spontaneous reaction. About 20 teams are reviewing digital evidence, including CCTV and drone footage, body-camera videos, mobile location data, call records, encrypted chats, WhatsApp groups, social media posts, and financial transactions. With facial recognition, police identified nearly 2,900 people with criminal records at or near the protest sites between 20 and 25 July, some of whom are linked to serious crimes. Investigators say

several of these individuals returned to the protest more than once.

Officers say early evidence suggests there were organised groups within the mostly spontaneous crowd. WhatsApp groups reportedly shared advice on what to bring, such as pepper spray, how to deal with being detained, and legal contacts.

Police say the march toward Parliament continued despite warnings about stamped risks and prohibitory orders. The number of FIRs has increased from about 10. These FIRs name the CJP as an organisation and include charges such as unlawful assembly, rioting, assault on public servants, mischief, and in some cases, attempted murder and crim-



inal conspiracy under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Part of the investigation has been handed over to the Crime Branch and Special Cell to look into possible infiltration and coordination.

Investigators are also checking if political parties

and student groups were involved in the escalation. One FIR mentions events from the CJP’s formation in mid-May and speeches by AAP leaders as signs of “pre-planned and coordinated planning,” possibly involving several people and a

political group. Reports say about 20 organisations are under investigation, which matches the scale of the digital probe. However, public information mainly refers to political figures, social media influencers, and alleged anti-social elements, rather than naming 20 specific groups.

Facial recognition systems used at the protest site identified nearly 2,900 people with prior criminal records who were present between 20 and 25 July. About 989 of them had records for serious offences like murder, attempted murder, robbery, sexual offences, and arms violations.

Police say some of these people returned to the site more than once. Part of the investigation has been given

to the Crime Branch and Special Cell to look into possible infiltration by outsiders and anti-social elements.

Nearly 20 organisations, including student groups and political parties, are being investigated for their alleged roles in organising the protest. One FIR mentions speeches by AAP leaders and describes the events as signs of coordinated planning involving political actors. Police are also examining how social media may have amplified the unrest and have identified about 480 Pakistan-based accounts that spread misinformation and deepfakes related to the protests.

Courts have given careful instructions. The Delhi High Court ordered that all rele-

vant CCTV, drone, body-camera, and electronic records be preserved and asked for responses to claims of police excess. The Supreme Court ordered the release of detained minors and protesters without criminal records, stopped coercive actions against peaceful students for now, and allowed investigations of existing FIRs to continue, especially for those with prior records.

The investigation is ongoing, matching digital timelines with field intelligence and witness statements. Police stress that any action will be based on solid evidence. The focus on digital records, organisational roles, and financial movements will shape the formal charges that come next.

## Teenager apologises for viral abuse video as police investigation continues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi/Noida

A 15-year-old girl from Faridabad has publicly apologised after a video of her using abusive language about Prime Minister Narendra Modi at a protest in Delhi went viral. In a video message shared on Saturday, she said she felt “extremely embarrassed and ashamed,” explained that she did not post the clip herself, and called the incident her “first and last mistake.”

“I went to Connaught Place with my friends in July,” she said. “We met a group of people who were using abusive and objectionable language against the prime minister. They influenced me and encouraged me to repeat those words, and I did.” Clearly upset, she added, “I am not able to look anyone in the eye. I appeal to the entire country and everyone to please forgive me. I am only 15 years old. This is my first

and last mistake, and I will never repeat such an act.”

The apology came after a Zero FIR was filed against her. Amit Khatri, Station House Officer at the Expressway police station in Noida, confirmed that the girl lives with her family in Faridabad. The case was first filed at the Expressway police station and then moved to the Parliament Street police station in New Delhi. “The Delhi Police will take further action,” he said.

A Zero FIR can be filed at any police station, no matter where the alleged offence happened, and is then sent to the correct jurisdiction. This process helps make sure complaints are recorded quickly. In this case, the FIR was moved to Delhi because the incident happened there. The original complaint, filed by a Ghaziabad resident on July 30, said the girl, who was first identified as living in Sector 168, Noida, used abusive and objectionable

language against the Prime Minister at Jantar Mantar on July 23. The case was registered under Sections 352 (intentional insult to provoke breach of peace), 353(1) (statements conducting to public mischief), and 356(1) (defamation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Delhi Police have also filed a separate FIR at the Special Cell Police Station about the spread of the video. They sent notices to the social media platform X to remove the content and asked for electronic records to be preserved for the investigation. Officers said they will first review the Zero FIR filed in Noida on July 29 before deciding what to do next.

Prime Minister Modi responded with his own late-night video message. He said he was hurt that both he and his late mother were subjected to “filthy abuses” at the Jantar Mantar protest. However, he urged restraint and said the “misguided chil-

dren” should be forgiven and guided in the right direction. The viral video appeared during youth-led protests organised by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) at Jantar Mantar. Thousands of student activists, along with innovative-activist Sonam Wangchuk during his 26-day hunger strike, gathered to protest alleged widespread leaks of competitive exam papers.

After intense protests, police standoffs, and a large march to Parliament on July 20, the movement led to the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. The CJP ended its protest on July 25 after the government agreed to its main demand. As Delhi Police continue to investigate, the case highlights the strong emotions in recent student protests, how quickly online content can spread, and the difficulties that come up when very young people become central to a national controversy.

## PM should adopt my daughter: mother of Noida teen

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The mother of a 15-year-old girl from Noida has made an emotional request for police protection, the withdrawal of the FIR against her daughter, and a safe place for the family to stay. She said they are getting rape and death threats online and cannot go back home or live normally. She also asked Prime Minister Narendra Modi to “adopt” her daughter.

The controversy began when a video of the teenager making objectionable remarks about the Prime Minister during a protest at Delhi’s Jantar Mantar went viral. The protest, which took place in late July over issues like the NEET paper leak, led to a Zero FIR in Noida. This was later sent to Delhi Police for investigation because the incident happened in the capital. The girl later posted apology videos. She said she had gone to Connaught Place with friends, met protesters using strong language



against Modi, and was influenced to repeat what they said.

Identifying herself as 15 years old, she called it her “first and last mistake.” She expressed deep shame and asked the whole country for forgiveness. Later, she thanked the Prime Minister, saying his response gave her a “second life” and that she would try to become a responsible citizen. He described the young people involved as “misguided children,” acknowledged the pain of hearing abusive language directed at him and even his late mother, and called on society to forgive



and guide them rather than subject them to prolonged legal action or social harassment. Mistakes made in childhood, he said, can still be corrected. Responding the next day, the girl’s mother thanked Modi for the gesture of forgiveness, describing it as “jeevandaan, a new lease of life, and noting that it coincided with her daughter’s birthday.

She asked for the FIR to be withdrawn, saying it had not been cancelled yet and that it listed her daughter’s age incorrectly. She said the family could not return to their old neighbourhood because of the backlash and

police attention. Her main request was for protection.

She spoke out against the online abuse aimed at her minor daughter and questioned how people could respond to one mistake with threats of gang rape or death. “My daughter made one mistake, but people are writing that four men should rape her. Is all this right?” she asked. She also asked for a safe place to live and said the Prime Minister should adopt her daughter. She explained that the girl’s father has died and that she and her brother deserve their share in the family home. She said she was afraid that if anything happened to the family, it could be used against Modi or his supporters.

This incident has started a wider discussion about how to protect minors, the dangers of online hate speech, and how social media can make controversies bigger. It also raises questions about how society and authorities should respond when young people make serious mistakes.

## Govt notifies compensation scheme for unnatural deaths of prison inmates

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Kin of prison inmates who die there under unnatural circumstances will be eligible for compensation up to ₹7.5 lakh under a scheme notified by the Delhi Government.

The Rekha Gupta Government has notified a compensation scheme for the next of kin or legal heirs of prisoners who suffer an unnatural death while in custody in Delhi prisons. Under the scheme, compensation ranging from ₹5 lakh to ₹7.5 lakh will be provided depending on the circumstances of each case.

According to the notification issued by the Home (General) Department of the Delhi Government, the scheme will be implemented as the Scheme for Payment of Compensation on Account of

Death of Prisoners in Delhi Prison, 2025.

It will apply only to cases involving the unnatural death of a prisoner in any Delhi prison on or after the date of notification of the scheme. Unnatural custodial death could be caused due to quarrels among inmates, beatings by prison staff, torture, negligence by prison officers, or negligence by medical or paramedical officers.

As per the notification, compensation of ₹7.5 lakh will be paid to the family of a deceased prisoner in cases where death occurs due to clashes between inmates or alleged torture or assault by prison personnel. A compensation of ₹5 lakh has been prescribed in cases involving negligence by prison authorities or staff, negligence by medical or



paramedical personnel, or suicide by a prisoner.

The notification makes it clear that no compensation will be payable in cases of natural death or death caused by illness.

It further states that deaths occurring while escaping from prison or from lawful custody, as well as deaths

caused by disasters or calamities, will not be covered under the scheme.

Under the scheme, the concerned jail superintendent will be required to submit the magisterial inquiry report, post-mortem report, final cause of death, the prisoner’s medical history, and details of the

treatment provided before death to the Director General (Prisons), Delhi, in every case.

According to Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, the scheme, notified in accordance with the guidelines of the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC), will ensure timely relief to affected families in specified cases while further strengthening administrative accountability.

The notification further provides that these cases will be reviewed by a committee headed by the Director General (Prisons). The committee will also comprise the Assistant Inspector General (Prisons), the Resident Medical Officer, the Deputy Controller (Accounts), and the Law Officer. Based on the committee’s recommendation, a proposal seeking approval of the compensation will be placed before the

administrative secretary of the department. The notification also stipulates that once the compensation has been disbursed, the concerned jail superintendent will inform the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC).

The chief minister said the Delhi Government remains fully committed to upholding the rule of law, human dignity, and constitutional values. She said that any unnatural death in custody is an extremely serious matter, and it is the Government’s responsibility to ensure transparency, accountability, and due process in such cases. She added that the government’s objective is to strengthen transparency, sensitivity, and accountability in prison administration while ensuring justice in every case in accordance with the law.

## Air pollution accelerating decay of Humayun’s Tomb: IIT study



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

A black crust formed on the sandstone of Humayun’s Tomb in Delhi by years of exposure to air pollution is accelerating the deterioration of the UNESCO World Heritage Site, a joint study of IIT Roorkee and IIT Kanpur has found.

Published in the International Journal of Architectural Heritage, the study examined black crust samples collected from different parts of Humayun’s Tomb using laboratory techniques to analyse their chemical composition, mineral content and microscopic structure.

The researchers found that the black crust is mainly made up of gypsum — a mineral formed when sulphur dioxide in polluted air reacts with calcium-rich dust and moisture, the study showed.

The gypsum layer traps soot, dust and tiny metal particles from vehicle emissions, construction activities, road dust, biomass burning and industrial pollution, gradually forming a dark coating on the sandstone, it mentioned.

The study found that the thickest black crust developed in rain-sheltered parts of the monument, where pollutants accumulate over long periods, while more exposed surfaces had comparatively thinner deposits because rain naturally washes away some of the pollutants.

According to the researchers, the black crust is more than a surface stain. The chemical reactions that form

the crust gradually weaken the sandstone, making it more vulnerable to weathering and long-term deterioration.

They said the findings provide scientific evidence linking air pollution to the deterioration of Humayun’s Tomb and could help authorities plan conservation measures for the monument.

The study recommended periodic removal of the black crust using scientifically tested conservation methods, continuous monitoring of pollution around the monument and evaluation of protective coatings before their use.

It also suggested reducing pollution at the source through cleaner transport and lower-emission fuels to slow the formation of the damaging deposits.

The researchers said the findings could help conservation agencies prioritise preventive measures and develop site-specific strategies to protect Humayun’s Tomb from further pollution-related deterioration.

Humayun’s Tomb, built in the 16th century by Empress Bega Begum in memory of Mughal emperor Humayun, is regarded as India’s first grand garden tomb.

The red sandstone and white marble monument introduced several architectural features that later influenced Mughal monuments, including the Taj Mahal.

The UNESCO World Heritage Site is one of Delhi’s best-known historical monuments and attracts visitors from across the world.

## Over 1.35 lakh women register for Delhi Laxmi Yojana: Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

More than 1.35 lakh women applied for Delhi Laxmi Yojna, a day after it was launched, the Government said on Sunday.

According to a statement, 1,35,048 registrations were completed, and 9,660 applications were finally submitted on the portal as of 8 pm on Sunday.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday launched the online portal for the scheme, under which eligible women will receive financial assistance of ₹2,500 per month.

The city Government has allocated ₹5,100 crore for the scheme.

The Delhi Cabinet, headed by Gupta, had approved the scheme earlier this week. It was one of the BJP’s key promises during the Assembly elections.

According to the scheme guidelines, women aged between 21 and 60, whose annual family income is up



**THE GOVERNMENT HAS ALLOCATED ₹5,100 CRORE FOR THE SCHEME**

to ₹2.5 lakh, are eligible to apply.

Women already receiving benefits under any other financial assistance scheme or pension, taxpayers, Government employees, women with more than three living children, families with annual electricity consumption exceeding 2,400 units, and those owning four-wheelers are not eligi-

ble under the scheme.

Families with any member in a government job will be excluded from the scheme. A woman having criminal antecedents/records will not be eligible for the money.

The applicant must secure the recommendation from the MP or the MLA of her constituency to apply for the scheme. Under the scheme, ₹1,500 of the monthly assistance will be kept in a fixed deposit with a three-year lock-in period, while beneficiaries will receive ₹1,000 directly each month.

## Delhi zoo holds reptiles, amphibians and mollusc walk

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

A reptiles, amphibians and molluscs walk was organised by the National Zoological Park (NZP) on Sunday as part of its citizen engagement and biodiversity documentation initiative.

The “Sunday Reptiles, Amphibians and Mollusc Walk” introduced participants to the ecological importance of lesser-known species found inside the zoo campus.

The walk was held from 7.30 am to 10 am under the guidance of wildlife expert Dr Surya Prakash. Nature enthusiasts, students, wildlife photographers, biodiversity researchers and volunteers participated in the programme, where they learnt to observe, identify and document different species in their natural habitats.

During the walk, participants recorded five species — slug, garden lizard, house gecko, monitor lizard and soft-shelled turtle. Prakash



explained the ecological role, behavioural adaptations and conservation significance of these species, while highlighting the importance of protecting urban biodiversity and maintaining healthy ecosystems, as per the statement.

Alongside the reptile walk, the zoo also conducted its regular “Sunday Bird Walk” under the guidance of bird expert Vijay Madan. Participants documented 42 bird species across different parts of the zoo, reflecting the rich bird diversity present within the campus, it said.

Indian spot-billed duck, Indian peafowl, grey francolin, Asian koel, red-wattled lapwing, painted stork, little cormorant, black-crowned

night heron and little egret were recorded in the survey.

Great white pelican, black kite, Indian grey hornbill, white-throated kingfisher, coppersmith barbet, Alexandrine parakeet, rose-ringed parakeet, house crow, common tailorbird, red-whiskered bulbul, Indian pied starling, common myna and oriental magpie-robin, among others were also recorded.

Addressing the participants, National Zoological Park Director Dr Sanjeet Kumar said such nature walks help strengthen field identification skills, contribute to biodiversity documentation and encourage greater appreciation for wildlife conservation.





IN FOCUS



Devotees travel in boats across the Ganga river before offering prayers at Kashi Vishwanath Temple during the month of Shravan in Varanasi

People of Punjab will give befitting reply to AAP, Congress in polls: Haryana CM Saini



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Faridkot (Punjab)

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Sunday said that in Punjab, the AAP Government and Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann are merely "entertaining people with jokes and rhetoric". Saini said the real responsibility of a Government is to work in the interest of the people, in which, he alleged, the Punjab Government has completely failed. Saini said that people from Punjab often come to meet him in Chandigarh and say that the reforms implemented by the BJP Government in Haryana should also be implemented in Punjab. Addressing an event here, Saini said that the people of Punjab have made up their mind to vote for the BJP in the Assembly elections, which are scheduled to be held early next year. According to an official statement, Saini said that the reservation quota for the DSC community is being scrapped in Punjab.

Money laundering charges forced BoB...

They also claimed that the bank failed to carry out adequate anti-money laundering (AML), know-your-customer (KYC) and due diligence checks, contributing to the continuation of the alleged fraud. "Claims are brought against Baroda [Bank of Baroda] on the basis of allegations that it acted fraudulently and without proper care in contract (under Article 246 of the Civil Code) and in tort (under Articles 282 and 285 of the Civil Code). Secondly, there are the so-called "insolvency claims", which are made by the Joint Administrators under Section 251 of the ADGM Insolvency Regulations 2022 (the "IR 2022") in fraudulent trading against Dr Shetty, Mr Manghat and Baroda, and under Section 252 of the IR 2022 in wrongful trading against Dr Shetty and Mr Manghat. For present purposes, it is the civil claims which are relevant: it is common ground that they are all UAE law governed. The insolvency claims are governed by ADGM law," said the judgment of Justice Sir Andrew Smith of Abu Dhabi Global Market (ADGM) Court of First Instance Commercial and Civil Division, dated March 25, 2025. This judgment's number was quoted by the BoB to Stock Exchanges without explaining why it paid public money of ₹5,700 crore as settlement. According to many top bankers and senior officials in the Union Ministry of Finance, this order of the Abu Dhabi court indicting BoB for violation of anti-money laundering norms, fraudulent activities and connivance with NMC Healthcare, led to the arbitration and finally led to settlement to creditors of the debt sunken NRI businessman BR Shetty's firms by the bank paying ₹5,700 crore. BoB has not yet declared how much money it lend to NMC Health Care till 2020. As per another ADGM court order dated September 27, 2020, BoB filed case against NMC Healthcare and its associates to recover their loan dues. However, the bank turned up as a co-accused along with promoters Shetty and Manghat for cheating creditors. Interestingly State Bank of India (SBI) and ICICI Bank and many other foreign banks filed case against the promoters to recover the loans. In October 2025, the SBI was lucky to recover \$46 million (around ₹405 crore) from

₹18 cr stolen annually from Siddhivinayak, alleges Raj

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) president Raj Thackeray has claimed that donations of ₹18 crore were being siphoned off every year at the famous Siddhivinayak Temple in Mumbai. He also alleged that ₹1,400 crore had been stolen at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya. Even temples are not safe these days, Thackeray said and demanded that Prime Minister Narendra Modi speak on this issue. The MNS chief was speaking at a programme organised by his party's student wing on Saturday. Frustrated youths visit temples, but even temples



are not safe from corruption, he said. Some employees who stole money from the donation box at the Siddhivinayak Temple were caught due to the alertness of the trustees, Thackeray said, reading out

a letter written by eight trustees to Maharashtra Deputy Chief Minister Eknath Shinde. The temple's weekly earnings from donations were less than ₹50 lakh before this theft was caught, and after-

wards the collection rose to ₹1.5 crore, he said. "Every year, ₹18 crore was being stolen," Thackeray alleged. Sada Sarvankar, chairman of the Siddhivinayak Temple Trust and a leader of the Shiv Sena led by Eknath Shinde, said that nine employees were arrested in this connection. "We have filed cases wherever required," he told reporters. The rise in donations was due to the efforts taken by the trust, Sarvankar said, adding that the temple's income has increased from ₹114 crore two years ago to ₹182 crore. Notably, police have arrested multiple accused in the case of alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple and the investigation is underway.

Yogi asks Govt, Opposition to raise public issues in House

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Lucknow

Ahead of the Monsoon Session of the state legislature, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday urged representatives from both the ruling party and the opposition to raise every issue concerning public interest in the House. He called on them to engage in healthy, constructive discussions and support the Government in accelerating the state's development, appealing to Opposition parties to ensure



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, Assembly Speaker Satish Mahana, and others, chair an all-party meeting ahead of the upcoming Monsoon Session of the State Assembly at Vidhan Bhawan in Lucknow, Uttar Pradesh on Sunday

the smooth functioning of the House. On Sunday, the UP Government stated that Adityanath addressed an all-party meeting chaired by UP Legislative Assembly Speaker Satish Mahana at the Vidhan Bhawan. The meeting was convened to discuss the conduct of the Monsoon Session of the Uttar Pradesh Legislature, which begins on Monday. Addressing the meeting as the Leader of the House, Adityanath said, "The Monsoon Session should witness constructive discus-

sions on issues concerning the common people. Such deliberations, he said, contribute to the state's development and help resolve public grievances." Mahana also sought the cooperation of all members for the smooth conduct of the House. On July 21, the Uttar Pradesh Cabinet approved convening the State legislature's third session of 2026 starting August 3. During this session, they will address the supplementary budget for the 2026-27 financial year and other legislative business.

BSP expels Ashok Siddarth, Randhir Singh Beniwal for indiscipline

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Lucknow

BSP president Mayawati on Sunday announced the expulsion of former Rajya Sabha member Ashok Siddarth and party coordinator Randhir Singh Beniwal from the party for repeated "indiscipline" and "violation" of organisational directives. In a post on X, Mayawati said Siddarth, who is the father-in-law of her nephew Akash Anand, had earlier been expelled over "indiscipline" during the Maharashtra Assembly elections, particularly over the issue of coordination with the party's State unit in



ticket distribution. He was later reinducted after he assured the leadership that such lapses would not be repeated, she said. According to Mayawati, Siddarth was thereafter assigned responsibilities

only in states outside Uttar Pradesh to strengthen the party's organisational base. However, the former chief minister alleged that complaints of indiscipline and violation of party directions continued to emerge from Kamataka, Odisha and West Bengal despite repeated warnings. She said Siddarth had been relieved of all party responsibilities on Saturday, but reports about his possible return to Uttar Pradesh were being spread deliberately to create confusion within the organisation and disrupt the BSP's campaign for the next Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections.

Punjab BJP chief Dhillon announces new office bearers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Chandigarh

Punjab BJP chief Kewal Singh Dhillon on Sunday announced the appointment of new office bearers for the State unit, saying it is aimed at further strengthening the party's organisational structure in the State. The appointments were announced following the approval of BJP national president Nitin Nabin. The party announced 12 state vice presidents — Surjit Kumar Jyani (Fazilka), Rakesh Rathour (Jalandhar), Subhash Sharma (SAS Nagar), Manjit Singh Rai (Ferozepur), Ashwani Sekhri (Batala), Sushil Rinku (Jalandhar), Geja Ram Valmiki (Fatehgarh Sahib), Tejinder Singh Bittu

(Jalandhar), Jasmine Sandhawalia (Kapurthala), Jatinder Mittal (Ludhiana), Ravi Karan Singh Kahlon (Gurdaspur) and Ranjit Singh Gill (Mohali). Five State general secretaries — Anil Sarin, Rajesh Bagha, Parminder Singh Brar, Rajnish Dhiman and Jiwana Garg — have been appointed. Dhillon also announced the appointment of 12 State secretaries. Prominent among them are Manjit Singh Manna, Mangat Rai Bansa, Rakesh Sharma, Suraj Bhardwaj, Vandana Sangwal, Meenu Sethi, Ranjam Kamra, Charanjeet Singh Brar, Kamalpreet Kaur Chaudhary and Meena Tarnaich. The party appointed Anuj Khosla as Yuva Morcha president and Jai Inder Kaur as



Mahila Morcha president. Kaur is the daughter of former chief minister Amarinder Singh. Lakhwinder Singh has been appointed Kisan Morcha president, Sheetal

Angural will be heading the SC Morcha and Shivrak Chudhary has been given charge of the OBC Morcha. Party leader SS Channi is Punjab BJP's new chief spokesperson and Vineet Joshi has been appointed the state unit media head. Pritpal Singh Baliawal and Pampal Kaur Sidhu have been appointed as state media co-incharges. The party also appointed state cell coordinators, State IT convener and State treasurer. Dhillon expressed confidence that the new team would work with dedication, discipline and commitment to further strengthen the BJP across Punjab. The Punjab assembly elections are due early next year.

FROM PAGE - 1

BR Shetty by revoking his personal guarantee. As per media reports, In October, a Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC) court ordered Shetty to pay \$46 million to SBI after finding he repeatedly lied under oath about signing a personal guarantee for a \$50 million loan. Shetty, however, has maintained he was the victim of a fraud by former executives like Prasanth Manghat. However, all the three Indian banks — Bank of Baroda and SBI and ICICI Bank — never made mandatory statement about the loan dues or about the recovery cases with NMC Healthcare to Indian authorities like Reserve Bank of India or in their monthly statements to the credit rating agencies like TransUnion CIBIL. Here the big question hangs fire is why Government of India allowed Bank of Baroda to pay public money of ₹5,700 crore as settlement in Abu Dhabi based NMC Healthcare's insolvency case. Will Union Ministry of Finance order a probe on BoB for dealing with Abu Dhabi based BR Shetty's NMC Healthcare, which resulted a huge loss of public money? Surely, this is a fit case to investigate the role of the bank's management and board of directors for criminal trespass, the scope of investigation can cover the role of entity putting external pressure on the banks management to settle the matter inappropriately leading to the enormous loss of capital and reputation for the bank.

TN CM Vijay defers Bengaluru visit amid...

"I have great respect for him. Though he may be new to politics, he is a courageous leader. I congratulated him on his bold decision. Whatever our political differences may be, he wanted to come to Karnataka. I only requested that we meet in a better and more cordial atmosphere because I don't want anyone shouting against my friends. We should respect each other. We have to live together and work together. Ultimately, India is one," Shivakumar told reporters after chairing an all-party meeting on Cauvery row. Shivakumar had on Friday appealed to his Tamil Nadu counterpart to defer his August 3 visit to Bengaluru in view of the charged atmosphere in the State following the Cauvery Water Management Authority's decision upholding the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's direction

to Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs of water to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. His appeal had come amid widespread protests across Kamataka, particularly in Mandya, where demonstrators tore posters of Vijay's recently released film Jananayagan and forced theatres at some places to halt its screening. Shivakumar had said the State Government had initially prepared to host the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister for talks but had decided to seek a postponement to ensure the meeting takes place in a peaceful atmosphere after consultations with his Cabinet colleagues and legal team. PM unveils anti-drug campaign "Family members live with this pain every day, watching their children gradually lose themselves before their eyes," he said. Questioning the taboo around drug addicts, PM Modi said those who come out of drug addiction are fighters and should be honoured by society. "Society should respect them, embrace them and give them a second chance," he said. The PM launched the campaign virtually in the presence of a large number of youth, who described themselves as representatives of Gen-Z, days after large-scale protests by students demanding reforms in the public examination system rocked Delhi and other parts of the country. The PM also said the Government stands firmly with the youth in this campaign against drugs. "Strict action is being taken against drug traffickers across the country. The arrests have gone up several times as compared to before, and drugs worth thousands of crores of rupees have been seized. This shows how strongly our Government is acting against drugs," the PM said. He also urged families not to hide their children's addiction out of concern for social reputation, and instead communicate openly with them and seek expert and medical help to help them overcome substance abuse. The launch marked the beginning of a 100-week nationwide Jan Bhagidari campaign, under which activities will be organised every Sunday across the country to promote awareness and encourage public participation in building a drug-free society. The activities will include sports events, walkathons, meditation sessions, cultural pro-

grammes, awareness campaigns, nukkad nataks, discussion forums, art competitions and community engagement programmes.

Taslima backs UCC, targets madrasas

Madrasas should be converted to secular schools with modern thoughts," She also alleged that madarsa-manufactured fundamentalists played a major role in the ouster of Awami League Government in that country. Madrasas were a threat to secular, democratic ideas and freedom of speech and expression in south Asia, she said. "Considering the present situation there is hardly any scope of a secular democratic fabric returning in Bangladesh because Awami League is banned, the Opposition space is occupied by hardline Jamaat i Islami — which wants to implement sharia laws," she said "Today standing in 21st century if you try to implement 7th century laws how can a modern country flourish? So, there is hardly any scope for Bangladesh to move forward in the present circumstances," she added. On former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasima and banning of her party she said, "The way she had to leave the country is not acceptable. Awami League should not have been banned."

Security call for West Bengal CM Suvendu

Earlier, State ministers Arjun Singh and Umesh Rai too demanded upgradation of Adhikari's security. Incidentally the terror mole had been tasked with getting Rai's son abducted through Arpita a honey trap. Hamim Mondal was arrested from Renaissance township in East Burdwan. Later his associate, Arpita Sarkar was picked up from Sahibganj in Jharkhand. Police found data tracking the travel schedules and security movement patterns of CM Adhikari on the suspects' devices. The police later found that he was taking instructions from his handlers in Pakistan. He is also suspected to have Jaish links and was tasked with procuring police uniforms to infiltrate the Jantar Mantar gathering of Cockroach Janata Party late last month, Garav Sharma IG STF said.

IAF ends combat exercise at Pokhran

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Jaisalmer

The Indian Air Force (IAF) on Sunday concluded its week-long exercise at the Pokhran Field Firing Range, showcasing its combat readiness and counter-drone warfare capabilities, officials said. According to defence sources in Rajasthan, the exercise, Rotor Clapp-III, was conducted on the theme of



'Counter Unmanned Aerial Systems (Counter-UAS)'. Multiple helicopter units of the IAF took part in it. The primary objective of the drill was to test operational concepts against emerging aerial threats and strengthen combat preparedness in an evolving battlefield environment, sources said. The exercise focused on enhancing the operational capabilities of the IAF's helicopter fleet to counter growing threats posed by unmanned aerial systems (UAS). It also assessed strategies, techniques and procedures for integrated helicopter operations under simulated real combat conditions. Almost all major heli-

copter platforms of the IAF participated and demonstrated their combat capabilities through a series of tactical missions. These included precision strikes, battlefield support, reconnaissance, troop insertion, casualty evacuation and coordinated operations to counter both aerial and ground-based threats, sources said. The drill provided aircrew and operational units an opportunity to test and validate mission planning, inter-unit coordination, rapid response and joint functioning under near-war conditions. Special emphasis was laid on ensuring seamless coordination between different helicopter platforms in the challenging desert terrain, they said. The Pokhran Field Firing Range, one of India's major military training areas, provided an ideal environment for conducting live operational exercises. The conclusion of Rotor Clapp-III reaffirms the Indian Air Force's commitment to maintaining a high level of operational readiness and adapting to emerging security challenges, the sources said.

Fuel consumption rises on weak monsoon

Month-on-month, sales in July remain lower because in June holiday travel picks up due to school and college holidays. Jet fuel (ATF) sales inched up by 2.9 per cent to 659,900 tonnes during July — volumes that were 2.3 per cent more than the consumption of 641,300 tonnes in July 2024 and 16.5 per cent more than 566,600 tonnes of July 2023. Month-on-month, the consumption fell 4.6 per cent from 691,700 tonnes of June. Liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) sales continued to fall, dropping 17.4 per cent to 2.37 million tonnes. Industry officials said this was largely because some volumes have shifted to piped natural gas since the West Asia crisis. LPG sales have been declining since the onset of the West Asia crisis disrupted supplies, leading to the imposition of consumption restrictions in sectors like hotels and restaurants. The curbs were lifted last month, and sales saw an 8.6 per cent rise to 2.18 million tonnes consumed in June but were lower year-on-year as some industrial and commercial users are now using piped natural gas for their needs, they said. The July LPG consumption was 13.3 per cent lower than 2.73 million tonnes of July 2024 and 1.1 per cent lower than 2.39 million tonnes of July 2023.

Shoe hurled at Pappu Yadav; knife claim...

He mentioned ongoing social media threats, including offers of ₹51 lakh to harm him, and said the accused was overpowered and handed to police. "There was a plot to kill me, but I survived," Yadav added, saying he would not be intimidated. The press conference happened while Yadav was facing criticism for his recent protest outside Parliament. He had dressed as a sadhu in saffron robes in a street play to draw attention to embezzlement of donations at the Ram temple, which drew outrage from VHP and other organisations. Police ensured the MP's safety and arrested the suspect. Officers are now reviewing video from the press conference and investigating the claims about the knife. Yadav's team criticised the security, saying only a few officers were present despite earlier warnings about threats. Police are still investigating to find out what happened and why.



GRAPEVINE

Chanakya's August 5

August 5 and the ensuing Monsoon Session has once again triggered speculation as to what special or a major announcement may be on platter for the nation. Retrospectively, the landmark abrogation of Article 370 in 2019 and the historic Ram Mandir foundation laying ceremony in 2020 were done on same date hence grapevine has it the Modi Government is preparing to introduce a major Bill in Parliament on August 5. While details regarding the content remains a secret, speculation ranges from comprehensive governance overhauls and key socio-economic reforms to significant legal updates. The chances of one transformative One Nation One Election which top on agenda has now been deferred to Winter Session. A tight lipped BJP camp however is guessing that Home Minister Amit Shah, key strategist and christened as Chanakya, must be having some surprises stored which only he would know and not even his entire concerned department except top couple of officers.



Why doesn't Cabinet Secretary want an extension?

Bureaucracy is abuzz with rumours why Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan avoids extension of service. For time immemorial, Cabinet Secretaries get extensions after extensions as they are close in working with Prime Ministers. Somanathan is so preferred by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and would be asked to continue, says many top officials. According to them, recently in a get-together Swaminathan is believed to have spoke against extension culture which spoils chance of others. Many believe PM will insist the Cabinet Secretary to continue.



8 dead, 13 injured, 8 missing following rains: Kerala CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
Thiruvananthapuram

Kerala Chief Minister VD Satheesan on Sunday said that eight people have died, an equal number are missing and 13 were injured in the previous day's heavy rains which caused property damage, landslides and waterlogging in many parts of the State.

In a statement issued by his office, Satheesan also said that 27 houses were completely destroyed, 196 homes were partially damaged and 5,792 people have been shifted to the 209 relief camps set up across the State.

The Government will ensure assistance to the families of the deceased and those who have lost their homes and livelihoods, he further said. The CM said that despite the reduction in rainfall since the previous day, people should be vigilant, especially in the hilly areas. He also said that people's representatives and volunteers were actively involved in relief efforts.

Satheesan further said that he was communicating with Revenue Minister AP Anilkumar and other ministers



Search operation underway for a man swept away in the Kanjirappuzha river in Kannur, Kerala on Sunday

assigned to various districts as well as the local administrations in connection with rain-related relief efforts.

The CM said that the subsid-ing or reduction in rainfall in many parts of the State was a relief and cleaning activities have started in the areas that were flooded or waterlogged.

He urged workers and activists of political parties and voluntary organisations to participate in the cleaning activities and assured all support of the Government for the same.

Anilkumar, while speaking to reporters here, also said that following the heavy rains the previous day which caused widespread damage

Shivakumar leads all-party meet on Cauvery

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Sunday asserted that his Government was committed to protecting the interests of the State's farmers and people on the Cauvery issue, while appealing to organisations to withdraw the proposed State-wide bandh.

He also said Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay has agreed to postpone his visit to Bengaluru following a request from the Karnataka Government in view of the prevailing Cauvery water dispute, describing the gesture as one that would help maintain a cordial atmosphere between the two States.

The two leaders were supposed to meet on Monday to discuss the Cauvery issue but Shivakumar had appealed to Vijay to defer his visit so as to hold talks in a more conducive atmosphere, as protests were happening across the State over the inter-State dispute earlier this week. Pro-Kannada organisations have

given a call for Karnataka Bandh on August 13 against the Cauvery Water Management Authority's order on Thursday upholding the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's order on releasing 3,500 cusecs of water for 15 days to Tamil Nadu.

Addressing reporters on Sunday after chairing an all-party meet on Cauvery, Shivakumar said there was no need for protests as rainfall had improved the situation and all political parties had extended support and such a bandh would not benefit anyone.

The CM said the Government would continue to take decisions within the legal framework, prioritise drinking water needs, consult legal and agricultural experts, and closely monitor the evolving water situation before taking any further steps.

"Our Government remains fully committed to protecting the interests of Karnataka's farmers on the Cauvery issue," he said. Stating that he too hailed from the Cauvery basin and was a farmer's son, Shivakumar said there should be no



Karnataka CM DK Shivakumar, former chief minister Siddaramaiah, and others during an all-party meeting to chalk out the State's legal and political strategy on the Cauvery water-sharing dispute with Tamil Nadu, following the CWRG's direction to release 3,500 cusecs of water daily for 15 days in Bengaluru on Sunday

doubt among the State's 7.5 crore people about the Government's commitment to safeguarding Karnataka's interests.

To a query, he said the Government would decide its future course after consulting its legal team on proceedings before the Supreme Court. Referring to Tamil Nadu's main opposition party DMK approaching the apex court, the CM

said Karnataka would respond through the legal process. "We must proceed very carefully while dealing with court proceedings, drawing upon the experience of senior legal experts," Shivakumar explained.

He also reiterated that the Mekedatu project should move forward, noting that the Supreme Court has already delivered its judgment on the issue. The project is about

constructing a balancing reservoir across river Cauvery at Mekedatu in the State and Tamil Nadu is opposed to it saying its interests would be harmed if the dam took shape.

Karnataka had received only about 30 to 35 per cent of normal rainfall so far and continued to remain under the shadow of drought, prompting the Government to advise farmers to remain patient until scientific guidance was issued, he said. The chief minister said the CWRG and CWMA had directed Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs of water for 15 days, while Tamil Nadu had sought 9 TMC of water.

Sharing the latest reservoir position, Shivakumar said Kabini was receiving an inflow of 24,000 cusecs, KRS 22,000 cusecs, Hemavathi 11,884 cusecs and Harangi 10,430 cusecs, taking the total inflow to around 67,178 cusecs. He stressed that Karnataka must reserve 40 TMC of water for drinking purposes, with at least 36 TMC being essential and another four TMC kept as contingency.

BJP, JD(S) caution Karnataka Govt against complacency over Cauvery rains

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
Bengaluru

Opposition BJP and the JD(S) on Sunday urged the Karnataka Government to vigorously defend the State's interests before the Supreme Court, prioritise farmers over reservoir storage after the recent rains, and provide immediate compensation to cultivators who suffered crop losses due to water scarcity.



At the all-party meeting on the Cauvery water-sharing issue convened by Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, Union Minister HD Kumaraswamy and BJP MP Basavaraj Bommai said the recent rainfall should not be seen as a permanent solution to the dispute.

They called for better water management and protection of Karnataka's drinking water and irrigation interests.

"We should not become complacent just because the rains have filled the reservoirs. Water should first be supplied to farmers, and the Government must immediately announce fair compensation for farmers who have suffered crop losses," Kumaraswamy said.

Addressing the all-party meeting, Kumaraswamy, who is the JD(S) second-in-command, said the rainfall had brought only temporary

relief, and the Government should remain vigilant.

"It is true that the rains have come to our rescue. But we should not lower our guard in the coming days. Along with ensuring drinking water, it is the Government's responsibility to provide water to farmers. We should not behave as though we have escaped the crisis simply because it has rained," he said.

Sheikh Hasina to make first public appearance in 2 years in New Delhi

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Ousted Bangladeshi Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina will make her first public appearance in nearly two years on Wednesday, addressing a media event in New Delhi as she prepares for a dramatic return to Bangladesh in December.

Hasina, who has been living in India since her Government was toppled by a student-led uprising in August 2024, is scheduled to speak at a programme organised by the Foreign Correspondents' Club of South Asia (FCC South Asia).

The event, set for August 5 from 6 PM to 7.30 PM at the Sir Mark Tully Auditorium on Mathura Road, will be live-streamed on the club's social media platforms.

The former Prime Minister is expected to outline her future plans during the interaction. Joining her on the occasion will be a prominent group of Bangladeshi figures, including her son and former ICT Adviser Sajeeb Wazed Joy, ex-Education Minister Mohibul



Hasan Chowdhury Nowfel, former cricketer and ex-MP Shakib Al Hasan, diplomat Aminul Hoque Polish, counterterrorism analyst Abu Obaidha Arin, and human rights advocates Mahammad Ali Siddique and Shah Md Bakhtiar.

The session will be chaired by Dr Waiel Awwad, President of FCC South Asia and the International Association of Press Clubs.

The timing of the event coincides with the second anniversary of the 2024 protests that ended Hasina's long political dominance. She faces a death sentence in

Bangladesh over allegations related to the crackdown on the student movement.

In a recent interview with Reuters, Hasina declared her intention to return to Dhaka in December and surrender to authorities. Facing the possibility of arrest or worse, the 78-year-old leader said she remains determined to go back.

"They may arrest me on my return, they may even kill me. Still, I have to go," Hasina was quoted as saying. "My party leaders and workers are being subjected to tremendous repression. If death comes, I want it to come on

my own soil, where my parents are buried and where their blood was shed." She added that several Awami League leaders and workers plan to return with her.

Hasina's potential homecoming is likely to intensify political tensions in Bangladesh, where the interim Government is still working to restore stability following two years of upheaval.

It could also test relations with India, which has faced repeated demands from Dhaka for her extradition.

In April this year, India's Ministry of External Affairs stated that it was examining Bangladesh's extradition request while expressing its desire to strengthen bilateral ties with the new administration in Dhaka.

Hasina has maintained a low profile since arriving in India, avoiding public events and formal media engagements until now.

Her appearance on Wednesday is being closely watched as a significant political statement ahead of her planned return.

India making big strides in manufacturing, innovation, green energy: Kishan Reddy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
Hyderabad

India is making significant strides in manufacturing, innovation, green energy and sustainable mobility under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Minister G Kishan Reddy said on Sunday.

Unveiling Telangana-based KETO Motors' "first commercial electric bus", Reddy said in a post on X that the launch reflected the growing strength of India's indigenous manufacturing capabilities and the country's



commitment to building an Aatmanirbhar Bharat.

"The launch of KETO

Motors' first commercial electric bus reflects the growing strength of India's indige-

nous manufacturing capabilities and our commitment to building an Aatmanirbhar Bharat," the union minister for Coal and Mines said.

According to Reddy, electric mobility is not merely an alternative to conventional transport. It is also key to enhancing India's energy security, reducing pollution, lowering dependence on fuel imports and promoting technological self-reliance.

He said the Central Government remained committed to strengthening the entire EV ecosystem, from manufacturing vehicles and batteries to expanding charg-

ing infrastructure, research and skill development.

Reddy said Telangana-based enterprises were making a valuable contribution to the country's electric mobility drive by developing indigenous solutions that strengthen public transport, generate employment and promote sustainable economic growth.

The launch of KETO Motors' "first commercial electric bus" marked a major milestone for the company and highlighted the growing strength of India's commercial EV ecosystem, he added.

40,000 registrations in 2 hours as advance safari booking opens in Ranthambore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
Jaipur

Advance safari bookings for the upcoming tourism season at Ranthambore Tiger Reserve witnessed an overwhelming response from domestic and foreign tourists, with nearly 40,000 registrations within two hours of its opening, officials said on Sunday.

According to the Ranthambore administration, the booking window for safaris scheduled between October 1 and December 31 this year opened at 12 noon on August 1. Within two hours, around 40,000 tourists registered. Of this, around 14,000 were foreign visitors. Officials said a large number of users accessed the official portal simultaneously, leading to a sharp surge in traffic. However, the portal — along with verification, booking processes and live reporting systems — functioned smoothly even during peak hours.

According to the Deputy Conservator of Forests, Ranthambore, Manas Singh, a key feature of the new system was that seats remained available across various safari options even two hours after the bookings opened. "Seats



were still available for several dates, including peak periods such as Diwali and Christmas holidays. Real-time seat availability on the portal enabled tourists to choose dates and safari options conveniently, making the process more transparent and user-friendly," he said.

Despite heavy digital traffic, multiple cyber attack attempts and unauthorised activities were detected and successfully blocked by the system, he said.

"During the booking process, around 20 lakh suspicious cyber attack attempts, over 150 suspicious IP addresses and more than two crore fake requests were blocked. Despite this, the portal functioned normally throughout," Singh said.

For the first time, foreign tourists were allowed to

directly book safaris from their respective countries through the official portal, he said, adding that the move showed encouraging results on the very first day.

Foreign tourists accounted for nearly 40 per cent of the total bookings, with around 200 of them logging in independently to complete bookings. Online bookings were recorded from countries including the United States, the United Kingdom, Australia and the Netherlands.

The Ranthambore administration said the new digital system aims to make the booking process more transparent, simple and equitable for all tourists. It expressed hope that the initiative would provide a smoother, safer and more efficient booking experience during the upcoming tourism season.

Anti-drug drive to continue until Punjab becomes free from menace: Mann

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
Ludhiana

Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday asserted that his Government's anti-drug campaign — 'Yudh Nashean Virudh' — will continue until the menace is eliminated from the State.

During a meeting with Village Defence Committee (VDC) volunteers, he said the campaign has completed 500 days during which 70,000 drug smugglers have been arrested, while 1.25 lakh volunteers

across 13,000 villages have emerged as the backbone of the movement. The AAP Government has broken the backbone of drug trade through strict action against smugglers, treatment and rehabilitation of victims, and an unprecedented public awareness campaign, Mann said.

He said Punjab, once branded as 'Udta Punjab', is now transforming into 'Padhta Te Tandrust Punjab' (educated and healthy Punjab), as reflected in the State's top ranking in school education, record JEE and



NEET success and merit-based employment.

He reiterated that the fight against drugs will continue until Punjab becomes com-

pletely free from drugs.

Addressing the gathering, Mann said Yudh Nashean Virudh has completed 500 days and "our Village

Defence Committees have completed one year".

"I thank the people of Punjab for turning both these initiatives into a people's movement. The day is not far when together these two movements will completely eradicate the menace of drugs from Punjab," he said.

The chief minister said he is indebted to all those serving Punjab in the true spirit and added that their determination proves that any challenge, however big, can be overcome with collective resolve.



# Indian envoy accuses Pakistan of dismantling IWT over decades

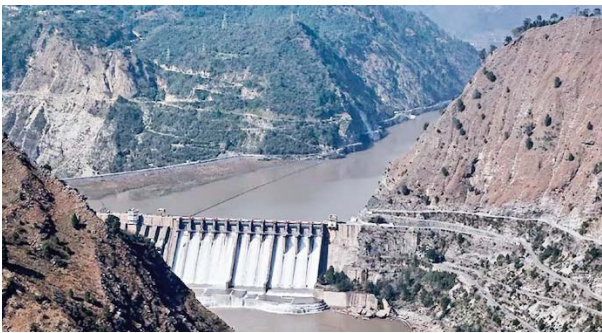
ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India's Ambassador to the United States, Vinay Mohan Kwatra, has strongly defended New Delhi's decision to place the Indus Water Treaty (IWT) in abeyance, stating that Pakistan systematically destroyed the spirit of the 1960 agreement through persistent hostility and terrorism.

In an article published in Newsweek, Kwatra asserted that the treaty was signed "in a spirit of goodwill and friendship," but Pakistan spent the next half-century dismantling that very goodwill. "The abeyance merely acknowledges what Pakistan's conduct had already destroyed," he wrote.

Kwatra's remarks came days after Pakistan hosted an international conference protesting India's move to suspend the treaty on April 23, 2025 — one day after a Pakistan-trained terrorist attack in Pahalgam, Jammu and Kashmir, killed 26 people, most of them tourists.

The Indus Waters Treaty, brokered by the World Bank



and signed in 1960, allocated three eastern rivers (Ravi, Beas, and Sutlej) to India, which carry roughly 20 per cent of the basin's water, while granting Pakistan rights over the three western rivers (Indus, Jhelum, and Chenab), carrying about 80 per cent.

Despite this significant asymmetry that limited development in its own northern regions for decades, India continued to honour the treaty, Kwatra noted. In contrast, Pakistan responded with wars in 1965, 1971, and 1999, along with repeated cross-border terrorism, including the 2001 Parliament attack, the 2008 Mumbai

attacks, the 2016 Uri and Pathankot strikes, the 2019 Pulwama attack, and the 2025 Pahalgam incident.

The envoy highlighted Pakistan's pattern of obstruction, including bureaucratic delays on India-initiated projects and consistent blocking of efforts to renegotiate the treaty to account for six decades of technological advancements and India's hydropower needs.

"Bit by bit, Pakistan eroded India's faith that it could exercise its rights under the treaty, or hope for a better one suited to today's realities," Kwatra wrote. He emphasised that if Pakistan genuinely seeks

cooperation on bilateral issues, it must first dismantle the terror infrastructure it has nurtured for years.

Addressing calls for renewed dialogue between the two nations, Kwatra criticised advocates for ignoring historical failures. "They must believe that doing the same thing over and over again and expecting different results is not insanity," he said.

Quoting Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the envoy reiterated India's firm position: "Terror and talks cannot go together... Terror and trade cannot go together... Water and blood cannot flow together."

Kwatra also pointed out that Pakistan's current water scarcity stems primarily from domestic mismanagement. He urged Islamabad to focus on improving its "dismal water productivity" rather than organising conferences to blame India and issue threats.

"The habit of pinning every domestic failure on India has grown old. The world should say so, unequivocally," he concluded.

## Om Birla stresses collective duty for dignified life for all

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Kota (Rajasthan)

Lok Sabha Speaker and Kota-Bundi MP Om Birla on Sunday said that society has a collective responsibility to ensure a dignified life for every individual and called for utilising the experience of retired officers to prepare long-term plans for community welfare.

Addressing an event organised here by the Retired Officers Association to felicitate him on completing seven years as the Lok Sabha Speaker, Birla lauded the association's social initiatives and said the expertise of retired officers should be utilised for community welfare.

During the event, the members of the association welcomed him with a traditional Rajasthani turban and floral garlands in recognition of his service.

The programme, during which umbrellas were distributed among the needy, was attended by retired Government officers, among others. "It is our collective responsibility to ensure that every individual



in society leads a dignified life. Given your vast experience across various sectors, we must work together to create comprehensive, long-term plans so that the benefits reach the last person in society," Birla said.

Speaking to the media after the event, Birla congratulated Kota-born boxer Arundhati Choudhary for clinching gold in the women's 70kg category at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow on Saturday, lauding her hard work and dedication.

He also said that state-of-the-art sports facilities would be established in Kota to help youngsters compete at national and international events, including world championships and the Olympic Games.

## Nation Focus



### PM MODI PAYS TRIBUTE TO PINGALI VENKAYYA ON BIRTH ANNIVERSARY

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday paid tributes to Pingali Venkayya on his 150th birth anniversary and remembered his invaluable role in giving the country its national flag.

A freedom fighter, Venkayya is known for designing the initial version of the national flag. He was a lecturer, author, geologist and educationalist. In a social media post, the prime minister said Venkayya is remembered for his "invaluable role in giving our nation the Tricolour".

"May his efforts always inspire people to serve our country with dedication and patriotic fervour," Modi said. "The Tiranga fills every Indian heart with immense pride and inspires us to work towards nation building," he said. (PTI)



### FOURTH EDITION OF TRI-SERVICE FUTURE WARFARE COURSE TO BEGIN

The fourth edition of the tri-service future warfare course, which covers a wide range of subjects, including geopolitical developments, artificial intelligence, quantum technologies, and cyber and cognitive warfare is set to begin from August 3.

The four-week course is being conducted under the aegis of the Headquarters Integrated Defence Staff (HQ IDS) and coordinated by the Centre for Joint Warfare Studies (CENJOWS). The fourth edition of the course will commence at Manekshaw Centre here, officials said on Sunday.

The course brings together officers from the three Services, along with representatives from Government organisations, academia, industry and strategic think-tanks. (PTI)

## Govt released over ₹3,200 crore for Punjab's education: Bittu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Chandigarh

Senior BJP leader Ravneet Singh Bittu on Sunday said despite the Centre releasing ₹3,205 crore to Punjab under major education schemes during the last four financial years, the AAP Government is turning school inaugurations into political advertisements.

His statement came on a day when Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann inaugurated two new 'Schools of Eminence' in Ludhiana.

The former union minister said the Centre has consis-

tently supported Punjab through flagship programmes such as Samagra Shiksha, PM SHRI Schools, PM POSHAN, ULLAS, and PM-USHA (formerly RUSA).

Pointing out that Samagra Shiksha alone has received more than ₹2,200 crore during this period, Bittu said these schemes provide financial assistance for school infrastructure, laboratories, digital education, teacher training, students' nutrition, and strengthening the overall education ecosystem.

"The issue is not who cuts the ribbon. The issue is who provided the resources. The



Modi Government has invested thousands of crores in Punjab's education, while the AAP Government is trying to

convert every inauguration into a political advertisement," said Bittu.

When substantial Central

assistance has been continuously flowing to Punjab, every educational facility inaugurated by the Punjab Government should not be portrayed as a sole achievement of the state government, Bittu said. "The chief minister has every right to inaugurate schools, but he has no right to erase the contribution of the taxpayers of India and the Modi government. The people deserve transparency, not political branding," he said.

Without discrimination, Bittu said the Modi Government has continued to release funds under Centrally sponsored schemes

despite repeated political attacks by the AAP government.

Questioning the Punjab government's reluctance to acknowledge the Centre's financial contribution to education, Bittu asked how much of the infrastructure being showcased on Sunday has benefited from assistance available under the central schemes?

The BJP welcomes every new school, every classroom, and every educational investment because it benefits Punjab's children. However, public money should never become a tool for political

## Rajasthan CM launches 340 projects worth ₹491 crore in Rajsamand



Rajasthan CM Bhajanlal Sharma with residents during a morning walk in Bida Gram Panchayat of Udaipur district on Sunday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Jaipur

Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Sunday inaugurated and laid the foundation stones of 347 development projects worth over ₹491 crore in Rajsamand district, saying his Government is working towards the vision of 'Viksit Bharat' and 'Viksit Rajasthan-2047' under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Addressing a public function at Bhikshu Nilayam in Rajsamand, Sharma also said the Government remains committed to the welfare of farmers, women, labourers and youth.

Asserting that the state Government has taken strict action against exam irregularities, he said 410 examinations have been conducted without leaks in the past two-and-a-half years.

According to an official statement, the projects include 266 works worth over ₹369 crore which were inaugurated and 81 works (total

cost ₹122 crore) for which foundation stones were laid.

Sharma said the development initiatives would add a "new chapter" to the growth story of the region known for its cultural and historical significance, including association with Shrinathji and Maharana Pratap.

Highlighting measures for farmers, the chief minister said the annual assistance under the Kisan Samman Nidhi has been increased from ₹6,000 to ₹9,000, while electricity subsidies exceeding ₹61,000 crore have been provided. He added that under the PM Kusum scheme, farmers are emerging as energy producers.

He said livestock owners are being provided interest-free loans up to ₹1 lakh under the Gopal Credit Card scheme, along with a subsidy of ₹5 per litre on milk. Over 23 lakh insurance policies have been issued under the Chief Minister Mangla Pashu Bima Yojana, Sharma said, urging farmers to adopt natural and advanced farming practices.

## PM speaks of forgiving students; Govt owes them justice, apology: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Sunday said Prime Minister Narendra Modi speaks of "forgiving" students, but it is the Government that owes the students truth, justice and an apology.

Gandhi made the remarks in an Instagram post as he shared a video of his interaction with the families of Gopika, Roshini and Vetri Anandan, who committed suicide following the NEET paper leak and cancellation, during his visit to Tamil Nadu

on Saturday.

The leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha said, "During my visit to Tamil Nadu, I met the families of Gopika, Roshini and Vetri Anandan, three young medical aspirants whose lives were lost following the NEET paper leak and the cancellation of the examination. Each family was left with the same painful question: why should honest, hard-working students pay the price for a dishonest system?"

A leaked paper led to a cancelled examination, a forced NEET re-exam and unbearable pressure on young minds, Gandhi said.



LoP in Lok Sabha and Congress MP Rahul Gandhi addresses a press conference in New Delhi on Wednesday

Behind every statistic is a child with a dream and a family now living with an irreplaceable loss, he said. "I listened to their pain. Our fight is for an education

system where hard work is respected, examinations are fair and no student is pushed to the edge because institutions failed them," the former Congress chief said.

## Labourers' killers' names must be revealed: Farooq

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Srinagar

National Conference president Farooq Abdullah on Sunday demanded that the identity of the killers of two migrant labourers in Kulgam and a policeman in Anantnag be made public. He also asked the authorities where the terrorists were coming from.

"They (administration) should tell people who is carrying out these killings. All we are told is that terrorists killed them. The question is where the terrorists are coming from when all the borders are sealed," Abdullah told reporters in Bijbehara area of Anantnag district.

The former chief minister of Jammu and Kashmir said it was imperative to unmask the killers to test the lieutenant governor's claim that terror-



ism has ended in the Valley.

"Let us and the whole world see who these killers are. Has terrorism ended? You can see how much the situation has changed," he said, referring to the change in status quo since the 2019 abrogation of Article 370.

Abdullah also demanded the Centre restore statehood to Jammu and Kashmir. The NC leader also accused the BJP of destroying the Union Territory, which was a state before 2019.

On the situation in the

Pakistan-occupied Jammu and Kashmir, he expressed surprise at the silence of the global community on the matter.

"They (PoJK people) are our brothers, and we are pained by what they are going through. The United Nations has a Human Rights Commission. They should send a delegation there to assess the situation first hand. While the global silence is surprising, our own country has not said anything about it," he added.

## Jammu Railway Division earns nearly ₹78 lakh in fines for ticketless travel in July

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Jammu

The Jammu Division of Northern Railway generated about ₹78 lakh in revenue by penalising more than 10,000 ticketless and irregular travellers during a month-long special drive in July, reflecting intensified enforcement against fare evasion, an official spokesperson said on Sunday.

The drive was carried out across the Jammu Division to curb ticketless travel, unauthorised travel in higher classes, the carriage of unbooked luggage, and other violations of railway rules through stringent ticket-checking and enforcement measures, the spokesperson said.

He said the ticket checking



staff conducted surprise and regular checks in all mail, express, and passenger trains as well as at major stations of the division under the guidance of Senior Divisional Commercial Manager, Jammu, Uchit Singhal.

"The special drive yielded highly encouraging results, with the vigilance and alertness of the ticket-checking staff leading to the detection of 10,014 cases of ticketless

and irregular travel during July. Penalties were imposed in accordance with railway rules, generating revenue of ₹77,97,430," the spokesperson said.

Singhal appreciated the commendable work of the ticket checking staff and said the objective of Jammu Division is not only to increase revenue, but also to create awareness among passengers and encourage them to travel as per rules.

"This achievement has been possible only due to the hard work and dedication of our ticket checking staff. Jammu Division will continue to conduct such intensive checking drives in the future as well for the convenience of passengers and for the safety of railway property," he said.

## India's greatest strength lies in its young population: J&K LG Manoj Sinha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Srinagar

India's greatest strength lies in its young population, with nearly 65 per cent of the population below the age of 35, Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha said on Sunday as he urged the youth to work towards nation building.

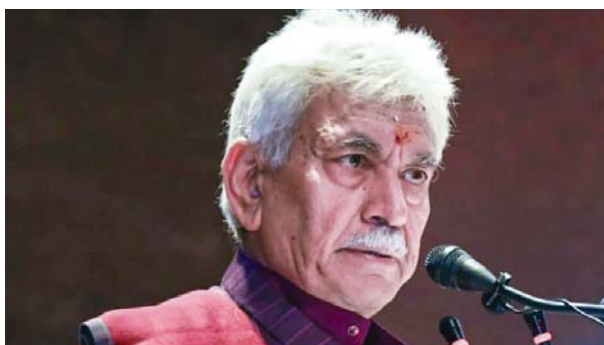
Addressing a UT-level function for the launch of the

'Nasha Mukht Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan', Sinha said that 37 crore youth in the age group of 15 to 29 years are eager to contribute to nation building.

The 100-week mega campaign was virtually inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, marking a nationwide resolve to secure India's future by empowering its youth and eliminating the menace of drugs.

"India's greatest strength lies in its young population, with nearly 65 per cent below the age of 35. Nearly 37 crore youth in the 15-29 age group are eager to contribute to nation building," Sinha said.

He said the 'Nasha Mukht Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan' seeks to energise this demographic, guiding them towards healthy lifestyles and active



participation in development. "Our youth must emerge like a cloud of energy and spread across the horizon of development," he added.

The Lieutenant Governor said that the campaign, launched in 2020 by the prime minister, is not merely a Government programme but a social movement against drug menace.

Sinha said that more than

one crore youth joined the campaign at nearly 10,000 locations nationwide, reflecting the collective responsibility of society to protect young people from drugs.

He also highlighted the significant achievements of the Nasha Mukht Jammu Kashmir campaign.

"Around 2,300 FIRs have been registered, 2,600 people arrested, and 1,500

kilograms of narcotics seized. More than 331 properties worth around ₹200 crore belonging to narcotics terrorists and drug smugglers have been attached," he added.

Additionally, over 370 driving licenses and 750 vehicle registrations have been cancelled, with recommendations made to cancel nearly 3,000 Aadhaar cards, he said.



# Himanta to tour worst-hit districts as flood situation improves in Assam

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The flood situation in Assam improved slightly, with the number of affected people coming down to 1.78 lakh even though the count of districts hit by the deluge increased to seven, officials said on Sunday. The toll remained unchanged at 82 as no fresh fatalities were reported in the state in the last 24 hours, they said. Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma visited the worst-hit areas from Sunday, even as the Centre sanctioned over ₹370 crore under the State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF), the officials said.

A total of 349 villages in Golaghat, Sivasagar, Charaideo, Bajali, Dhemaji, Sonitpur and Jorhat districts remained affected by the deluge. Charaideo was the worst-hit, with 75,199 people affected, followed by 58,824 in Sivasagar.

A total of five districts and 1.92 lakh people were affected on Friday.

Forty-four relief camps were operational in the State, providing shelter to around 15,000 displaced people.



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma visited the erosion-hit areas of Chabua, Balijan, Pukhurjan, Dinjan and Rahmoria in Dibrugarh to assess the situation firsthand and announced that IIT experts will be engaged to develop a long-term solution to Brahmaputra erosion PIONEER PHOTO

Another 17 relief distribution centres were also working, catering to 5,569 people.

A crop area of 15,060 hectares remained submerged, while 1,543 animals were washed away and another 6,765 were affected.

Sarma expressed his gratitude to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah for extending all assistance to the flood-hit State.

"The approval of ₹379.35 cr under the SDRF and the timely deputation of Inter-Ministerial Central Teams to

Assam reflect the Centre's unwavering commitment to standing with our people," Sarma said in a post on social media.

The CM will be touring the affected districts to oversee the relief work and ensure that proper damage assessment is done.

"In a short while from now, I will be reaching Dibrugarh and thereafter to the flood-affected areas to meet the people, oversee ongoing relief efforts and lay the ground-work for a full proof assessment exercise to ensure

appropriate compensation to the affected," he said.

Sarma had reviewed the relief and rehabilitation work in the worst-hit four districts in a virtual meeting from Guwahati on Saturday.

"CM @himantabiswa today reviewed the ongoing relief and rehabilitation efforts in the flood-affected districts of Sivasagar, Charaideo, Jorhat and Golaghat with the respective District Commissioners," the chief minister's office (CMO) said in a social media post.

The Chief Minister directed the DCs to expedite the submission of the list of affected families to enable the release of financial assistance from August 3, ensure uninterrupted distribution of relief kits, complete damage assessment of educational institutions ahead of the reopening of schools on August 10 and submit the list of damaged 'Namghars' (Vaishnavite centres of prayer) for early restoration support. "HCM also informed that the comprehensive flood damage assessment will begin on August 9," the CMO added.

# New criminal laws to ensure faster, tech-driven justice: Chhattisgarh CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Raipur

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Sunday said the objective of the new criminal laws is not merely to punish offenders but to establish a citizen-centric system in which victims receive timely justice, and criminals cannot escape the law.

He said the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, which came into force on July 1, 2024, under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, have modernised India's criminal justice system by replacing colonial-era laws.

Addressing a workshop on "Strengthening Digital Justice through New Criminal Laws", organised by the State's Home Department here, Sai said the new criminal laws have been framed in line with present-day requirements and emerging challenges.

They have marked a historic transformation in India's justice delivery system by ensuring faster,



Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai

transparent, accessible and time-bound justice for citizens, he said.

"The old laws were enacted at a time when digital technology, CCTV surveillance, electronic records and modern forensic science did not exist. Today's crimes have evolved, and technology has become an indispensable part of the justice delivery system," Sai said.

He said the new legal framework recognises digital evidence, CCTV footage, mobile chats, electronic records and scientific forensic examination, thereby strengthening criminal investigation and prosecution.

The CM said that the establishment of a campus of the

National Forensic Sciences University in Chhattisgarh would further strengthen criminal investigation and judicial processes.

The use of digital technology has made the justice delivery process significantly faster and more efficient. While serving summons earlier took several days, the e-summons system now enables instant delivery and digital tracking, he said.

Platforms such as Nyaya Shruti, a national video conferencing framework, facilitate secure digital recording of court proceedings and support online and hybrid hearings, he said.

Referring to the Crime and Criminal Tracking Network and Systems, Sai said police

stations across the country have now been digitally interconnected, enabling instant access to criminal records and facilitating prompt police action.

All police stations in Chhattisgarh are functioning online, and 1,97,547 FIRs have so far been registered digitally in the State, he said without specifying the period to which the figure pertains.

He said the Inter-Operable Criminal Justice System (ICJS) has established secure digital coordination among the judiciary, police, prosecution, prisons and other agencies, significantly reducing delays in the judicial process through faster exchange of information.

Sai said the new laws have simplified the justice delivery process, reduced paperwork and made it more transparent and cost-effective.

The laws would also prove useful in tackling emerging challenges such as cyber-crime, he said, adding that the State Government has recently established nine new cyber police stations and launched awareness campaigns.

# Andhra Govt, Australia sign MoUs on clean energy, manufacturing, education, skills

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Amaravati

Andhra Pradesh and Australia on Sunday signed four MoUs covering clean energy, advanced manufacturing, inclusive education, student mental health and skill development, marking a significant expansion of bilateral cooperation in these sectors.

The agreements were signed in the presence of Andhra Pradesh Education, Information Technology and Electronics Minister Nara Lokesh and Australia's Assistant Minister for International Education, Citizenship, Customs and Multicultural Affairs Julian Hill.

"These partnerships are a direct outcome of our recent visit to Australia and reflect the growing collaboration between Andhra Pradesh and Australian institutions in education, research, innovation and workforce development," Lokesh said in a release.

The minister said the agreements followed discussions held in Australia with leading universities, research institutions, industry leaders and Government representatives, where he showcased Andhra Pradesh's investment-friendly ecosystem and invited Australian institutions to partner with the State.

Under the first MoU, the Andhra Pradesh Government's Centre of Excellence for Energy Transition (CoEET), IIT Tirupati and the University of New South Wales (UNSW), Sydney will establish a Centre of Excellence for Solar Manufacturing at IIT Tirupati.



N Chandrababu Naidu meet the Australian delegation led by Julian Hill

The proposed centre will focus on advanced solar photovoltaic manufacturing, solar panel recycling, circular economy practices, industry-driven research, faculty development, technology commercialisation and specialised training programmes aimed at positioning Andhra Pradesh as a hub for solar manufacturing and innovation.

The minister said UNSW would support curriculum development, training programmes and research covering solar cell manufacturing, device physics, reliability engineering, recycling, safety, maintenance, ingot manufacturing and wafering technologies.

A second MoU signed between UNSW, Sri Padmavati Mahila Visvaavidyalayam (SPMVV) and Samagra Shiksha, Andhra Pradesh aims to strengthen inclusive education by enhancing teachers' capacity to educate children with autism and other neurodiverse learning needs through specialised training, professional development and teaching resources.

Under the third agreement, the Andhra Pradesh State Council of Higher Education

(APSCHE) and Australia's Rebound will jointly implement a technology-enabled pilot project to provide confidential mental health resources, wellness assessment tools and virtual counselling services for students in selected higher educational institutions. The pilot programme will be implemented free of cost.

The fourth MoU, signed between the Andhra Pradesh State Skill Development Corporation (APSSDC) and Australia's Dynamic Learning Services (DLS), seeks to strengthen vocational education, workforce development, industry-aligned training, globally recognised professional certifications and international employment pathways.

Earlier, Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu met the Australian delegation led by Julian Hill and highlighted Andhra Pradesh's economic transformation, investment opportunities and development initiatives.

Naidu felicitated the Australian minister with a traditional shawl and presented him with Araku Coffee and a commemorative memento.

# BJP leader among 17 arrested in Bhilai Steel Plant scrap theft

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Durg

A ruling BJP functionary was held in connection with the alleged theft of iron scrap worth several crore rupees from the public sector Bhilai Steel Plant in Chhattisgarh's Durg district, taking the total number of arrests in the case to 17, police said on Sunday.

Bhaskar Mudaliyar, a businessman from Vaishali Nagar in Bhilai whose vehicles had been operating inside the plant for a long time, was arrested on Saturday, Bhilai Nagar City Superintendent of Police (CSP) Satyaprakash Tiwari said.

"Investigators found links between him and vehicles allegedly used in transporting stolen iron scrap. Mudaliyar was questioned and subsequently arrested. The case involves an organised network operating both inside and outside the steel plant," Tiwari said.



Following the arrest, BJP's Bhilai unit spokesperson Vijay Singh said Mudaliyar, who served as treasurer of Vaishali Nagar mandal unit, has been expelled from the party for six years.

According to police, iron scrap was being stolen over the past four to five months by concealing it in

consignments of flue dust.

The case came to light on May 26 after police, acting on a tip-off, raided the premises of AK Traders in Bhilai's Hathkhaj area and recovered iron plates, beams, cutting material and other iron scrap loaded in trucks and heavy vehicles along with flue dust.

# Govt aims to complete Mumbai coastal road project by 2028: Piyush Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Union Minister and MP from Mumbai, Piyush Goyal, on Sunday said the Government intends to complete the Bandra-Versova-Bhayander Coastal Road project by December 2028, with March 2029 set as the target timeline.

The commerce and industry minister reviewed the progress of various key infrastructure projects, including the Mumbai Coastal Road, the proposed desalination plant, Madh-Versova Bridge and other connectivity projects.

He was briefed by Additional Municipal Commissioner Abhijit Bangar on the status, timelines and expected public benefits of the projects.

"The Bandra-Versova stretch of the Coastal Road is progressing rapidly, while work on the Versova-



Union Minister Piyush Goyal inspects the Versova-Charkop Coastal Road project at Kandivali in Mumbai on Sunday PTI

Bhayander section has commenced after receiving all necessary approvals. Our endeavour is to complete the project by December 2028,

with March 2029 as the target timeline," Goyal told reporters after reviewing the projects.

The Coastal Road is an eight-lane

high-speed expressway being built along Mumbai's western coast, cutting travel time between south Mumbai and the suburbs from 2 hours down to 40 minutes.

Goyal said the proposed interchanges and tunnel network in north Mumbai would help decongest the Western Express Highway and provide seamless east-west connectivity across the western suburbs.

The Mumbai North MP added that the proposed desalination plant would strengthen long-term water security by supplying drinking water to Gorai, Manori, Mahavir Nagar, Borivali, Charkop and surrounding areas.

He said concerns of the fishing community were being addressed through careful project planning to ensure that infrastructure development did not affect their traditional livelihoods.

# AI, semiconductors will shape future of this century: Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Nagpur

Artificial Intelligence, semiconductors and quantum computing will define the century ahead, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said on Sunday, urging the education system to embrace the new technologies and create employable, cutting-edge human resources.

Fadnavis was addressing a gathering at the inauguration of the AI Centre of Competency powered by NVIDIA at Ramdeobaba University in Nagpur.

"AI, semi-con and quantum computing are going to shape the future of this century," he stated.

The Maharashtra Government encourages educational institutions to look at the job market and the changes happening, Fadnavis said, emphasising the creation of cutting-edge human resources and not just graduates, but employable and meaningful



human resources.

Talking about the new technologies, he said that looking back at all industrial revolutions, there has been a huge time lag between the first three revolutions.

The first industrial revolution started in 1740, the second in 1860 and the third in 1950, he noted.

"But look at the scenario today: we started talking about Industry 4.0 around 2010, it started to peak at 2016-17, and today, when we

are in 2026, we are talking about the industrial revolution, which is around AI, deep tech, frontier technologies and the world has started talking about the sixth revolution now," he said.

"The speed at which the technology is changing, and the way we conduct our business is changing, I think it is the right time that our educational system embraces all the new technologies," Fadnavis said.

The chief minister further

said that AI will change every walk of life.

He cited his conversation with a big tech expert on AI, who told him that in the next 1,000 days, the nature of 75 per cent jobs in the market will change. It does not mean that jobs will go, but their nature will change because of the advancement of AI, he added.

Fadnavis emphasised that the educational systems must adopt and transform their entire way of imparting education, "looking at the way we and the world are changing".

Along with other sectors, agriculture can also benefit from AI-related technologies, he pointed out.

The Maharashtra Government's 'Mahavistar' App initiative, an AI-powered app dedicated to agriculture, answers farm-related queries of cultivators in their own language, the CM informed.

He praised Ramdeobaba University for embracing new ideas and imparting them to students.

# Congress, GFP begin alliance talks for 2027 Goa polls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Panaji

Opposition parties Congress and the Goa Forward Party have launched preliminary talks to ally for the 2027 state assembly polls, with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) also signalling its willingness for a tie-up.

Goa Pradesh Congress Committee president Girish Chodankar said he had held talks with Goa Forward Party (GFP) chief Vijai Sardesai on forming an alliance.

The duo met in the Fatorda town of South Goa on Saturday.

The Congress and GFP had fought the 2022 Goa Assembly polls together.

Chodankar said that the talks on Saturday were preliminary and a decision has to be taken on renewing the alliance.

"We will be meeting again to hammer out and finalise details, including seat sharing," he said.

Meanwhile, AAP Goa president Valmiki Naik on



Saturday held a meeting with the party's committee formed to decide on a tie-up with like-minded parties.

Talking to reporters, Naik said the AAP is ready to ally with like-minded parties, as "the main aim is to defeat the corrupt BJP Government in the State".

Polls for the 40-member Goa assembly are likely to be held in February-March 2027.

The BJP is in power in the coastal State with the support of 33 MLAs. While 28 of these legislators belong to the party, three are independents, and two others are from the Maharashtrawadi Gomantak Party (MGP).

In the 2022 State elections, the BJP had won 20 out of 40 seats. But later, it inducted eight Congress MLAs into the party.

The Congress currently has three MLAs, the AAP has two, while the GFP and the Revolutionary Goans Party (RGP) have one legislator each.

The ruling BJP in Goa last month announced it has set a target of winning at least 30 seats in the Assembly elections to be at the helm in the coastal State for the fourth consecutive time.





Editor's  
TAKE

## Nathu La: A small trade route carries a large signal

A reopened pass cannot undo six years of mistrust between India and China. But it can be the first plank of a bridge that can shorten the distance

On August 1, after a silence of more than six years, trade resumed across the frozen no-man's-land at Nathu La, the 14,140-foot Himalayan pass linking Sikkim to Tibet. Traders exchanged wool, silk, blankets and borax under the gaze of Indian and Chinese officials – a modest commercial event carrying outsized diplomatic weight. The numbers involved are trivial: the pass moved barely ₹49 crore worth of goods in its last full year, a rounding error against bilateral trade nearing \$150 billion. Yet few border crossings anywhere carry as much history per kilogram of yak wool.

Nathu La's story mirrors the relationship itself: cordial, then broken, then cautiously mended. The pass shut after the 1962 war and stayed closed for over four decades, reopening only in 2006 as one of the few tangible results of the Special Representatives' boundary talks begun under Prime Minister Vajpayee. That thaw lasted until 2020, when two things happened almost together: the Covid-19 pandemic shut borders worldwide, and Chinese troops moved aggressively along the Line of Actual Control in Ladakh.

The Galwan Valley clash that June – the deadliest India-China confrontation in 45 years – killed Indian and, Chinese soldiers, though number of Indian soldiers killed was much higher. Trade, tourism and the Kailash Mansarovar pilgrimage through Nathu La all stopped, pandemic notwithstanding. Six years is a long time to nurse a grudge between nuclear-armed neighbours. Disengagement in Ladakh's most contested sectors dragged on well past the pandemic, and real momentum arrived only after Prime Minister Modi and President Xi Jinping met on the sidelines of the BRICS summit in Kazan in October 2024.

What followed was incremental: a 24th round of Special Representatives' talks in Delhi last August, Modi's first visit to China in seven years for the SCO summit in Tianjin, and a shared, unspoken incentive – Washington's tariff wars have made both capitals warier of leaning on the West, and readier to de-risk relations with each other.

Well, is this a bridge to something larger? The short answer is, only partly. Trade through Nathu La will not touch India's roughly \$100-billion-plus deficit with China, nor settle where the boundary actually runs – the question that has outlasted 24 rounds of talks since 2003. What it does is restore a livelihood to Sikkim's border communities, and give both governments a low-cost, high-visibility way to show that normalcy is possible. Confidence-building measures rarely resolve disputes on their own; they simply make the next difficult conversation easier to hold. The way forward lies in not mistaking the gesture for the destination. New Delhi should use this goodwill to press the boundary 'expert group' both sides have agreed to set up, widen the narrow list of 36 tradeable items, and insist that re-engagement bring fairer market access, not merely larger imports. But it is by no means a small development. It is a confidence building measure that can pave the way for better relations.

# When strength becomes a liability

As the conflict with Iran grows longer, costlier, and more uncertain, Trump confronts a paradox familiar to many wartime leaders: the very instincts that brought him to power may now stand in the way of securing a lasting peace



BHOPINDER SINGH

Donald Trump has built his political identity around a simple and powerful message i.e., he is the leader who gets things done. He has often spoken in a triumphant, even imperious, tone about his own abilities and about his promise to 'Make America Great Again.' Whatever one's political views, his political comeback represented a remarkable defiance of conventional expectations. Many scholars, commentators, public officials, and voices from across the ideological spectrum had warned that his return to power would face enormous obstacles. Yet Trump demonstrated an extraordinary ability to connect with millions of voters and overturn predictions that had underestimated his appeal.

His supporters did not merely vote for his policies; many were drawn to his persona. They embraced his confidence, his defiance, and his willingness to break political conventions. For many, his refusal to conform to traditional presidential behavior was not a weakness but the very reason he appeared authentic. Actions and rhetoric that critics described as divisive, including his conduct surrounding 6th January and his repeated attacks on political opponents, were often dismissed by loyal supporters as the necessary disruption of a system they believed had failed them.

That combative style extended beyond America's borders. Allies such as Canada and the European Union, as well as partners like India, found themselves subjected to sharp criticism, tariff threats, and a more transactional approach to diplomacy. To Trump's supporters, this represented a long-overdue willingness to put American interests first. To his critics, it reflected an unnecessary erosion of alliances and a disregard for the conventions of international statecraft.

Trump's political resilience became one of his defining characteristics. Controversies that might have ended the careers of other politicians seemed to strengthen his bond with his base. Traditional institutional checks, public criticism, and repeated scandals appeared unable to weaken his hold over the Republican Party. He seemed politically untouchable.

But every political force has limits. The prolonged conflict with Iran may represent the moment when political bravado collides with geopolitical reality. The qualities that helped Trump dominate domestic



THE MOST  
DAMAGING  
SHIFT FOR ANY  
LEADER IS NOT  
WHEN  
OPPONENTS  
LOSE  
CONFIDENCE-IT  
IS WHEN LOYAL  
SUPPORTERS  
BEGIN TO  
WONDER  
WHETHER THE  
LEADER'S  
INSTINCTS ARE  
STILL SERVING  
THE COUNTRY

The writer, a military veteran, is a former Lt Governor of Andaman & Nicobar Islands and Puducherry

politics - relentless confrontation, personal attacks, public displays of toughness, and refusal to appear weak are far more difficult to translate into a successful wartime strategy.

War has a way of exposing the gap between rhetoric and reality.

A conflict that was expected by supporters to demonstrate American power has instead raised uncomfortable questions about cost, strategy, and endurance. As the war drags on, fatigue grows. Economic pressures mount. Military risks increase. The public begins to ask the question that eventually confronts every wartime leader: What is the endgame?

Historically, war has often provided presidents with a surge in popularity as citizens rally around the flag. After the attacks of 9/11, even President George W. Bush, previously a relatively conventional and politically vulnerable leader experienced an extraordinary increase in public approval, reaching historically high levels (90% approval rating) as Americans united behind the government's response.

The current situation presents a very different political dynamic. Instead of producing a sustained rally effect, the Iran conflict has increasingly become associated with uncertainty, expense, and exhaustion. Rising costs, increased government spending, military casualties, and deepening political divisions have made the reality of war harder to ignore. The promise of quick and decisive victory is confronting the far more complicated reality of prolonged conflict.

The political danger for Trump is not merely opposition from his critics. It is the possibility that his own supporters begin questioning the strategy itself. The most

damaging shift for any leader is not when opponents lose confidence-it is when loyal supporters begin to wonder whether the leader's instincts are still serving the country.

And here lies the ultimate irony. The only realistic path toward a negotiated settlement may require Trump to do something profoundly uncomfortable: become 'un-Trump.'

The same qualities that helped him rise politically may now need to be restrained. A successful diplomatic outcome will likely require patience rather than provocation, private negotiations rather than public humiliation, and strategic compromise rather than constant escalation. Insults, threats, and declarations of absolute victory may enrage supporters, but they rarely create the conditions necessary for peace.

A negotiated end to a war requires giving the opposing side a way to step back without total humiliation. It requires recognizing that diplomacy is not surrender and that compromise is not weakness. For a leader whose political brand has been built on never backing down, this may be the greatest challenge of all.

Trump's problem is no longer simply how to defeat Iran. It is whether he can overcome the very instincts that made him politically successful but may now be preventing him from achieving the outcome he wants. The supreme irony is this: to preserve the image of the strongest man in the room, Trump may have to stop behaving like the only man who refuses to listen. The war may not be decided by who can threaten the loudest, but by who can recognise when strength requires restraint. The ultimate test of the strongman may be whether he can learn the art of peace.

## PIC TALK



Women carry decorated structures for the annual 'Kanwar Yatra' in the month of 'Shravan', in Haridwar

PHOTO: PTI

## Earth and humanity: An eternal spiritual symbiosis



RAMESH DAVESAR

### 2ND OPINION

The Earth and the soil-the infinite symbiosim of Spiritually and the Human kind that we often equate it to the most sacred relation of "Mother". Recalling the beginning of my academic journey from my village Gurudwara in early 50s, the morning prayers ending with Japji Sahib's Hymn (Shalok) - "Pawan Guru Pani Pita,Mata dharat mahat "(earth is like mother to us) still resonate in my memory neurons. The earth commands special reverence in all faiths. In Hinduism, the Earth is not merely a planet or a resource but is revered as a sacred living entity often personified as the Goddess - Bhumi Devi or Bhumi Mata (Mother Earth). It is further corroborated in Atharva Veda, the "Prithavi Sukta (Hymn) portrays it as a sacred nurturing mother to the humanity , (Mata

bhumih putroham prithivyah). In chapter 3 of Holy Gita, Lord Krishana says that the Universe originated from the earth; further in chapter 15, HE goes on that the "earth is- My incarnation.

Similarly, the relation of earth and soil to the humanity has been widely acknowledged in Islam . It believes that it is not an object to be exploited but to be treated as a sacred trust bestowed upon humanity by the God. It further states "Turbah (soil) is an essential requisite to purify Salah (daily Namaaz)". Similarly, the Earth, in Christianity, is viewed as a Theatre of HIS glory, stewardship and a place to be redeemed and renewed.

Call it our National Vox Populi that we Indians address our country as our mother land and are espoused to sacrifice everything to defend its honour. As elucidated in Gurubani" Soora so pehchaniye jo ladey deen ke het, purza purza kat marey kabuh na chhade khet"(warrior is the one who while defending his land would never leave the battlefield even shredded into pieces). Again going back to Gita, Lord Krishana in Chapter 2 says that "Veer bhogya vasundhara" means that only the braves rule the land.

Further, highlighting blessedness of soil, the Fifth Guru Sh Guru Arjun Dev Ji sermoned : "Pehla maran qabool, jiwan ki chhad aas, hohu sabna ki renuka tau ao hamare pas" ( If you want to be with Me [The God], First accept death, give up attachments and become the dust of humankind's feet). Bhai Sahib Bhai Nand Lal Ji, a devout disciple of Sh Guru Going Singh ji and renowned

Persian Scholar likened his end existence with a hand-full of Soil ( Hasti -ye man tanha moshti khaq ast).

The Sufism too has acknowledged the incorporeal spirit of earth. Kabir ji says; " Kabira garv na kijiye ooncha dekh awas, aij kal bhoye letna ooper jamey ghas" (one should not feel proud of one's wealth because sooner or later the person on death will be buried in the soil). Baba Farid- a Punjabi Sufi Saint says; "Farida khaq na nindiye, khaq jida na koi jividan pairaan taley moyian ooper hoye" (earth being supreme; when alive it is below us but after death it would be above us). And he goes on , " Budha hoiya Sheikh Farid kamban lagi deh, je sau baras jeevna bhi tan hosi kkeh" ( even if One lives for 100 years would ultimately be buried in the soil ).

There cannot be more apposite spiritual apogee than what Punjabi Sufi Saint- Baba Bulle Shah said:-

"Mati (soil) ghoda (horse) mati jora,mati da aswar (rider). Mati mati nu doravey, mati di kharkal (Authority).

Mati mati nu maran lagi,mati de hathiar. Jis mati par bahuti mati, so mati hankar.

Mati mati nu dekhan ayeey,mati di hai bahar.Hass khed phir mati hovey, paindi pao pasar."

( The earth make people compete and fight. A person with more resources become arrogantly more powerful; but finally merges in the soil)

Col Ramesh Davesar is a Veteran who fought 1971 Indo-Pak War; had two years stint in the IPKF & commanded Battalion in the Valley

### DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



www.dailypioneer.com

facebook.com/dailypioneer @TheDailyPioneer  
instagram.com/dailypioneer linkedin.com/in/The Pioneer

### ASSAM NEEDS FLOOD RESILIENCE, NOT ANNUAL RELIEF

Assam has once again witnessed the devastating consequences of seasonal floods, but this year's disaster has been exceptionally severe.

Torrential rainfall in the hills of Nagaland, coupled with rampant hill cutting and illegal mining, triggered massive surface runoff that inundated Jorhat, Sivasagar and Charaideo districts within hours.

Homes, vehicles, livestock, standing crops and food stocks were swept away, leaving thousands homeless and destitute. Heart-rending images of bodies floating in floodwaters underscored the immense human tragedy.

The misery has continued even after the waters receded. Thick layers of toxic silt have rendered homes, roads and agricultural fields unusable. Access to

drinking water, healthcare and essential commodities remains severely disrupted, forcing many families to depend entirely on relief assistance.While normalcy may gradually return, Assam cannot continue relying on emergency responses alone.

Repeated floods inflict enormous economic losses through damaged infrastructure, disrupted supply chains, agricultural destruction and increased compensation burdens. Scientific flood management, stronger embankments, better watershed conservation and coordinated action with neighbouring states are essential. The objective should not merely be surviving floods every year but building a resilient Assam capable of withstanding future disasters.

KABIR AHMED SAIKIA | JORHAT

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

### Boxing triumph must be sustained

Apropos the news report, "India wins 7th gold in Glasgow CWG" (August 2). India's magnificent boxing campaign at the Commonwealth Games deserves wholehearted appreciation. Winning seven gold and three silver medals marks the country's finest-ever performance at the Games and reflects the remarkable progress Indian boxing has made over the past decade. The gold medal-winning performances of Preeti Pawar, Priya Ghanghas, Jaismine Lamboria, Sakshi Choudhary, Arundhati Choudhary, Sachin Siwach and Ankush demonstrate the success of systematic coaching, scientific training methods and effective talent identification programmes.

Although Lovlina Borgohain narrowly missed the top podium, her silver medal against formidable international competition is equally commendable. Every medal strengthens India's reputation as an emerging global boxing powerhouse.This historic achievement should encourage governments and sports administrators to further invest in modern training facilities, sports science, quality coaching and international exposure. Equal emphasis must also be placed on nurturing talented youngsters from rural and economically weaker backgrounds.

SANJAY CHOPRA | MOHALI

### Protest must respect religious sentiments

The allegations regarding the theft of donations from the Ayodhya Ram Temple are undoubtedly serious and deserve a thorough, impartial investigation. The Supreme Court's decision to monitor the probe is a welcome step that should ensure accountability and justice.However, the manner in which certain opposition MPs chose to protest inside the Parliament premises was deeply unfortunate.

The skit, in which an MP dressed as a Hindu priest while carrying an image of Lord Ram and allegedly depicting the theft of devotees' offerings, crossed the line between political criticism and disrespect for religious symbols. Parliamentary protest is a legitimate democratic right, but it should never be exercised in a manner that hurts the sentiments of millions of believers. If there were any attempt to suppress the investigation, strong opposition would certainly be justified.

Yet political theatre should not come at the cost of reverence for faith. Similar restraint should be observed in matters concerning all religions.Corruption and financial irregularities have occurred under different governments and institutions over the years. The focus should remain on ensuring a fair investigation and punishing the guilty rather than resorting to provocative symbolism.

V. JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

## LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

### Preserve the legacy of India's blue jersey

The decision to replace India's iconic blue hockey jersey with saffron ahead of the World Cup has sparked a debate that extends well beyond sport. For nearly a century, the blue jersey has symbolised India's glorious hockey tradition—from the era of Major Dhyan Chand to the country's recent Olympic resurgence. It represents history, achievement and the emotional bond shared by generations of players and supporters. The official explanation that the change is based on technical considerations has failed to convince many. If improved visibility against blue synthetic pitches is the objective, numerous alternative colours could have been considered without abandoning a jersey that has become synonymous with Indian hockey.

The choice of saffron has inevitably created the impression that symbolism has taken precedence over sporting tradition. National sporting symbols should not be altered without broad consultation and transparency. Their significance lies not merely in design but in the memories, achievements and collective identity they represent.At a time when the country faces pressing challenges in employment, healthcare, education and infrastructure, avoidable controversies over sporting symbols serve little public purpose. Governments must preserving the heritage that has inspired generations.

AP THIRUVADI | CHENNAI



# Queues to QR codes: India’s daily commute is becoming a digital experience

Smartphones are no longer just changing how Indians shop or pay-they are changing how the people move. From buses and metros to railways and airports, transport is increasingly becoming part of everyday digital life.



SHREYA GUPTA | SHUBHANGI GUPTA

For decades, urban commuting meant standing in line, buying paper tickets and carrying cash. Today, tickets are moving to smartphones, payments to QR codes and airport access by facial recognition. What is changing is not just transport digitisation but the integration of mobility into everyday digital behaviour. This reflects a wider behavioural shift. Government data shows digital payment transactions rose from 4,371 crore in 2020-21 to over 18,000 crore by January 2025-more than fourfold in under five years. As smartphones become central to payments and services, the commuters increasingly begin experiencing hassle free and convenient travel experience.

Railways offer one of the earliest examples of this shift. While online reservations became common much earlier, daily commuting remained tied to counters and printed tickets until Indian Railways introduced paper-less mobile ticketing through the UTS app in 2015. The app later expanded to include UPI payments and multilingual support. Mobile-based UTS booking has also become increasingly popular, particularly in Mumbai’s suburban network. Between April and November 2023, Central Railway reported that 14.76 crore passengers used UTS, including 14.44 crore on Mumbai Division, generating over ₹161 crore-showing growing commuter comfort with carrying tickets on smartphones. Alongside this, Indian Railways now operates more than 4,661 Automatic Ticket Vending Machines (ATVMs) and 5 Coin-cum-Card Operated Ticket Vending Machines (CoTVMs) to support digital purchase of unreserved, platform and season tickets and reduce counter congestion. Digital adoption is also visible in reserved travel: e-ticketing accounted for approximately 87.5% of all reserved tickets booked in 2024-25. More recently, the RailOne app has integrated services including ticket booking, live train tracking, PNR status, food ordering and complaints onto a single platform while enabling digital payment through R-Wallet, cards, net banking and UPI.

Metro systems had introduced electronic ticketing years ago through smart cards and tokens, but the current shift is moving ticket access onto smartphones. Delhi Metro now offers QR-ticket booking across multiple digital platforms including the Delhi Sarthi (Momentum 2.0) app, WhatsApp, Paytm, PhonePe, Amazon Pay and the One Delhi app. After introducing QR-based paper tickets in 2023, DMRC recorded more than 74 lakh QR-ticket sales in the first month, contributing to a nearly 32% decline in token usage. A similar shift is visible in Bengaluru: QR-ticket usage rose in 2023-24 from 0.09% to 11.63% on Line-1 and from 0.06% to 10.02% on Line-2, increasing further in 2024-25 to 23.23% and 20.34% respectively, while smart card usage declined. Bus systems are also becoming more digital through app-based ticketing, QR payments and real-time information. Delhi’s experience showed how quickly commuters adapt when systems become easier to use.

Before COVID-19, over 36% of bus tickets were issued through passes and mobility cards, indicating some digital familiarity. However, a 2020 QR-ticketing pilot expanded access beyond existing users. The first trial recorded over 1,000 app downloads within two days, and after interface improvements, the second phase expanded to more than 15 DTC and cluster routes, generating over 51,000 digital tickets in 14 days. Surveys by WRI India found over 90% of users intended to continue, and the programme later expanded to around 650 buses, issuing more than 2 lakh digital tickets within three months. Bengaluru shows how this can scale: UPI ticket payments rose from 76.2 crore in January 2024 (7.6% of revenue) to ₹43.7 crore in September 2025 (nearly 49%). According to the 2024 IAMAI-Grant Thornton Connected Commutes survey covering more than 1,400 respondents, 47% of Mumbai bus commuters used travel apps to buy tickets. The shift is also changing commuter expectations: 27% of respondents prioritised real-time seat availability, 21% valued live bus



THE CHANGE IS NOT LIMITED TO PAYMENTS. INCREASINGLY, COMMUTERS EXPECT TRANSPORT APPS TO TELL THEM WHEN THE NEXT BUS WILL ARRIVE, WHETHER SEATS ARE AVAILABLE AND WHICH ROUTE IS FASTEST. ACCORDING TO BEST, ITS LIVE BUS-TRACKING APPLICATION HAS CROSSED 60 LAKH DOWNLOADS

Shreya Gupta is a Research Associate, and Shubhangi Gupta is a Consultant at The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI).

tracking, and 26% identified ease of use as the most important feature. The change is not limited to payments. Increasingly, commuters expect transport apps to tell them when the next bus will arrive, whether seats are available and which route is fastest. According to BEST, its live bus-tracking application has crossed 60 lakh downloads. The authority also reported rapid early adoption after launch, with more than 3 lakh users joining within the first few months and 12,000-15,000 new users being added daily.

According to the 2025 BusTrack report by redBus, growing smartphone and UPI adoption in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities is increasing the use of online bus booking platforms and shifting travel decisions closer to departure time. Nearly 43% of bus users booked tickets on the same day of travel, suggesting that digital access is making intercity bus journeys more immediate and flexible rather than dependent on advance bookings.

Airports are moving in the same direction. DigiYatra, which uses facial recognition for airport entry and verification, was launched at just three airports in December 2022 but expanded to 13 airports within little over a year. The number of registered DigiYatra users increased from 38 lakh on 1 January 2024 to 45.8 lakh by 10 February 2024 - a rise of over 20% in just six weeks. The largest gains were recorded at high-volume airports such as Delhi and Bengaluru, where DigiYatra journeys increased by around 24% and 27% respectively within this short period. What makes this important is not that airports became digital-online check-ins already existed. The bigger change is that identity verification, ticket access and movement are beginning to merge into a single digital journey. Several forces are driving this shift. First, India’s digital infrastructure has expanded dramatically, with more than 900 million internet subscribers creating the foundation for app-driven mobility.

Second, digital systems provide significant operational advantages to transport agencies. Digital ticketing reduces dependence on paper-based systems and manual cash handling, helping lower revenue leakages and improve fare collection transparency. At the same time, app-based systems generate real-time commuter data that can help agencies understand ridership patterns, optimize routes and improve service planning. Third, commuters themselves are driving this transition. Research by IAMAI on digital bus mobility platforms found that features such as digital ticketing, live tracking and route discovery significantly improve commuter convenience by reducing waiting times and streamlining boarding processes.

Yet this transition remains uneven. Many cities still operate fragmented systems and broader integration initiatives such as the National Common Mobility Card, launched in 2019 under the “One Nation, One Card” initiative, are evolving but slowly. Delhi Metro launched NCMC services on its Airport Express Line in December 2020 and is now attempting to accelerate this shift. As stated by DMRC officials, in April alone, NCMC accounted for over 92% of all smart card sales, indicating a rapid transition away from conventional metro-only cards. In Nagpur Metro, the “Maha Card” was introduced as a common mobility smart card to allow seamless travel and integrated digital payments, while Kochi Metro has already issued more than 1.15 lakh EMV-based mobility cards between 2017 and 2022. Bengaluru has not yet achieved broader ticketing integration through the National Common Mobility Card. Even so, the direction appears clear. The future of local as well as long distance travel will be defined by how seamlessly mobility becomes integrated into everyday digital life.

# CJP agitation: Failure of BJP’s media cell?



ARVIND CHATURVEDI

Following the 2024 Lok Sabha elections, when the BJP’s much-publicised slogan “Abki baar 400 paar” ended with the party being reduced to around 240 seats, many political pundits remarked that this was, in effect, a defeat of the BJP’s arrogance. I would also view Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan’s resignation in the same light, because the BJP appears to have drawn no meaningful lessons from the 2024 verdict.

The protests that erupted in response to the NEET medical entrance examination paper leak included, in particular, opposition from the newly formed Cockroach Janata Party (CJP). Since this organisation had no substantive political presence on the ground and no widely recognised leader, the BJP initially chose to ignore it completely. That changed when a large crowd joined the Parliament march in Delhi on July 20, forcing the to use lathi charge and tear gas to contain the protesters. I shall return later to the violence and the police response; first, it is necessary to examine the underlying reasons, especially the BJP’s arrogance. The BJP’s dismissive approach to this movement was not simply a product of being in power. Many political observers also regarded CJP as just a paper or virtual organisation, and that assessment was not entirely unfounded. At one point, the CJP’s virtual following crossed 22 million mark even then it was not being taken seriously due to a lack of ground presence. A party with no leader, no office and no history could not be taken note of.

Another reason for the BJP’s indifference was the organisation’s lack of any real ground presence, along with the fact that its founder was studying in the United States. Yet the BJP, the RSS, and other right-wing voices belittled the movement by attributing it to foreign backing and anti-India forces like George Soros, thereby reinforcing the logic to ignore it. What neither sociologists nor the government, nor the BJP’s own strategists, fully understood was the silent but growing spirit of discontent among the country’s youth, including Gen Z. In the absence of such understanding, the NEET paper leak, irregularities in the evaluation of CBSE answer sheets, and the broader middle-class opposition to the UGC regulations gradually combined into a much larger political storm, which the BJP failed to anticipate.

The BJP’s media and IT cell were completely ineffective in handling this youth and student agitation. The party’s media machinery also failed to generate any meaningful positive public sentiment in support of the Modi government or the Education Minister. At the same time, Amit Malviya’s entire team failed to counter the narrative built by CJP and its allied left-wing student and youth organisations.

It is true that Cockroach Janata Party and its supporters indeed displayed a degree of creativity in shaping a broader emotional backlash against the government, extending even beyond the student community. It must also be acknowledged, however, that some of the posters, memes, and other materials circulated by the protesters contained crude slogans and obscene remarks, which warranted a strong rebuttal but did not receive one. If the BJP’s spokespersons, media wing, and IT cell did anything at all, it was limited to repeatedly alleging that the protesters were foreign-funded and linking them to the Aam Aadmi Party or the Congress.

This was clearly insufficient to shape public opinion. In that respect, the protesters maintained the upper hand. They succeeded in generating sympathy among neutral sections of the public, even though there was little in the movement itself, apart from the hunger strike, that would ordinarily have inspired sympathy or support. The failure of the BJP’s spokespersons and IT cell in this regard was significant. They neither grasped the ground reality nor conveyed it effectively to the party’s top leadership. The BJP-friendly media, especially electronic media, remained largely defensive, as the protesters had sharply targeted it and often prevented camera crews and correspondents from covering the event properly. So much so that the agitating crowd manhandled a few of them. The success or failure of any movement depends largely on the degree of sympathy, support and solidarity it generates in public. In this case, public sympathy was initially very limited, but over time the protesters’ narrative spread rapidly and their support widened. It is also relevant to note that the arrogance of the BJP’s top leadership contributed to the situation.

The party appears to have assumed that the protesters would raise slogans for a few days and then disperse on their own. Had Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan resigned earlier, the matter may not have escalated to this extent. There would have been less violence, and the government’s image would not have suffered such serious damage. Even in the case of E20 ethanol, Minister Nitin Gadkari continues to adopt an aggressive posture, which is generally sending a negative message to the public.

Arrogance, a combative attitude, and a lack of clear public communication all serve to deepen public anger against the government. At present, that appears to be the prevailing reality. The arrogance of the BJP continues even after the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. During the ongoing Parliament session, the government is not effectively defending the brutal police action against the agitating students. The absence of the Home Minister from Parliament has added fuel to the fire.

Although a few bills have been passed in both houses of Parliament, the session largely belonged to the opposition thus far.



The writer is an academician and a political analyst

# Silence cannot be an option when the country is held hostage by a violent mob



VARUN SINGH

What began as a protest seeking accountability for a paper leak has, over the last few weeks, turned into a ground for activities that have no relation, direct or distant, to NEET, to exams, or to education. The protest lost its way, lost its path and lost its vision quite a while back. Anyone still lending it support today is doing so out of vested interest, not out of concern for students.

Let us be clear about the facts first, because facts are what this entire agitation was supposedly built on.

NEET-UG 2026 was held on May 3 this year, with over 22 lakh aspirants appearing across the country, out of nearly 22.75 lakh who had registered. Within days, reports emerged that a “guess paper” circulating before the exam had an unusually high overlap with the actual questions. The National Testing Agency cancelled the exam on May 12 and handed the matter to the CBI. The agency arrested a coaching institute owner from Latur in Maharashtra on May 18, and investigators later found that the racket behind this leak had also compromised the NEET-UG 2025 paper. A re-exam was conducted on June 21 for over 22 lakh students. They appeared, they wrote the exam, and results followed. The cul-

prits were caught. They are being tried under the law, as they should be. This is not where it should have ended, but this is where the anger of genuine students should have found its resolution. And to its credit, the government did not stay silent either. Just this week, the Prime Minister announced that the Centre will set up fast-track courts specifically to ensure swift trial and stringent punishment in paper leak cases, calling it part of a continuing effort to safeguard the interests of the country’s youth. Accountability is being fixed. Responsibility is being assigned. This is precisely how a democratic government is expected to respond to a genuine grievance.

And it is not as if NEET was an isolated case this year. Barely a week ago, Punjab Police busted a cheating racket during the Pharmacy Officer Recruitment Examination conducted by Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, detaining 35 people including seven alleged masterminds, and recovering pen cameras and battery-operated wireless devices that candidates had allegedly paid between three lakh and thirteen lakh rupees to use. University officials have since clarified there is no evidence of an actual paper leak, that the fraud was carried out through concealed electronics during the exam itself. Even so, it is exactly the kind of exam-integrity story that a protest genuinely rooted in education would have seized upon immediately. Instead, there has been near total silence about it at Jantar Mantar. That silence tells its own story. If the movement at the heart of Delhi’s protest site was still about



exams, this would have been front and centre. It was not even mentioned. Which raises the obvious question: is this protest about students anymore, or about something else entirely wearing a student’s badge? Because what has actually been happening at Jantar Mantar since early June has very little to do with any of that.

Article 370 was abrogated by Parliament in 2019, applying the very principle of equality before law that Dr Babasaheb Ambedkar envisaged for every citizen of this country, one Constitution, one set of rights, no separate status carved out for anyone. That was integration. What is being demanded at the protest site today, under different slogans, is a return to appeasement dressed up as grievance.

“Mera Ling Meri Azaadi” has nothing whatsoever to do with a paper leak. No one in this country today stops any adult from living their life or loving whom they choose. It is worth remembering which government actually opposed the decriminalisation of Section 377 in earlier years, a colonial-era provision that criminalised consensual relations between adults and was, for decades, a tool of harassment against the LGBTQ community. It was the Supreme Court, and a government under Narendra Modi that chose not to stand in its way, that finally allowed that decriminalisation to go through in 2018. To invoke this slogan now, at a protest ostensibly about exam fairness, is opportunism, not activism.

Then there is the conduct on the ground itself. On July 20, what was billed as a students’ demonstration against the paper leak descended into stone-pelting and vandalism of police vehicles near Jantar Mantar, leaving more than a hundred police personnel injured over subsequent days, several of them bleeding from head injuries. A protester was caught on camera brandishing a brick and threatening policemen. Videos have surfaced of individuals at the site making remarks so inflammatory they do not deserve repetition here, one clip purportedly shows a participant calling for the assassination of the Prime Minister, another shows a woman mocking Lord Ram and the Ram Mandir with open contempt. Journalists covering the protest, including women reporters, have alleged being heckled and manhandled. None of this belongs anywhere near a protest about exam fairness. All

of it belongs to a script written with an entirely different purpose.

Videos have also surfaced of protesters at the site who, when asked, could not answer basic questions about the very exam they claim to be protesting over. Meanwhile, the students who are actually serious about NEET or any other competitive exam are doing exactly what serious students do after a government crackdown and a completed re-examination: they are back in their books, preparing for the next attempt, not camped out at Jantar Mantar in the Delhi heat. Let there be no confusion about this. Every citizen has the right to protest.

That right is one of the pillars of our democracy, and no column, no government and no commentator should ever wish to see it diminished. But a right to protest is not a licence to pelt stones at policemen, to threaten the life of an elected Prime Minister, to insult the faith of a billion Hindus, to vandalise a rickshaw belonging to some poor driver who had nothing to do with any exam, or to hound journalists doing their job. That is not protest. That is disorder wearing the mask of protest, and the two must never be confused with each other.

The paper leak was real, it was addressed, and the guilty are being punished. What is happening at Jantar Mantar now is a different animal altogether, and the country would do well to see it for exactly what it is.

Varun Singh is a political analyst





**TRANSGLOBE  
ADVISORS**

**Your Trusted  
Management  
Advisory**

**www.transglobeadvisors.in**



**Order Order**

**Delhi court orders framing of charges in codeine case**



A Delhi court has ordered the framing of charges against a man for the alleged illegal possession of over 4,300 kg of codeine-based cough syrup, saying the evidence raises grave suspicion against him. Special Judge Jitendra Pratap Singh said a prima facie case is made out against the accused, Vipin Chawla, under the NDPS Act.

According to the prosecution, the special cell of Delhi Police conducted a raid on June 16, 2023, at a shop in Azadpur where 302 boxes containing a total of 36,238 bottles (100 ml each) of cough syrup were recovered. It said the total weight of the seized psychotropic substance was approximately 4,312 kg, which far exceeded the "commercial quantity" limit of one kg for codeine prescribed by the Government.

In its order dated July 30, the court trashed the accused's defence that he was merely a manager at a firm called 'M/s Surya Pharma' and that the stock was being returned to the supplier following a Government ban on certain codeine combinations, and that the firm had valid licences. (PTI)

**Paper leak cases: HC transfers fast-track court special judge**



The Delhi High Court has transferred the special judge of the designated fast-track court dealing with paper leak cases, Anu Grover Baliga, along with 137 other judges.

Special judge Baliga had barely completed a week in the designated court after taking charge on July 25. Special Judge Ajay Gupta, who was initially hearing the paper leak case, including the NEET matter, will replace Judge Baliga.

Judge Baliga has been transferred to a special court under the National Investigation Agency (NIA) Act to try terror cases, according to a high court order issued on Saturday.

Other new NIA judges who will deal with terror cases are Vikas Dhull, Prashant Sharma, Pulastya Pramachala, Kiran Bansal and Amit Bansal.

Judge Baliga was appointed after the high court notified a designated court to deal with criminal cases arising from paper leaks as well as the use of other unfair means in public examinations on July 23.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had announced setting up of fast-track courts to swiftly deal with cases of paper leaks. The first hearing in the NEET paper leak case was conducted on July 27, with the proceedings adjourned at the request of the defence counsel. (PTI)

**Implement modalities of anti-ragging Bill till its finalised: Kerala HC to Govt**

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ Kochi

The Kerala High Court has asked the State Government to follow and implement the modalities prescribed under the draft anti-ragging Bill till the legislation is finalised.

A special bench of Chief Justice Soumen Sen and Justice C Jayachandran issued the direction after the court was told that the draft Bill was under active consideration and it might take some time to finalise it.

"This court is of the view that, till the finalisation of the draft Bill, the modalities prescribed under the said Bill may be followed and implemented, subject to the finalisation of the said Bill by the Legislature," the bench said.

The direction from the court came while hearing a plea moved by the State's legal services authority, KeLSA, last year seeking effective implementation of anti-ragging laws and the establishment of a mechanism to monitor instances of ragging.

KeLSA in its plea has said that ragging was "a deeply entrenched social menace that continues to plague educational institutions, causing severe psychological, emotional, and even physical harm to students."

It has claimed that despite the existence of laws, regulations, and judicial directives aimed at eradicating ragging, such incidents are occurring which highlights the presence of "significant gaps in enforcement and accountability."

KeLSA in its plea has referred to the ragging incidents in a Government nursing college in Kottayam district, another Government college at Karyavattom in Thiruvananthapuram district and a private institute in Kozhikode district.

# From Jantar Mantar to the Supreme Court: The battle for peaceful protest

**RANJIT KUMAR SINHA**

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has reached out to the nation in connection with the protests at Jantar Mantar, New Delhi. He has made appeals through social media more than once, and his messages have been published and broadcast prominently in the print and electronic media.

The Prime Minister spoke in detail about the new anti-paper leak law, along with other measures the Government is likely to undertake to make competitive examinations foolproof. He has shown magnanimity through his messages by pardoning those who used filthy, abusive language against him and his departed mother during the protest movement at Jantar Mantar and surrounding areas.

His Government at the Centre is responding judiciously before the Supreme Court, which is dealing with a batch of petitions arising out of the protest movements. Several sensitive issues are being deliberated, and the nation is keeping a close watch on those deliberations. The outcome from the apex court would carve out guidelines for the constitutional right to protest.

In contrast, the organisers of the protest movement have been stubborn, defiant, and unapologetic. Their members have been disrespectful even to the Supreme Court and have openly expressed their disagreement with the observations and directions issued by the judges.



They have also announced plans to return to the spot of the protest.

This raises the question of whether a future protest movement on the same issue will garner similar support, strength, and sympathy witnessed from July 20 onwards, prior to its withdrawal on July 25, 2026, after a 36-day agitation that began on June 20, 2026.

Since then, several developments have taken place. The Supreme Court, which was initially cautious, has undertaken a few hearings and issued significant directions. This judicial intervention has now taken a crucial step forward.

Beyond the initial petitions, the deliberations in the apex court have assumed a new dimension with family members of injured police and paramilitary personnel entering the legal proceedings to demand justice and oppose any unilateral move to withdraw FIRs registered against errant protesters. This move served to check the momentum with which the organisers of the protest movement were forwarding their narratives unhesitatingly.

Further, a significant de-escalation occurred when prominent Ladakh-based education and climate activist Sonam Wangchuk officially called off his 26-day indefinite hunger strike on July 23. Following assurances conveyed by Union Ministers regarding student grievances and examinations, Wangchuk broke his fast, removing a major flashpoint that had heavily charged the emotional momentum of the agitation.

With Wangchuk having effectively stepped back from the agitation, some activists are trying to keep the momentum going, but they have not been as successful in gaining his level of credibility. Furthermore, none of them have acknowledged or spoken about the negative aspects of the protest movement. Now, it appears that the battleground has shifted from the streets of Jantar Mantar to the

Supreme Court. The legal arena is now where the most important decisions will be made. The apex court has a heavy responsibility on its shoulders. It has to balance two vital needs of a healthy democracy.

First, it must protect every citizen's constitutional right to peaceful protest and free expression. Second, it must ensure public safety, the rule of law, and fairness to the police officers who were injured while doing their duty.

How the court resolves these questions will set a crucial rulebook for the future. It will show the nation how peaceful dissent and lawful governance can coexist without sliding into chaos.

To achieve this, the Supreme Court is looking into several major steps. It is considering setting up an independent, high-powered team to investigate complaints of police heavy-handedness.

At the same time, it is examining how crowd control is handled to protect the safety of everyone involved. The court is also reviewing violence directed against security personnel to ensure that accountability applies equally to all sides. Ultimately, these hearings aim to create clear, nationwide guidelines that keep public spaces safe while respecting the voice of the people. In this context, it becomes crucial to examine the dual track adopted by the protest leadership throughout these proceedings.

This strategic approach exposes a sharp paradox. Rather than allowing the judicial process to run its course, public statements outside the courtroom continued to challenge the institutional authority of the very bench examining their grievances. On one hand, they ask the highest court in the land to protect their constitutional rights. On the other hand, attempting to pressure the court through outside hostility undermines the integrity of their own legal petitions.

Such confrontational tactics severely damage their standing as serious and responsible stakeholders in a constitutional democracy.

A legitimate struggle cannot maintain credibility when legal arguments inside the courtroom are coupled with street-level attacks against the bench outside.

Ultimately, abandoning judicial decorum does not strengthen a movement; it weakens its legal foundation and alienates the broader public.

This stance carries a high cost, causing ordinary citizens to lose confidence. These are the very people who sacrificed their time and energy to march to Jantar Mantar in genuine solidarity.

When organisers act with defiance instead of responsibility, everyday citizens feel let down. This disappointment has a lasting impact. It makes people hesitant to join future protest movements, even when the issues and demands are entirely genuine.

Citizens become wary of investing their time and energy if protests are hijacked by aggressive defiance rather than constructive dialogue. If public trust completely breaks down, the vital democratic right to protest risks being hollowed out. Instead of being a living, breathing tool for positive change, it could remain trapped solely in textbooks and academic debates.

The writer is a senior journalist covering legal affairs

## Delhi HC protects personality rights of cricketer Yuvraj Singh

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has protected the personality rights of cricketer Yuvraj Singh and restrained the unauthorised use of his name, image, etc, by third parties for commercial or personal gain, including the sale of merchandise and creation of AI-generated or deepfake content.

Justice Jyoti Singh, in an interim order passed on the sportsman's lawsuit, said Yuvraj is one of the most decorated, recognised and globally renowned cricketers, who represented the country across all formats of the sport for 17 years, and those violating his personality and privacy rights needed to be "dealt with a heavy hand".

In the order passed on July 29, Justice Singh protected the exploitation or misappropriation of the name 'Yuvraj Singh' as well as 'Yuvi', along with the image, voice, likeness, and any other personality attributes of the cricketer.

Yuvraj contended that besides the unauthorised sale of merchandise bearing his personality attributes, several social media accounts were publishing and disseminating AI-generated



images and videos, purportedly showing him in fabricated and fictional scenarios which were damaging his reputation and goodwill.

The objectionable content included religiously insensitive posts, videos showing aggressive and violent behaviour towards another cricketers, and posts with vulgar and abusive language, his counsel told the court.

Directing Meta Platforms and other online platforms to remove the offending content, the court observed, "There can be no dispute that plaintiff's stature inherently grants him proprietary rights over his personality and associated attributes and gives him the exclusive rights to use the personality attributes for commercial purposes and consequently, the right to protect various attributes of his persona from unauthorised use or exploitation by third-parties."

"The contents of the impugned AI-generated posts and deep fake videos are tarnishing the immense goodwill and reputation of the plaintiff, garnered over the years with hard work and stellar performances in the field of cricket as well as his contribution to social welfare and lowering his image and standing in the eyes of the public," the court concluded.

Several public figures, like actors Aishwarya Rai Bachchan, Abhishek Bachchan and Salman Khan, Art of Living founder Sri Sri Ravi Shankar, journalist Sudhir Chaudhary have previously approached the high court seeking protection of their personality and publicity rights.

## Protests over paper leaks: SC to hear on Monday pleas relating to police action

**PIONEER NEWS SERVICE**  
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a batch of pleas alleging police brutality during the recent protests against irregularities in exams and the NEET paper leaks.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana will be hearing the pleas in which the court had indicated that it might constitute an SIT headed by a former Supreme Court judge for a probe into the allegations made by protestors, pellet gun victims and to ascertain whether the attacks on policemen were carried out by students or some "miscreants".

On July 28, the top court had restrained states from taking any coercive action against protesters and directed them to release those under 18 on the condition that none should have any criminal antecedents.

The top court had observed that a fair and independent probe in the matter was required and whosoever committed excesses, took law into their hands should be taken to task.

It had directed, "All states are hereby instructed to



release children under the age of 18, who have been reported to be arrested or detained in connection with the ongoing protests and who do not possess any criminal antecedents."

The top court had said if necessary, these children shall be released upon the execution of a simple bond by themselves or their family members, especially if such a requirement is insisted upon for surety.

It had taken note of allegations such as the use of pellet guns, lathis embedded with nails, rubber bullets and electric batons on protestors resulting in severe life threatening injuries to several students and young women.

The top court had directed that Delhi Government and other states may proceed with the investigation of the FIRs registered but no coercive measures shall be taken against the

protesting students. "Such protection, nonetheless, shall not be extended to the persons with criminal antecedents," it had clarified.

Noting that the bench is mulling an independent, a transparent and thorough probe into all allegations by a task force, the bench had said a probe is also required to ascertain the attacks on policemen and whether they were by students or some "miscreants".

"Be that as it may, the allegations made by the petitioners, prima facie, establish a compelling case for an independent and impartial investigation into the incidents of violence. Such an investigation will adequately address the allegations presented by the family members of the police personnel, as well as the issues raised by the Solicitor General of India," it had said.

## 158 CBI cases related to examination irregularities awaiting trial in courts

**ABHISHEK SHUKLA**  
■ New Delhi

Around 158 cases linked to alleged recruitment examination irregularities are awaiting the start of trial in various courts in the country despite the completion of CBI investigations, with some of them registered more than two decades ago, sources said.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has decided to approach all high courts to transfer these pending cases to the fast-track courts, which are being set up in various states to handle cases under the new anti-paper leak law, they said.

Sources said the CBI has decided to convey to the high courts that it will provide dedicated special prosecutors to conduct these trials and make all possible resources available so that they are concluded at the earliest possible.

In the national capital Delhi, there are around 25



cases since 2000 that are awaiting trial despite the completion of CBI investigation. These include the AIIMS PG recruitment examination of 2010-11, Delhi University Medical and Dental Entrance of 2011, CAT (common admission test) irregularities of 2004, SSC (staff selection commission) recruitment of 2013, and teachers' recruitment, sources said.

Bihar has five pending cases, including three

related to the alleged paper leak of NEET 2024, besides irregularities in the PMT (pre-medical test) of 2003 and 2011, they said.

In Himachal Pradesh, the constable recruitment case of 2022 is among the three cases awaiting start of trial. In Jammu and Kashmir, three cases are awaiting trial, which include irregularities in junior engineer and constable recruitment, they said.

Similarly, five cases are awaiting trial in Jharkhand;

five in Karnataka; three in Maharashtra, including two cases related to NEET 2024; eight in Rajasthan; 14 in Tamil Nadu; and 10 each in West Bengal and Uttar Pradesh.

Government officials argue that prolonged delays severely erode the prospect of successful prosecution. As years pass, witnesses become elderly or unavailable, memories fade, identification of the accused becomes increasingly difficult, and testimonies often change, they said.

Frequent transfers of investigating officers, prosecutors and even presiding judges further complicate proceedings, raising the risk that some of the country's examination fraud prosecutions could eventually collapse.

The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Act, 2026, recently passed by Parliament, provides for every state and Union Territory to designate a

sessions court as a Special Fast-Track Court, in consultation with the Chief Justice of the high court concerned.

The law provides for these fast-track courts to hear cases day-to-day without unnecessary breaks, the trial to be completed within three months of the charge sheet being filed, and the cases already pending in other courts to be transferred to these new Special Fast-Track Courts, which are to be completed within three months of transfer.

Every state and Union Territory will also appoint special public prosecutors dedicated to arguing these cases.

"If an accused also faces other connected charges under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita or any other law, the Special Fast-Track Court will try those charges together in the same trial, instead of sending the case to multiple courts," a recent Government statement had said. (PTI)



# Beyond the Vedas: Reimagining Civic Responsibility for Modern Times

Civic sense may be broadly understood as social ethics. It comprises inherent discipline and a sense of responsibility that citizens must possess for fellow human beings as well as their country. It unequivocally forms the foundation of national development and progress. India at present is poised to become a world leader with prominent economic growth, rapid infrastructure expansion, and an increasing global presence. However, the next quantum leap will be hastened by bringing about a transformation in the behaviour and attitudes of people with regard to civic responsibility. There are modern laws and institutions which regulate behaviour but they cannot create trust, empathy or self-restraint that comes from within and can be described as “civic spirituality”, which means, the consciousness that “I am part of a larger whole - a city, a nation, humanity - and my actions must reflect responsibility, compassion and integrity towards that whole”. It is, thus, a bridge between “inner values” and “outer citizenship”. It can also be termed as ‘ethical discipline’.

The idea of ethical discipline embedded within the Buddhist and Jain philosophy can be appropriated to inculcate civic consciousness among Indian citizens. These ancient affirmations can effectively play a positive role in cultivating integrity in people. Ethical discipline transforms civic duties from forced legal obligations into deeply held personal convictions. When we practice ethical discipline, we inadvertently align our daily actions with moral principles like fairness, integrity, and accountability, even without supervision. This self-consciousness naturally makes one a more conscientious member of the community and country. Its dimensions include: (1) duty beyond self (*Kartavya*), (2) empathy and compassion (*Karuna*), (3) integrity and truth (*Satya and Ritam*), sense of belonging (*Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam*) and (5) equanimity and restraint.

The sixth century BCE in India witnessed the emergence of heterodox sects like Jainism and Buddhism, which challenged ritual authority and varna-based prescriptions. Their rigorous debates concerning nonviolence, karma, and renunciation enriched the existing discourse, pluralizing what counted as righteous conduct.

The Buddhist *pancha-shila* and the Jain *anuvrata* are important concepts, both of which translate moral discipline into everyday conduct. Their continuing importance lies not only in personal salvation within the religious domain, but also in the cultivation of citizens capable of trust, restraint, and responsibility. These traditions offer a compelling moral basis for civic duty in the contemporary milieu.

The Buddhist *pancha-shila*, or five precepts, are the basic ethical commitments expected of lay Buddhists- non-monastic practitioners who form the majority of the Buddhist community. These include,



**JUSTICE AK SIKRI**  
FORMER JUDGE,  
SUPREME COURT  
OF INDIA



**Dr. PRACHI SHARMA**  
SENIOR RESEARCH  
FELLOW, BHARAT  
KI SOCH

abstaining from killing of living beings, not taking what is not given, refraining from sexual misconduct, abstaining from false speech, and abstaining from intoxicants.

The significance of these tenets transcends the ambit of personal virtues. Each precept possesses a public dimension. Abstention from killing translates into respect for life, empathy for fellow humans and rejection of cruelty; not stealing results in honesty in dealing with common resources; not lying turns into defense of truthful public discourse; and avoiding intoxicants ensures responsible conduct. In the context of society, the five foundational ethical principles outline the personal self-control needed to foster mutual trust among citizens.

न हि वेरेन वेरानि, सम्मत्तीघ कुदाचनं।  
अवेरेन च सम्मन्ति, एस धम्मो सनन्तनो॥  
(*Dhammapada, verse 5, Khuddaka Nikaya*)

Hatred is never appeased by hatred in this world. By non-hatred alone is hatred appeased. This is a law eternal.

Within the Jain framework, the *anuvrata*, or “small vows,” serve a similar role for lay followers. These are moderate forms of the great vows (*mahavratas*) and include abstinence from violence, falsehood, and stealing, along with contentment with one's own wife and limiting one's possessions. The primary moral imperative here is restraint. Jain ethics do not regard desire as benign. Unbridled want is seen to have the potential to produce harm, possessiveness, and exploitation. In a civic society, such restraint is remarkably pertinent because public life depends on an individual's ability to restrict self-interest for the larger common good.

जो सहस्सं सहस्साणं, संगामे दुज्जयं जिणे।  
एकं जिणेज्ज अप्पाणं, एष से परमो जिओ॥  
(*Uttaradhyayana sutra 9.34*)

One may conquer thousands of un-conquerable enemies in battle; but he who conquers his single self wins the ultimate victory.

The Buddhist and Jain traditions converge on the same principle, namely, that a disciplined population forms the building blocks of a good society. We often find civic duties couched in legal language such as following the law, paying taxes, safeguarding public property, and respecting others' rights. However, law on its own is not sufficient to sustain a robust nation. If citizens lie uninhibitedly, exploit resources without thinking, or engage in aggressive behaviour, institutions weaken from within. The Buddhist emphasis on right speech and the Jain emphasis on truthfulness both suggest that truthful speech is indispensable for civic order.

This is precisely why these ethical concepts resonate strongly in the current climate. High rates of crime is not the only factor that threatens modern civil life. It is also endangered by indifference, misinformation, excessive consumption, and the erosion of responsibility. The precept against false speech is especially important in the age of social media, where rumours and deliberate distortions tend to spread faster than facts. They can prove to be especially detrimental in the field of health and wellness, where incorrect information on diets, medicines and treatment of diseases can lead to serious harm to gullible people who follow these advices without verifying.

In a similar vein, the vow against not taking what is not given speaks to corruption, bribery, and misuse of public assets. The Jain principle of *aparigraha* or limiting possessions is tremendously relevant in an epoch where consumerism is eclipsing rationality, leading to environmental strain. Both traditions drive home the fact that civic failure often begins with everyday moral neglect.

The importance of Buddhist and Jain precepts extends into fostering social harmony. Civic duty is not simply limited to exhibiting obedience to law. It is care for coexistence and consideration for fellow human beings. The *pancha-shila* and *anuvrata* encourage kindness, self-restraint, and truthfulness, which are the values needed in diverse societies. India's plural public life depends on people who can disagree without harbouring hatred, pursue ambition without exploiting the vulnerable, and seek progress while maintaining ethical balance.

It is crucial to note that these principles should not be understood as being restrictive in a negative sense. They are enabling. Imbibing these would facilitate smoother societal conditions in which cooperation between people would be greatly enhanced. Civic duty is then not a burden imposed from outside but a form of moral participation. The state can enforce rules, but it cannot build character. Our ancient traditions can achieve that by shaping conscience and thereby conduct. This makes *pancha-shila* and *anuvrata* especially valuable in education, community life, and public service.

## Fable with Moral

### Bhasmasura



The story of Bhasmasura is a popular Indian mythological tale deeply engrained in Indian oral traditions and regional literature that cautions us about the dangers of unbridled ego, greed, and the misuse of power. It appears with slight variations in the Bhagavat Purana, Shiva Purana and the Sthala puranas.

Bhasmasura was a powerful demon who performed intense penance to please Lord Shiva. Satisfied with his devotion, Shiva appeared and granted him a boon. Bhasmasura asked for immortality, but since that was against the laws of nature, Shiva refused. Instead, the demon asked for a unique power- anyone whose head he touched with his hand should immediately burn to ashes. Shiva granted the boon.

Driven by arrogance and malicious intent, Bhasmasura decided to test the power on Shiva himself to take over the universe and possess Shiva's wife, Goddess Parvati. Terrified and threatened by the demon's pursuit, Shiva fled and sought help from Lord Vishnu, the preserver of the universe.

Vishnu formulated a clever plan to trick the demon. He transformed himself into Mohini, an exquisitely beautiful dancer. When Bhasmasura saw Mohini, he was completely enchanted by her beauty and forgot about his ambition of capturing Shiva. He persuaded Mohini to marry him. Mohini agreed, but on one condition, that Bhasmasura had to match her dance moves with precision.

Blinded by lust and ego, Bhasmasura eagerly agreed. As they danced, Mohini performed intricate steps, and the demon copied each one flawlessly. Eventually, Mohini struck a pose where she placed her hand on her own head. Without thinking, Bhasmasura mirrored the gesture and placed his hand on his own head. The deadly boon instantly triggered, and the demon was reduced to a heap of ashes.

**Moral of the Fable**  
Conquer your inner arrogance before it transforms into a force of self-destruction.

## Did you know?

**Did You Know Kautilya Treated Roads, Wells and Traveller Safety as Administrative Duties?**

In the *Arthashastra*, the safety and maintenance of travel routes was assigned to *Vivatadhyaksa* or the Superintendent of Pasture Lands. However, his responsibilities extended beyond managing grazing areas. He was expected to examine travellers' passes, maintain roads, watch over wilderness routes, arrest thieves and ensure the safety of mercantile traffic.

The text directs that pasture grounds should be opened between dangerous places and that valleys should be cleared of threats posed by thieves, wild elephants and other animals. The superintendent was also charged with protecting timber forests, elephant forests and cattle while keeping commercial routes operational. The *Arthashastra* also refers to *prapas*, places where water was supplied freely to travellers, as



recognised features of the administrative landscape. Roads, irrigation works, feeding houses, pasture grounds and public water points were to be identified and recorded while village and territorial boundaries were being established.

From a governance perspective, the arrangement linked infrastructure, policing, communication and economic policy. The *Arthashastra* recognised that secure mobility encouraged trade, protected state revenues and connected distant parts of the kingdom.

### UNJUMBLE

1. Unjumble these scrambled words to form the terms often used in the governance of Ancient India:

MTAAAY

HUTIROP

GARAM

YAJAR

2. Arrange the circled letters to answer the following:

The Supreme Ruler: \_\_\_\_\_



Answer: 1. Amshya, Purncha, Gama, Rajya; 2. Maharaja

## Marvels of India

### THE ASHOKAN EDICTS

A Marvel of Effective and Efficient Communication

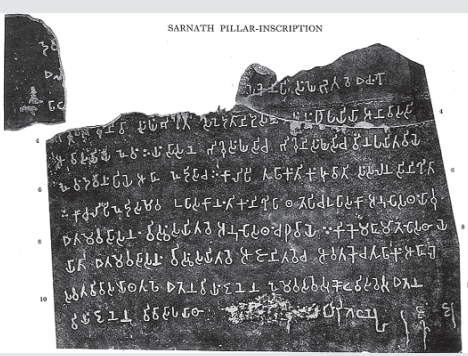
The Mauryan emperor Ashoka used inscriptions on rocks and pillars as his primary instrument of statecraft. These proclamations communicated his policies, administrative instructions and ethical teachings directly to the masses, mostly in Prakrit, using the Brahmi script so that ordinary subjects could understand them. These were strategically placed along trade routes, near borders and at administrative centres to unify a vast, diverse empire through moral governance.

**Institutionalising Welfare**

Rock Edicts III and IV show Ashoka consulting his council of ministers on both routine and emergency matters. At the same time, officials called *Mahamattas* were tasked with promoting his moral order/norm/code of conduct or his socio-cultural policy termed *Dhamma*, overseeing administration and safeguarding the frontier provinces. Other edicts detail administrative measures to improve public benevolence, healthcare, general wellbeing of the populace etc.

**An Enduring Governance Model**

Some historians call this “conquest by *Dhamma*”, i.e., rule sustained through good administration and paternal concern for subjects, rather than force, making Ashokan inscriptions among human history's earliest documented royal orders creating and shaping a form of governance that was anchored in and driven from *Dharma* (righteous and just behaviour).



| QUIZ Governance                            |                                                                                                                                            |                                              |                               |                              |                               |
|--------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------|------------------------------|-------------------------------|
|                                            | Questions                                                                                                                                  | Option A                                     | Option B                      | Option C                     | Option D                      |
| 1                                          | How were the Paiks who provided specialized non-manual services (such as artisans, clerks, scribes) classified in the Ahom administration? | Chamua                                       | Kanri                         | Likson                       | Got                           |
| 2                                          | Which feature was common to both the Kushan and Saka administrations?                                                                      | Provinces under military governors (Satraps) | Hereditary joint rule         | Divine theory of kingship    | A, B & C                      |
| 3                                          | Which earlier empire's governance structure heavily influenced the Satavahana dynasty?                                                     | Chola                                        | Mauryan                       | Gupta                        | Kushan                        |
| 4                                          | What was special about Gopala I from the Pala dynasty coming to power during extreme political chaos around modern-day Bengal?             | Appointment by Buddhist monks                | Capture through military coup | Election by political elites | Selection by a Vardhana ruler |
| 5                                          | Which of these queens from Kannauj (U.P.) took active steps to maintain India-China cultural ties?                                         | Prabhavati-gupta                             | Dattadevi                     | Kumaradevi                   | Didda                         |
| Answers: 1 - A, 2 - D, 3 - B, 4 - C, 5 - C |                                                                                                                                            |                                              |                               |                              |                               |

## नेट-वोर्क

### The SIBI Jataka

1 **DISCOVERY OF THE AJANTA PAINTINGS**

A GROUP OF STUDENTS VISIT AJANTA CAVES AND ADMIRE THE ANCIENT PAINTINGS.

2 **THE TEACHER EXPLAINS JĀTAKAS**

THE TEACHER EXPLAINS THAT JĀTAKAS ARE STORIES OF BUDDHA'S PREVIOUS BIRTHS WHICH TEACH HIGH VALUES AND SELFLESS DEEDS.

3 **KING SIBI – A GENEROUS RULER**

KING SIBI WAS BELOVED BY HIS PEOPLE. HE ALWAYS HELPED THE POOR AND CARED FOR EVERYONE'S WELFARE.

4 **THE KING'S REFLECTION**

CAN I GIVE EVEN MY OWN BODY FOR THE WELFARE OF OTHERS?

THE KING'S RELECTION

5 **THE DIVINE TEST**

O KING! GIVE ME ONE EYE.

DISGUISED AS A BLIND BEGGAR (SAKRA), THE GOD KING INDRA ASKED KING SIBI FOR ONE OF HIS EYES.

6 **THE SUPREME SACRIFICE**

WITHOUT HESITATION, KING SIBI OFFERED BOTH HIS EYES TO THE BEGGAR, SAYING THAT HIS VOW TO HELP THE DISTRESSED IS ABOVE EVERYTHING.

7 **REVELATION OF SAKRA**

SAKRA REVEALED HIS TRUE FORM AND RESTORED THE KING'S EYES. HE PRAISED KING SIBI'S COURAGE, COMPASSION AND SELFLESS SACRIFICE.

8 **BLESSING AND THE MORAL**

THE KING WAS BLESSED WITH GREAT VISION AND WISDOM. TRUE WELTH LIES IN GIVING, NOT IN KEEPING. THERE IS NO HAPPINESS EQUAL TO SACRIFICE.

**MORAL OF THE STORY:** There is no happiness equal to sacrifice

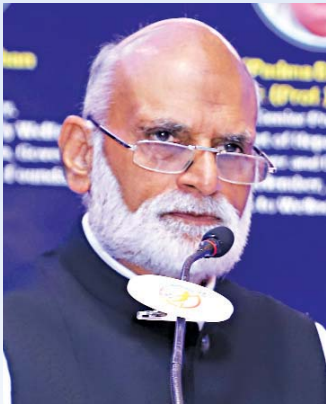


# EXPERTS ADVOCATE WIDER SCREENING, ADULT IMMUNISATION AND MATERNAL CARE TO SUPPORT HEPATITIS ELIMINATION GOALS

EXPERTS ADVOCATE A PREVENTION-FIRST APPROACH, EMPHASISING EARLY DIAGNOSIS, EQUITABLE TREATMENT AND STRONGER MATERNAL HEALTHCARE



**Mr. Rajesh Bhushan,**  
Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India, and Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation



**Mr. Anil Rajput,**  
Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation



**Dr. Anil Agarwal,**  
Co-chairman, Institute of Surgical Gastroenterology, Sir Ganga Ram Hospital



**Dr. Asha Hegde,**  
Director South Asia - HIV/Hepatitis/STIs and Family Health, PATH India



**Dr. Suneela Garg,**  
Member, FICCI Swasth Bharat Task Force



**Dr. R. S. Mishra,**  
Principal Director & Head - Internal Medicine, Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket



**Dr. (Prof.) S. K. Sarin,**  
Senior Professor, Department of Hepatology & Director, ILBS

India has the knowledge, vaccines, diagnostics and treatments needed to eliminate viral hepatitis as a public health threat. The next challenge is ensuring that these lifesaving interventions reach every individual from expectant mothers and newborns to high-risk adults through universal screening, adult immunisation, stronger maternal healthcare, early diagnosis and equitable access to treatment, leading policymakers, hepatologists and public health experts said at the second edition of the Illness to Wellness Foundation's conference on "Prevention, Diagnosis and Treatment for Hepatitis," organised on the occasion of World Hepatitis Day 2026.

Delivering the keynote address, Mr. Rajesh Bhushan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India, and Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said, "India has made meaningful progress through the National Viral Hepatitis Control Programme, but achieving greater impact will require stronger collaboration across stakeholders. Government, healthcare institutions, the private sector, civil society and development partners must work together to expand the reach of hepatitis services and ensure that quality care is available to every community. A well-integrated, partnership-driven approach will be key to building a stronger and more inclusive public health response."

Highlighting India's progress in hepatitis prevention while outlining the next phase of the country's response, Padma Bhushan Dr. (Prof.) S. K. Sarin, Senior Professor, Department of Hepatology & Director, ILBS, emphasised, "India's next priority must be to expand adult hepatitis B immunisation, encourage early diagnosis, eliminate stigma and ensure timely treatment for every patient."

Preventing hepatitis is no longer only about scientific progress-it is about reaching every individual with the care they need, so that no one is left behind in India's journey towards eliminating viral hepatitis."

Delivering the welcome address, Mr. Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, asserted, "We believe that success demands a whole-of-society approach. Governments, healthcare professionals, researchers, industry, civil society, the media and citizens all have vital roles to play. Public health succeeds not through isolated efforts but through partnerships that place prevention at the heart of national development. The Illness to Wellness Foundation remains committed to advancing this movement through awareness, evidence-based dialogue and collaborative action. Our aspiration is simple yet ambitious-to make wellness the first line of defence and prevention the first principle of healthcare."

Highlighting the importance of maternal health in hepatitis elimination, Dr. Asha Hegde, Director South Asia - HIV/Hepatitis/STIs and Family Health, PATH India, said, "Today, the challenge is no longer the absence of scientific solutions-we already have effective vac-



L to R: Dr. Gargi Agarwal, Associate Professor & Senior Consultant, Amrita Hospital; Dr. Rahul Manchanda, Hon. Senior Consultant (Endoscopic Gynaecology), PSRI Hospital; Dr. (Prof.) Kamna Datta, Dept of Obstetrics and Gynaecology, ABVIMS & Dr RML Hospital and Dr. Bhavana Malhotra, Sr. Consultant, Dept of Paediatrics & Neonatology, Felix Hospital



L to R: Dr. K Madan Gopal, Senior Health Sector Expert, Former Senior Consultant Health, NITI Aayog; Dr. Manoj Gupta, Sr Director & Head- Department of Robotic & Laparoscopic GI Surgery, Yatharth Super Speciality Hospital; Dr. Kapil Dev Jamwal, Chief - Innovation & GI Interventions, Artemis Hospital; Dr. Anita Shete-Aich, Scientist-E, Hepatitis Group, ICMR-National Institute of Virology (NIV), Pune and Dr. (Prof.) Jugal Kishore, Director, Department-Community Medicine, VMMC & Safdarjung Hospital, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare



L to R: Dr. Shabana Parveen, Clinical Nutrition & Dietetics Department, Artemis Hospital; Ms. Ishi Khosla, Chief Nutritionist, Founder, Celiac Society of India; Dr. Rajesh Kesari, Member, National Executive Committee - Elect, RSSDI; Dr. Shikha Sharma, Scientific Mentor, Ranfort Wellness and Dr. Kalpana Bhamini Sehra, Senior Ayurvedic Doctor, MD - Internal Medicine, Maharishi Ayurveda Hospital

## 'WOMEN'S HEALTH AND HEPATITIS: PREVENTION, MATERNAL CARE, AND ELIMINATING MOTHER-TO-CHILD TRANSMISSION', FOCUSED ON UNIVERSAL SCREENING DURING PREGNANCY, PREVENTION OF MOTHER-TO-CHILD TRANSMISSION, BIRTH-DOSE HEPATITIS B VACCINATION AND INTEGRATING HEPATITIS SCREENING INTO MATERNAL HEALTHCARE SERVICES

cines, accurate diagnostics and highly effective therapies. The real challenge lies in delivering these interventions consistently, equitably and at scale. Every pregnancy should be an opportunity to prevent hepatitis transmission, every birth should be protected, and every child should have the opportunity to grow up free from hepatitis. Achieving this will require stronger integration of healthcare services and collective action across all stakeholders."

Addressing the gathering, Dr. R. S. Mishra, Principal Director & Head - Internal Medicine, Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket,

underlined, "Hepatitis often progresses silently, making awareness and timely action critical. Along with strengthening healthcare systems, we must empower people to seek testing without fear or stigma and ensure that quality care is accessible to everyone who needs it."

Providing a clinical perspective, Dr. Anil Agarwal, Co-chairman, Institute of Surgical Gastroenterology, Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, said, "India has made remarkable progress in hepatitis care, but sustained success will depend on greater adult immunisation, stronger patient awareness and ensuring con-

tinuity of care. Our collective effort must be to translate medical advances into better health outcomes for every patient."

Providing insights into advances and challenges in hepatitis diagnostics, Dr. Anita Shete-Aich, Scientist-E, Hepatitis Group, ICMR-National Institute of Virology (NIV), Pune, emphasised, "Early and accurate diagnosis remains the cornerstone of hepatitis elimination. Strengthening screening, expanding access to quality diagnostics and integrating molecular testing wherever appropriate will enable timely treatment, improve surveillance and support India's goal of eliminating viral

hepatitis by 2030."

The conference featured three thematic technical sessions that examined critical dimensions of hepatitis prevention and management across the continuum of care. The inaugural session was followed by three panel discussions that explored different aspects of hepatitis prevention, diagnosis, treatment and long-term care.

The first panel discussion, "Women's Health and Hepatitis: Prevention, Maternal Care, and Eliminating Mother-to-Child Transmission", focused on universal screening during pregnancy, prevention of mother-to-child transmission, birth-dose hepatitis B vaccination and integrating hepatitis screening into maternal healthcare services. Moderated by Dr. Rahul Manchanda, the panel featured Dr. Gargi Agarwal, Dr. (Prof.) Kamna Datta and Dr. Bhavana Malhotra, who highlighted strategies to strengthen maternal and newborn care and eliminate vertical transmission of hepatitis.

The second panel discussion, "Integrated Approaches to Viral Hepatitis Prevention: Vaccination, Awareness, Screening, and Early Intervention", explored strategies to expand vaccination coverage, strengthen community awareness, improve screening programmes, enhance infection prevention and leverage digital health technologies and public-private partnerships to improve hepatitis prevention and patient care. Moderated by Dr. Kapil Dev Jamwal, the session featured a special presentation by Dr. Anita Shete-Aich, followed by an engaging discussion with Dr. Manoj Gupta, Dr. (Prof.) Jugal Kishore and Dr. K. Madan Gopal on strengthening collaborative approaches to hepatitis elimination.

The third panel discussion, "From Prevention to Wellness: The Role of Nutrition and Diet in Hepatitis Care", underscored the importance of nutrition and healthy lifestyle interventions in supporting liver health and improving treatment outcomes. Moderated by Dr. Rajesh Kesari, the panel brought together Ms. Ishi Khosla, Dr. Shikha Sharma, Dr. Shabana Parveen and Dr. Kalpana Bhamini Sehra, who emphasised personalised nutrition, dietary counselling and community education as integral components of comprehensive hepatitis care and long-term wellness.

Delivering the concluding remarks, Dr. Suneela Garg, Member, FICCI Swasth Bharat Task Force, emphasised that eliminating viral hepatitis would require a whole-of-society approach, with sustained public awareness, timely vaccination, stronger preventive healthcare, reduced stigma and coordinated action across government, healthcare institutions, academia, civil society and communities to accelerate progress towards the WHO's 2030 elimination goal.

The experts collectively underscored that eliminating viral hepatitis is an achievable goal for India. They called for sustained investments in preventive healthcare, universal screening, adult immunisation, maternal and child health interventions, timely diagnosis, equitable access to treatment and stronger public awareness to translate scientific advances into improved health outcomes and achieve the World Health Organization's 2030 elimination target.





FROM THE WORLD

CHINA

Four killed in apartment fire

Four people were killed and two others injured after a fire broke out at an apartment building in Changsha, Capital of central China's Hunan Province, local firefighting authorities said on Sunday.

The blaze erupted at 3.54 am Saturday.

Firefighters rescued the six people from the high-rise residential building and sent them to hospital for treatment. Four of them later died despite medical efforts, while the remaining two are still receiving medical treatment, State-run Xinhua news agency reported.

An investigation into the cause of the fire is currently underway, it said. (PTI)

US

Restaurant shooting: 3 dead

Three people were killed and seven more were injured, some critically, in a shooting at an In-N-Out Burger restaurant in southern Idaho on Saturday afternoon, a Twin Falls city spokesman said.

Police who responded to the shooting found the body of the suspected gunman in an area near the restaurant, Twin Falls city public information officer Josh Palmer said. He did not know if the suspect was included in the fatality count. Officials were still working on notifying the family members of victims and so were not yet releasing the names, ages or other details about the people hurt in the shooting, Palmer said. Some of the people injured are in critical condition, Palmer said.

Police were still trying to determine the shooter's identity and motive. (AP)

Trump halts strikes on Iran

AAMER MADHANI/SAMY MAGDY  
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump says he will order American forces to hold off on new strikes against Iran, claiming Mideast allies have reached the parameters of a deal to end the 5-month-old war.

The emerging deal "would include the Immediate, Complete, and Total OPENING OF THE HORMUZ STRAIT, and an end to Iran's nuclear threat," Trump wrote in a Saturday evening social media post.

"Based on this request, I have agreed, for the future benefit of the WORLD and, likewise, the survival of a successful and prosperous Iran, to cancel the attack, subject to being able to rapidly make a DEAL," Trump said.

Trump has announced halts to strikes in Iran on several occasions since the US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, only for things to unravel and fighting to resume again.

Iran's defence minister said on X that the country was "neither surprised nor



passive" following Trump's announcement and said Iran continues to remain alert in the face of concrete threats from the US.

A regional official says the proposal announced by Trump over the weekend calls for the US and Iran to return to negotiations and continue working out many of the issues that have stymied prior progress on the deal.

The official, who is involved in the mediation efforts, said the proposal calls for reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and halting attacks across the region, including by Iranian-backed militias in Iraq on the Arab Gulf countries and Jordan.

The US, in exchange, will end its naval blockade on Iran and allow Tehran to export its oil as stated in the tentative ceasefire deal, he said.

No deal has been reached yet, but mediation efforts are underway, said the official, who spoke on condition of anonymity because he wasn't authorised to talk to the media.

Trump said that Israel is joining his commitment to end the war by implementing the ceasefire deal. Israel did not publicly comment on the announcement.

Saudi Crown Prince

Mohammed bin Salman, the kingdom's de facto leader, spoke with Trump by phone Saturday and raised concerns about the US potentially escalating the conflict with Iran, according to the Saudi press agency.

The Saudis, according to the person briefed on the substance of the call but not authorised to comment publicly, are concerned that Tehran could respond with attacks on the energy infrastructure of the kingdom and other Gulf countries. The call happened before Trump's social media announcement, the person said.

The crown prince sought clarity from Trump on what potential new action he was weighing to take against Iran, the person said. A White House official, who was not authorised to comment publicly and requested anonymity, confirmed the leaders spoke on Saturday but did not offer any detail.

Iran has repeatedly attacked vessels attempting to transit through the Strait of Hormuz without its authorisation as part of its ongoing conflict with the US. (AP)

Curfew relaxed in southern Nepal as situation improves after communal clashes

SHIRISH B PRADHAN  
■ Kathmandu

Nepalese authorities on Sunday relaxed the curfew imposed in various parts of Madhesh Province in southern Nepal and Koshi Province in eastern Nepal as the security situation improved days after communal violence rocked the region.

Three people have been killed in communal violence in Nepal that started after clashes erupted in Sunsari district bordering India in Koshi Province, prompting authorities to impose curfews, prohibitory orders and step up security deployment.

The violence broke out after members of the two communities, who were holding separate programmes, clashed over the use of loudspeakers and the display of religious flags on July 26. The violence soon spread to neighbouring



areas. Authorities said that two people were killed in Sunsari district and one in Siraha district.

The curfew has been removed, and only prohibitory orders are in effect in two areas of Saptari district, including Rajbiraj Municipality, taking into consideration the improved security situation, said Naresh Kumar Yadav, assistant chief district officer of Saptari district.

Similarly, in Dhanusha, curfew orders have been

Ruling BNP authorises PM Rahman to finalise nominee for Bangladesh's presidential elections

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Dhaka

The ruling Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) has authorised Prime Minister Tarique Rahman to select the party's candidate for the country's presidential elections, local media reported.

The decision was taken on Saturday at BNP's National Standing Committee's meeting, the Dhaka Tribune newspaper reported.

The meeting was headed by PM Rahman, who is also the BNP chairman.

"The Standing Committee has entrusted Prime Minister and BNP Chairman to take necessary decisions regarding presidential election and select the party's nominee," state-owned Bangladesh Sangbad Sangstha quoted BNP Secretary General Mirza Fakhru'l Islam Alamgir as saying.



Speaker Hafiz Uddin Ahmad took charge as the acting president after Mohammed Shahabuddin resigned on July 24.

According to Article 123(2) of the Constitution, an election to fill the vacant office of the president must be held

within 90 days of the post becoming vacant, Dhaka Tribune reported.

"The Election Commission had already informed that it is prepared to conduct the presidential election. Once the election schedule is announced, the party chairman and Prime Minister will determine the BNP's candidate for the presidency," Home Minister Salahuddin Ahmed was quoted as saying by the BSS.

He said that no specific names were discussed at the meeting.

The party's Secretary General Alamgir said the Standing Committee also discussed the Government's development activities, the upcoming local Government elections, and organisational matters.

BNP standing committee members Dr Khandaker Mosharraf Hossain, Babu Gayeshwar Chandra Roy, Nazrul Islam Khan, Amir Khosru Mahmud Chowdhury, Iqbal Hasan Mahmud Tuku, Begum Selima Rahman, AZM. Zahid Hossain were also present at the meeting, the report added.

Plane crash in Peru kills 13 people

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Bogota

A plane carrying European tourists to view the famed Nazca Lines crashed into a field outside the Peruvian city of Ica on Saturday and was operated by Peruvian company Aerodiana. On its website, the airline said that it has offered scenic flights over the Nazca lines for the past 14 years using Cessna Grand Caravan planes.

The Nazca Lines are a group of extensive geoglyphs scraped into the desert around Nazca hundreds of years ago by Peru's Indigenous inhabitants. The lines form images of animals that can only be fully appreciated from planes or viewing towers.

Among the dead were seven Italian citizens between the ages of 18 and



54, two 52-year-old Spaniards and two Germans of 77 and 78 years, Peru's Transportation Ministry said. The other two fatalities were the pilot Americo Salazar and copilot Irenka Guanilo del Carpio, it said in an official report.

President Keiko Fujimori expressed regret over the

From Athens to Bordeaux, Europe's wildfire emergency rages on

ASSOCIATED PRESS  
■ Lacanau

Europe's wildfire crisis fractured along starkly different fronts Sunday: gale-force winds drove flames deeper into the Athens region and forced fresh evacuations, France guarded a still-burning scar four times the size of Paris against renewed spread, and Spain's major fires finally stopped advancing.

The centre of immediate danger was Greece. Flames spread through western Attica, the capital's surrounding region, threatening villages and an industrial district outside Megara as violent gusts prevented firefighting aircraft from collecting water from the sea.

Earlier this week, two firefighters died battling a blaze on Crete, while a third was killed in a separate fire in the Peloponnese.

But the easing emergency farther west offered little sense of an ending. France's largest wildfire remained con-



tained after 224,000 people were forced to flee in what may have been the largest civilian evacuation outside wartime. Active pockets still burned across 420 square kilometres (162 square miles) of devastated forest, thousands remained unable to return home, and nearly 3,000 firefighters were deployed against that blaze and a second, still-uncontained fire in Provence.

Fires in France and Spain alone have driven roughly a third of a million people from homes and vacation sites, emptied communities

warmed at more than twice the global average since the 1980s, according to the European Union's Copernicus Climate Change Service.

Human-caused climate change doubled the likelihood of the extreme fire conditions that fuelled the French blazes this year, scientists at World Weather Attribution calculated in a rapid analysis while the fires were still burning.

Nearly 500 firefighters and 23 aircraft were deployed, but gale-force winds fanned the fire while crippling the response. The winds drove flames through dry forest and made it impossible for some aircraft to descend to the sea for water.

Smoke rose over the mountains as evacuation orders were issued for the communities of Kandili, Agia Skepi and Toutouli. Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis was briefed on the operation, with authorities particularly concerned about Porto Germeno, a seaside community on the Gulf of Corinth.

Elsewhere, flames burned dangerously close to homes on Kefalonia, forcing evacuations from inland villages as aircraft made water drops over the Ionian tourist island. On the mainland, nearly 50 firefighters, a specialist wildfire unit, 16 engines and a helicopter battled another blaze near Nea Tenedos in Halkidiki.

The fire began Friday near Agios Vasileios before sweeping toward Porto Germeno and into the forested mountains west of Athens.

Firefighters evacuated 254 people by sea from Agios Vasileios on Friday and another 12 from Porto Germeno on Saturday - an escape route of last resort in coastal communities where fire and smoke can cut the few roads out.

Wildfire meteorologist Theodore Giannaros estimated Saturday that the blaze had affected 40 to 50 square kilometres (15 to 19 square miles), though authorities had not issued an official figure. (AP)

Ceuta grapples with aftermath of border surge after most migrants leave Spanish territory

SUMAN NAISHADHAM  
■ Ceuta (Spain)

Ceuta over the weekend no longer looked like a city on edge, but the events of the week were still on everyone's minds.

Most of the 60,000 migrants who swam, scrambled and later charged into the tiny Spanish exclave in North Africa this week had walked back to Morocco by Sunday, while others tried to blend in and stay on. Spanish civil guard ships continued searching for migrant bodies in the waters near the stretch of urban beach that tens of thousands of migrants had breached days earlier.

Shops in Ceuta reopened, and the usual blend of residents and tourists in the city of 84,000 was

filling the open-air terraces, restaurants and cafes.

But the city that prides itself on being home to four cultures was still grappling with the aftermath of the border surge, with locals disagreeing on what caused it and who exactly is to blame.

At least 72 migrants died, including some who drowned and others who were killed in a stampede to cross a breakwater barrier, Spanish authorities said Sunday. The humanitarian crisis caused by the sudden rush of people has reignited a debate around immigration in Europe and beyond.

"It's not the young men's fault," said Mohamad Abdelkader Driss, 44, a waiter at a fried fish restaurant in town. "If you open the



border, of course everyone comes in, but the young men aren't to blame. The authorities are responsible."

Some migrants who returned to Morocco described a border that was effectively open and said authorities did little as they watched thousands of people cross.

The unauthorised arrivals on Thursday and Friday of 50,000 to 60,000, mostly young men, swelled Ceuta's population by more than half. Abdelkader lamented what happened, but said that those who breached the border behaved relatively well.

"It could have been much worse," he said.

Over the weekend, far-right, anti-immigrant Spanish politi-

cians and well-known right-wing influencers descended on the city, sparking counterprotests that included members of the Spanish city's large Muslim population, many of whom are of Moroccan descent.

Alvise Perez, a far-right Spanish politician and member of the European Parliament, called on Saturday evening for migrants to be expelled as he faced an angry crowd of rival protesters. Perez eventually had to shelter in a bar as residents banged on the windows, until police escorted him away.

Among the counterprotesters on Saturday was 20-year-old Ceuta resident and student Noor Ahmed. She denounced the protest and presence of figures like Perez in her city as

opportunistic.

"They just want to take advantage of the humanitarian crisis Ceuta is currently experiencing," Ahmed said.

Santiago Abascal, the leader of the far-right Vox party, visited Ceuta on Sunday, slamming the Spanish Government for the surge in migrant arrivals, which he called "an invasion."

"The frontiers of Ceuta and Melilla are the walls of our home and homeland, and they are not being protected by a corrupt and traitorous Government," he said.

Some locals, even acknowledging Ceuta's population of Christians, Muslims, Jews and Hindus that normally live in relative harmony, worried about what the week revealed about the city. (AP)



▼PROSPECT

NCLAT rejects DoT’s ₹469-crore claim appeal in Rolta insolvency



The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) has dismissed the appeal filed by the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) challenging the resolution plan for debt-ridden Rolta India Ltd, holding that the plan has already been approved and implemented.

The DoT had challenged the resolution plan approved by NCLT while claiming statutory dues of ₹469.09 crore towards unpaid licence fees.

A three-member NCLAT bench upheld the order of the Mumbai bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT), which on December 15, 2025, approved the ₹900-crore resolution plan submitted by Ashdan Properties for Rolta India, a multinational technology company.

The tribunal observed that Rolta's resolution plan had already been implemented, with the NCLT closing the company petition on February 2, 2026. Moreover, DoT never raised the issue of categorisation of its claims before the NCLT during hearings.

"The resolution process having attained finality and the plan having been acted upon, interference to the order dated 15.12.2025 at this stage, would be inappropriate, and that the sanctity of an approved and implemented resolution plan is not to be disturbed on claims that were not timeously agitated," said the bench comprising Officiating Chairperson Justice Yogesh Khanna along with Members Barun Mitra and Ajai Das Mehrotra.

This was challenged by the DoT, an operational creditor, before the appellate tribunal NCLAT, claiming statutory dues of ₹469.09 crore towards unpaid licence fees linked to adjusted gross revenue (AGR) dues for FY2005-06 and FY2006-07. DoT had granted Rolta Internet Service Provider (ISP) license.

However, the resolution professional classified DoT's claim as "not acceptable but contingent" citing an interim stay granted by the Telecom Disputes Settlement and Appellate Tribunal (TDSAT).

IIFL Finance crosses 3,000 Gold Loan branches

IIFL Finance, a leading NBFC, has announced crossing 3,000 dedicated Gold Loan branches across India.

Mayank Sharma, Head - Gold Loan, IIFL Finance, said the milestone reflects the company's commitment to providing timely institutional credit to entrepreneurs, farmers, traders and self-employed individuals, irrespective of location.

"Millions of families own gold but remain underserved by formal finance. Our expanding network converts this trusted household asset into productive capital to help customers grow businesses, manage seasonal cash flows and meet financial needs with confidence," Sharma said.

The company added that the wider network will boost financial inclusion in tier-2, tier-3 towns and rural areas, powering MSME lending.



Nasha-Mukt Yuva for Viksit Bharat assembly held at Akshardham

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

A special assembly titled "Nasha-Mukt Yuva for Viksit Bharat" was organised on Sunday at BAPS Swaminarayan Akshardham in New Delhi. Thousands of young men and women from Delhi and adjoining regions participated in the event.

The programme began at 10:00 am with a devotional dhun and prayers. Prime Minister Narendra Modi then addressed the gathering virtually and urged the youth to adopt an addiction-free lifestyle as part of the vision for a developed India. Union Minister of Tourism and Culture Gajendra Singh Shekhawat was also present at the venue. The assembly was held simultaneously at all BAPS centres across the country.

Ahead of the Prime Minister's address, Pujya Ishwarcharandas Swami, a senior sadhu of BAPS, addressed the youth. He said, "Bhagwan Swaminarayan has commanded us to live a life free from addictions. Only one who is free from addictions can become a true Satsangi."

He added that since the Hon'ble Prime Minister is leading this noble campaign, everyone should join with enthusiasm and devotion to



support it. Gajendra Singh Shekhawat appreciated the youth initiatives undertaken by BAPS and encouraged the participants to engage in creative and constructive work.

In his virtual address, the Prime Minister emphasised the crucial role of young people in realising the dream of Viksit Bharat and called upon them to actively participate in building a de-addicted India.

The programme saw participation from youth, MY Bharat volunteers, NSS volunteers, students from schools and colleges, and representatives of more than 125 spiritual institutions. People joined virtually from 10,000 loca-

tions across the country.

The event highlighted BAPS' long-standing commitment to de-addiction. Since the time of Bhagwan Swaminarayan, over 3,000 sants and Paramhansas have travelled across villages, spreading the message of an addiction-free life. Carrying forward this mission, His Divine Holiness Pramukh Swami Maharaj inspired more than five million people during his lifetime to give up addictions and lead a pure and virtuous life. Those who took the pledge included farmers, members of tribal communities, business leaders and public figures.

For decades, BAPS has run

several initiatives to promote awareness:

1997: De-addiction camps were held in villages and towns across Gujarat. Mobile exhibitions were also organised to spread awareness, and many people pledged to stay away from intoxicants.

2000: Children aged 9 to 14 formed 2,500 groups and visited homes in Gujarat, Mumbai, Kolkata and other states. Lakhs of people signed written pledges to quit gutka, drugs, smoking and alcohol.

2007: Around 23,000 children and youth reached out to 2.1 million people through a nationwide campaign, with 6,30,000 people pledging to give up addictions. Former President Dr APJ Abdul Kalam met BAPS youth volunteers at Rashtrapati Bhavan, lauded their efforts and felicitated them.

2022: During Azadi Ka Amrit Mahotsav and the Birth Centenary of HDH Pramukh Swami Maharaj, BAPS youths led de-addiction drives across the country, inspiring lakhs to adopt a pure lifestyle.

Today, under the guidance of His Holiness Mahant Swami Maharaj, countless individuals continue to transform their lives by embracing an addiction-free path. Inspired by his darshan and saintly conduct, they are working toward a better future for themselves and for society.

NCC organises cyclothon to commemorate 79 years of India’s Independence



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The National Cadet Corps (NCC) organised Cyclothon 2026 on Sunday in New Delhi to commemorate 79 years of India's Independence.

The initiative aimed to inspire the youth to embrace fitness, environmental responsibility, and sustainable living while reinforcing the core values of patriotism, discipline, unity, and national service that form the foundation of the National Cadet Corps.

The Cyclothon was flagged off by the Union Minister of Youth Affairs and Sports, Mansukh Mandaviya, in the presence of the Minister of State for Defence, Sanjay Seth, renowned boxer MC Mary Kom and renowned tennis player Leander Paes. Director General, NCC, Lieutenant General Virendra

Vats led the group of 79 NCC cadets in a symbolic 79-kilometre ride to mark 79 years of India's Independence. The event commenced from Major Dhyan Chand National Stadium and concluded at the same venue after successfully covering the designated route through prominent landmarks of the National Capital.

Organised under the theme "Clean India, Green India, Fit India," the Cyclothon reaffirmed NCC's commitment to national missions such as TB Mukht Bharat, Swachh Bharat, Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam, and Har Ghar Tiranga. The event encouraged participants and the public to adopt cycling as an eco-friendly and sustainable mode of transport while promoting environmental conservation, reducing carbon emissions, and embracing healthy lifestyles.

No plan to monetise subsidiaries, focus on enhancing their value: PNB MD

KUMAR DIPANKAR  
■ New Delhi

With its capital adequacy ratio exceeding 18 per cent, Punjab National Bank has no immediate plans to monetise its subsidiaries, the bank's Managing Director and CEO Ashok Chandra said, adding that the lender will instead focus on strengthening their operations to unlock greater value in the future.

PNB's capital adequacy improved to 18.13 per cent as on June 30, 2026, compared to 17.5 per cent at the end of the first quarter of the previous fiscal year.

This is well above the regulatory requirement of 11.5 per cent.

As the bank is well capitalised, the bank will not be raising any fund from the

market to drive growth, Chandra told PTI in an interview.

In fact this year, the bank will retire ₹5,000 crore AT 1 and Tier II bonds, which are getting matured, he said, adding that this will help save ₹300 crore as there would no longer be interest outgo on these papers.

About monetisation of subsidiaries or associates, Chandra said, "We don't have any plan now. In fact, we are strengthening all these subsidiaries and we want to have value maximisation through strengthening those subsidiaries. In future, we will see how it pans out but in this financial year nothing (on the cards)."

He said all subsidiaries also are well capitalised whether the PNB MetLife



Ashok Chandra

India Insurance, PNB Housing Finance or PNB Gilts.

"Even our eight sponsored Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) are very very strong... so, I don't think any capital is required to any of our sub-

sidaries or any associates now," he said.

PNB is the sponsor for Assam Gramin Bank, Bihar Gramin Bank, Himachal Pradesh Gramin Bank, Punjab Gramin Bank, Haryana

Gramin Bank, Manipur Rural Bank, Tripura Gramin Bank, and West Bengal Gramin Bank.

Chandra exuded confidence that the bank's profit would surpass the ₹20,000-crore mark in the ongoing financial year.

The public sector lender had earned a net profit of Rs 16,904 crore in the previous financial year.

From the second quarter of the last financial year, the bank has been maintaining a net profit of over ₹5,000 crore every quarter, he said.

"We have maintained the same trend in the first quarter (ongoing financial year). And I am hopeful and confident that with the profitable growth, which is happening in the system... we will be surpassing the ₹5,000 crore

number and every quarter will be reaching a new height," he said.

On whether the bank can cross the ₹20,000-crore mark during FY27 at this run rate, he said, "If I am saying that every quarter ₹5,000 crore of net profit will happen, I think that goes to that figure which you are talking about."

To achieve the target, he said, the bank is focusing heavily on conducting mega outreach activities every quarter on a very large scale.

Besides, he said, retail, agri, MSME, and self-help groups are going to be the focus areas for asset creation.

Overall, loan growth will be 12-13 per cent while deposits would be growing at 9-10 per cent during the ongoing financial year, he added.

DAILY SUDOKU

|   |   |  |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|--|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 6 | 3 |  | 8 |   |   |   |   |   |
|   |   |  | 3 | 7 |   |   | 1 | 9 |
| 9 |   |  |   | 4 |   |   | 3 |   |
| 1 |   |  |   |   |   |   | 9 | 7 |
|   |   |  | 2 | 3 | 8 |   |   |   |
| 4 | 6 |  |   |   |   |   |   | 3 |
|   | 1 |  |   | 8 |   |   |   | 5 |
| 5 | 9 |  |   | 6 | 2 |   |   |   |
|   |   |  |   | 4 |   | 7 | 2 |   |

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

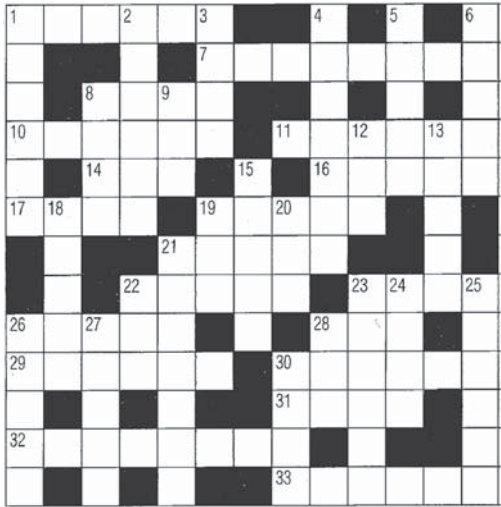
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.

SOLUTION (1.8.26)

|   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 3 | 5 | 8 | 2 | 4 | 7 | 6 | 9 | 1 |
| 1 | 2 | 6 | 8 | 9 | 3 | 5 | 7 | 4 |
| 9 | 4 | 7 | 1 | 6 | 5 | 2 | 8 | 3 |
| 5 | 3 | 4 | 6 | 7 | 9 | 8 | 1 | 2 |
| 7 | 8 | 2 | 5 | 3 | 1 | 9 | 4 | 6 |
| 6 | 9 | 1 | 4 | 2 | 8 | 3 | 5 | 7 |
| 8 | 7 | 5 | 3 | 1 | 6 | 4 | 2 | 9 |
| 4 | 6 | 9 | 7 | 8 | 2 | 1 | 3 | 5 |
| 2 | 1 | 3 | 9 | 5 | 4 | 7 | 6 | 8 |

DOUBLE CROSSWORD  
MONDAY | AUGUST 3, 2026



- ACROSS
- 1 It's endless and could be magic (6)
- 7 Outburst that could bring aid to the people (8)
- 8 Pain does father no good (4)
- 10 Doctor going back to tell fibs to young lass (6)
- 11 Regarding a city, England's capital is cultured (6)
- 14 One caught in the Elbe? (3)
- 16 One takes a turn around town (5)
- 17 Transported soldiers for training (4)
- 19 Local centre also shifted (as to Newcastle?) (5)
- 21 It takes a turn playing records! (5)
- 22 Be ill, perhaps, due to transgression (5)
- 23 Men of tomorrow (4)
- 26 Shoot the rotten pigs! (5)
- 28 Prohibition, as related to alcoholic drink lass (6)
- 29 The remainder showed hesitation in disseminating tosh (6)
- 30 A growing source of wooden blades (6)
- 31 Finishing comfortably in good style (4)
- 32 The vehicle one got rid of has gone (8)
- 33 A happy one can be dramatic (6)
- DOWN
- 1 No ordinary eel can be said to dance! (6)
- 2 Talk about the French at Swiss Cottage! (6)
- 3 Border of united Germany (4)
- 4 Make a shocking debut at short leg (7)
- 5 Tobacco usefully wrapped (5)
- 6 Left still on the loch (5)
- 8 Quietly representative sort of school? (4)
- 9 There's nothing in lining up (3)
- 12 It should have a lane to itself (3)
- 13 Smart way to get fit in New York (5)
- 15 Swede (a prize specimen)? (5)
- 18 Take up half the load as you choose (5)
- 19 Where to get advice about taxis? (3)
- 15, Sto-ic
- 16, S-ham-s
- 18, Title
- 19, Pig-tail
- 21, Ravage
- 22, F-ig-aro
- 23, Reverse
- 25, S-L-ash
- 26, Site
- 12, Seash
- 13, Seash
- 14, Libel
- 19, Paris
- 20, Credit
- 22, Firm
- 24, Mail
- 25, St-U-ices
- 26, Mania
- 27, Stole
- 28, Rated
- 29, Tipster
- 30, Level (rev.)
- 31, Poles
- 20 A £50 total (3)
- 21 She's catty in a big way (7)
- 22 Ball location, a bit unbelievable? (3)
- 23 It's no good embracing everything in one song (6)
- 24 The suburb of Paris one may have landed in (4)
- 25 Working for unity with the southeastern member (6)
- 26 To mend shattered loves is all you have to do (5)
- 27 With no tail, this animal is obviously shortened (5)
- 28 It protects against spillage in imbibing
- 30 Go paddling with Virginia (4)

Higher tobacco taxes burn cigarette makers’ net revenue, volumes, profit in Q1

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

The government's steep increase in taxes on cigarettes and tobacco products has started weighing on the country's leading cigarette makers, with ITC, Godfrey Phillips India, and VST Industries reporting declines in net revenue, volumes and profitability in the April-June quarter, the first full quarter after the revised tax regime came into effect.

The three companies together account for more than 90 per cent of the domestic cigarette market, which, according to some reports, has an estimated annual volume of over 100-120 billion sticks.

Earlier in February this year, the government raised the goods and services tax (GST) on cigarettes and tobacco products to a flat 40 per cent. It replaced the compensation cess with a new additional excise duty ranging from ₹2,100-8,500 per 1,000 sticks, depending



on cigarette length. Though reported revenues (from operations) of cigarette companies surged as the higher duty component was reflected in sales, their underlying revenues (net revenue) and profits came under pressure as companies grappled with the impact of the unprecedented tax increase.

In the June quarter of FY27, market leader ITC's revenue from the cigarettes business grew 73.71 per cent to ₹16,596.67 crore, from ₹9,553.86 crore a year earlier — a rise which the company attributed to its "staggered pricing approach amidst unprecedented increase in

tax." However, the company's gross revenue (from sale of products and services) in the cigarettes segment, which strips out duty pass-through, actually fell 31.45 per cent to ₹3,769.11 crore, from ₹5,498.93 crore in the year-ago quarter — pointing to a hit on underlying sales volumes.

ITC, which controls over three-fourths of the domestic cigarette market, said it had mounted a "strategic and calibrated response by the Cigarettes Business to the unprecedented increase in tax, balancing the interests of all stakeholders".

ITC's cigarette brands include India Kings, Insignia

and Classic in the premium segment, and Gold Flake, Wills Navy Cut, Scissors, Capstan and Players in the mass-market segment.

Godfrey Phillips India reported a 44.3 per cent decline in consolidated net profit to ₹198.39 crore for the June quarter. Revenue from operations of the Modi Enterprises firm nearly doubled to ₹3,819.56 crore, largely on account of ₹2,614 crore in excise duty paid during the quarter.

Excluding excise, its net revenue fell 18.8 per cent to ₹1,206 crore, from ₹1,486 crore in the year-ago period, the company said.

Godfrey Phillips sells cigarettes under brands, including Cavanders, Four Square, Red & White, Stellar, North Pole and Tipper, besides Marlboro, which is owned by Philip Morris.

VST Industries, which owns the Total, Editions and Charms brands, said its quarterly performance was also weighed down by the sharp tax increase.

Bank of Maharashtra slashes home loan rates to 7%

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ New Delhi

Public sector lender Bank of Maharashtra (BoM) on Sunday slashed its home loan rate to 7 per cent from the existing 7.1 per cent as part of an offer.

The bank has launched of a special limited period — Monsoon Dhamaka — offering its home loan starting from 7 per cent interest rate along with complete waiver of processing fees and doc-



umentation charges, BoM said in a statement on Sunday.

This triple benefit of reduced interest rates with zero processing fees and

documentation charges reflects bank's commitment to offer best financing solutions to all its customers and help them fulfil their dreams, it said.

The 7 per cent interest rate on home loans and 7.45 per cent interest rate on car loan are priced among the lowest in the industry, which along with zero processing fees and documentation charges, significantly reduce the EMI burden on the customers, it said.



BRIEFLY

Crew play Miami to a 2-2 draw as Lionel Messi returns



Brais Mendez scored a late equaliser in his MLS debut and the Columbus Crew played Inter Miami to a 2-2 draw. Columbus (5-8-5) ended Miami's six-game winning streak on Saturday. Miami (11-2-5) is still unbeaten in seven straight games. Mendez curled a free kick from the right side that went untouched off the post and into the net in the 84th minute to tie it.

Lionel Messi, who entered as a substitute in the 53rd minute after leading Argentina to its second straight World Cup final appearance, had several good scoring chances in the closing stages but couldn't find the back of the net. Columbus also scored on an own goal in the first half. Luis Suarez opened the scoring in the 16th for Miami - with his seventh goal in the last four regular-season games. Suarez became the fifth player in MLS history to record at least 10 goals and five assists in each of his first three MLS seasons. Noah Allen gave Miami a 2-1 lead on a header in first-half stoppage time. Kickoff was delayed 40 minutes by inclement weather.

(AP)

Lewandowski scores 2 goals as Chicago beats Charlotte FC



Robert Lewandowski scored two goals, including the winner, in his home debut for the Fire, helping Chicago beat Charlotte FC 2-1.

Lewandowski, who made the move from FC Barcelona in a two-year deal with Chicago, equalised in the 20th minute off a screamer from outside the box that tied the game at 1 on Saturday. He connected on his second goal of the night in the 68th minute with a go-ahead shot to the bottom left corner to seal the win for the Fire (9-6-2), who played their first home match in over two months. Pep Biel gave Charlotte (7-7-4) an early lead with a shot from the right side of the box on an assist from Idan Toklomati. Charlotte pushed for an equalizer late and earned a corner in stoppage time, but Chicago held on to preserve the one-goal lead. Charlotte entered the match unbeaten in its last two games, but dropped its third straight against the Fire.

(AP)

CWG: Boxers shine with 7 gold, best show by judokas

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Glasgow

Boxers punched their way to a record-breaking haul of seven gold medals, while judokas and para track and field athletes also shone on the most productive day for India in the Commonwealth Games here on Saturday.

On the penultimate day of competitions, India jumped to the fourth spot in the medal table with 13 gold, 17 silver and 9 bronze for a total of 39 podium finishes. Australia led the medal table with 62 gold medals, followed by England (26 gold) and Canada (18 gold).

Out of the eight gold won by the Indians, boxers con-

tributed seven in their best ever show in the Commonwealth Games. India topped the boxing medal table with seven gold and three silver.

The other gold was won by Soman Rana in the men's F57 para shot put event.

In the boxing ring, India reigned supreme with their women pugilists living up to their billing with a dominant five-gold haul, while Sachin Siwach and Ankush Panghal sealed the men's titles as the country produced its greatest-ever performance in the sport at the Commonwealth Games. Reigning world champion Jaismine Lamboria (57kg), Asian Games medallist Preeti Pawar (54kg), Asian



champion Priya Ghanghas (60kg), Sakshi Chaudhary (51kg) and Arundhati Choudhary (70kg) won gold medals, while Olympic medallist Lovlina Borgohain (75kg) settled for silver.

In the men's competition, Sachin (60kg) and Ankush (70kg) struck gold, while

Sharma clinched a bronze medal in the women's 63kg event to continue the country's historic run at the Commonwealth Games. Unnati defeated South Africa's Skye Knoester by ippon, wrapping up the contest in just 1 minute and 7 seconds with a decisive move, hooking her leg to unbalance Knoester before throwing her cleanly onto her back to earn an ippon -- the highest score in judo -- and seal the bout instantly. The Indian had earlier gone down to Australia's Saya Middleton in the semifinal but bounced back strongly to secure a place on the podium with an emphatic victory.

The bronze was India's

fourth medal in judo, continuing the country's best-ever Commonwealth Games campaign in the sport. The historic run was led by Harsh Singh (men's -60kg) and Asmita Dey (women's -48kg), who became India's first-ever Commonwealth Games judo gold medallists with twin titles on Saturday.

Yamini Mourya added a silver in the women's -57kg category, giving India their record haul.

India will have a chance to add to their record tally on the concluding day on Sunday, with Ishroop Narang (women's -78kg), Avtar Singh (men's -100kg) and Yash Ghangas (men's +100kg) all in medal contention.

Gulveer wins bronze in 5,000m, first Indian to win 2 athletics medals in CWG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Glasgow

Gulveer Singh, on Saturday, scripted history as he became the first Indian to win a 5000m medal in the Commonwealth Games with a bronze as well as the first track and field athlete from the country to win two medals in a single edition of the Games.

Reigning Asian champion Gulveer, who had won a silver in the 10,000m on July 28, finished third in the 5000m with a time of 13 minute 24.95 seconds to complete a historic double on the concluding day of the athletics competition. Mathew Kipchumba



Kipsang of Kenya took the gold with a time of 13:23.61, while Australia's Ky Robinson, who had earlier won the gold in the 10,000m, clinched the silver, clocking 13:24.70.

However, the 28-year-old

Indian, who holds national records in both 5000m and 10,000m, ran much below his season best timing of 13:03.93. His Saturday's time was also well outside his national record effort of 12:59.77.

Gulveer, who also won a 10,000m bronze in the Hangzhou Asian Games in 2023, kept himself among the leading pack throughout the race before surging ahead in the final lap. He beat Kenya's Cornelius Kemboi for the bronze by a mere 0.04 seconds.

Kemboi is a sub-13 runner, having clocked 12:56.02 in June, but on Saturday, Gulveer beat him, though by a whisker.

Indian shuttler, Tanvi Sharma wins maiden BWF Super 300 title at Taipei Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Taipei City

Teen sensation Tanvi Sharma clinched her maiden BWF World Tour title after defeating Vietnam's sixth seed Thuy Linh Nguyen in straight games in the women's singles final of the Taipei Open Super 300 badminton tournament in Taipei City on Sunday. The 17-year-old from Punjab, who had finished runner-up at last year's US Open Super 300, needed just 36 minutes to outclass world No. 21 Nguyen 21-16 21-16 in the summit clash.

"I'm really very happy to win this title here," said Tanvi, who became the youngest champion in Taipei Open history at just 17 years and 222 days old, surpassing the legendary Tai Tzu Ying. "I didn't expect to win a title, but yeah,

I just thought I'll give my best over here. So I was going step by step, match by match. So yeah, every match I played really well here."

Coached by PV Sindhu's former mentor Park Tae-sang, Tanvi also became the first Indian to win the women's singles title at the Taipei Open since Saina Nehwal, who had lifted the trophy in 2008. "I was quite nervous, but I just thought I will play my 100 percent, what I have in my game, I will play that," said Tanvi, who dropped only one game all week. "It was pretty hard for me as well, playing five matches. But yeah, I just needed to be consistent. I have to work harder for playing Super 500 and 750s. So I'll be keep working hard."

Tanvi had defeated Nguyen en route to the final at US



Open. The Indian made a flying start, repeatedly catching Nguyen at the front court with deft drops played with the same action as a smash to open up a 4-1 lead.

The Vietnamese struggled to read the Indian's deception and also found it difficult to judge the drift, going wide twice as Tanvi mixed steep cross-court smashes with her

powerful smashes from both flanks to move 15-9 ahead. Though she gifted away a few points with errors at the net and from the back court, she regained control, earning five game points before sealing the opening game with a cross-court smash. After the change of ends, Nguyen opened a 3-0 lead by making Tanvi cover the court with sharp angles. But the Indian slowly began dictating the rallies, drawing level at 3-3 with a fine net shot before once again pushing her opponent deep and catching her at the net with deft touches.

Nguyen's inconsistency also helped Tanvi build an 8-4 lead before another patch of errors allowed the Vietnamese to close the gap to 7-8, prompting Park to tap his head in frustration. Two exquisite deceptive winners helped Tanvi take

an 11-8 lead at the interval.

The Indian gradually stretched the advantage to 15-10 and then 18-12, her deception once again fetching crucial points. At 19-12, Tanvi successfully challenged a line call after being ruled late, but soon earned seven match points with a smash. A nervous finish saw her squander three of them before she finally converted to seal her maiden BWF title. In a heartwarming moment, Tanvi took off her gold medal and placed it around coach Park Tae-sang's neck before the two posed together for photographs.

Tanvi is the youngest finalist in the tournament's history, surpassing Korean doubles great Lee Yong Dae, who was 17 years and 287 days old when he reached the men's doubles final in 2006.

India to host Malaysia U-21 men's hockey team for 8-match exposure series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Bengaluru

India will host Malaysia U-21 men's hockey team for an eight-match exposure series at the SAI Netaji Subhas Southern Centre here from August 7 to 13.

The Malaysia U-21 men's hockey team will take on the Indian junior men's side in five matches and the SAI team in three matches. The series forms an important part of both teams' preparations for upcoming international competitions.

The exposure series is designed to provide both teams with high-quality competitive opportunities while



strengthening bilateral sporting ties. The Indian junior team will face Malaysia on August 7, August 8, August 10, August 12, and August 13. In addition, the Malaysian team will take on the SAI Team on August 3, August 5, and August 15.

Speaking ahead of the series, Indian junior men's

hockey team coach Frederic Soyez said, "These matches will serve as important preparation for the Asia Cup.

They are part of the continuity of the work we started during our tour in Belgium, where we already saw significant progress throughout the matches we played there. "We hope this series against

Malaysia will allow us to continue building on that progress by reinforcing the work we put in during our time in Belgium, as well as the improvements made over this past week of training."

The exposure tour follows the Indian junior team's productive training and competition phase in Belgium and forms a key part of their preparations for the upcoming Junior Asia Cup. The series is expected to provide the players with valuable international match experience and help the coaching staff assess combinations and strategies ahead of the continental tournament.

Ankur, Yashaswini bag title in Commonwealth TT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Ankur Bhattacharjee and Yashaswini Ghorpade clinched the men's and women's singles title with contrasting wins at the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships here on Sunday. Bhattacharjee emerged a deserving 4-3 winner over Payas Jain after a hard-fought match.

Payas looked set for victory after opening a 7-4 lead in the deciding game.

However, Ankur called a timeout that disrupted his opponent's rhythm, and fought back to level at 8-8. He then edged ahead 10-9, and eventually sealed the title 11-9 when Payas' return drifted long. In the women's final,



Ghorpade delivered a commanding performance to defeat Sreeja Akula 4-1.

India dominated the championships, winning all but one of the gold medals on offer. The lone title eluded the hosts was the men's doubles, where Malaysia's pair defeated Manav Thakkar and Manush Shah in the final.

Ghorpade dominated the opening two games, racing to an 11-6, 11-1 lead and putting Sreeja under immense pressure.

Sreeja responded admirably, taking the third game 11-8 to keep her hopes alive, but Ghorpade quickly regained control, claiming the fourth game 11-7 and

moving within touching distance of the title.

The fifth game produced the most entertaining contest of the match, with both players matching each other point-for-point in a tense finish. Although Sreeja fought hard and saved two championship points, she failed to benefit from crucial opportunities at the business end.

Yashaswini held her nerve to convert her third match point, sealing a 13-11 victory and the championship in style. In the men's doubles final, contrary to expectations, Malaysia's Shen Qi Wong and Javen Choong delivered a clinical display, defeating India's Manav Thakkar and Manush Shah, the world No. 2 pair, in straight games.

Debutants Samaleswari Sporting stun Mohammedan SC in five-goal thriller

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE  
■ Kolkata

Durand Cup debutants Samaleswari Sporting stunned two-time champions Mohammedan SC 3-2 in a thrilling Group B fixture of the 135th IndianOil Durand Cup at the Vivekananda Yuba Bharati Krirangan in Kolkata on Sunday, August 2, 2026.

The side from Odisha took a two-goal lead through strikes from Basit Ahmed Bhat and Russian forward Marat Tareck. Mohammedan levelled the scores in the second half through strikes from Lalthankima and Lalngaihsaka. Samaleswari found the winning strike nine minutes from time through a well

taken free kick by Veer Arjun Joshi. Samaleswari ended their group stage proceedings with six matches from three matches while Mohammedan remain on three points from two matches.

Mohammedan Sporting Club head coach Mehrajuddin Wadoo retained his preferred 4-2-3-1 formation, making just one change to the side that defeated Baghpat FC. F. Lalremsanga replaced Md. Fardin Ali Molla in the starting XI, while the remaining ten players kept their places. Samaleswari Sporting head coach Abdul Azim Siddique also made a solitary change, introducing Kongbrailatpam Manjit Sharma for Prosenjit Chakraborty in an otherwise

unchanged 4-4-2 lineup.

Mohammedan made a bright start, dominating possession and pinning Samaleswari deep inside their own half. F. Lalremsanga looked particularly dangerous with his direct running, while the Kolkata side repeatedly threatened with crosses into the penalty area and efforts from distance. However, Samaleswari defended resolutely, standing firm to withstand pressure.

Completely against the run of play, the Odisha-based side broke the deadlock from a well-worked set-piece. Hafiz Ur Rehman Khan delivered an inviting corner into the penalty area, where captain Basit Ahmed Bhat timed his near-



post run to perfection before guiding a clinical finish beyond the goalkeeper to give Samaleswari the lead.

Samaleswari Sporting made the first substitution of the contest by introducing Cris Nowang Sherpa, who made an immediate impact down the left flank. Using his pace to beat

his marker, Sherpa whipped a dangerous cross into the penalty area for Gnohere Krizo. Although the Ivorian failed to bring the ball under control, it fell kindly to a teammate whose goal-bound effort was bravely blocked by the Mohammedan defence, with the visitors forced to settle for

a corner. At the other end, Mohammedan continued to pose a threat by winning possession high up the pitch and switching play with long diagonal passes into the wide areas. However, Samaleswari's backline remained disciplined, dealing comfortably with a succession of crosses into the penalty area to preserve their advantage.

Samaleswari Sporting doubled their advantage through Marat Tareck following a superb piece of direct play. Hafiz Ur Rehman Khan picked out the Russian forward with a perfectly weighted long ball from deep, and Tareck brought it under control with an excellent first touch before skilfully beating his marker.

Keeping his composure, the striker slotted a precise finish into the bottom-left corner, punishing Mohammedan Sporting's defence after they were caught out by the swift attacking move.

Trailing by two goals, Mohammedan Sporting Club responded with urgency and dominated the remainder of the first half. F. Lalremsanga remained at the heart of their attacking play, winning possession in midfield, earning a series of corners and troubling the Samaleswari defence with dangerous deliveries into the penalty area and long-range efforts. The Kolkata side carved out their best chance of the half when Lalremsanga threaded a clever pass into the

box for Lalthankima, but the forward failed to keep his effort on target. Despite applying constant pressure in the attacking third, Mohammedan were unable to find a breakthrough as Samaleswari's defence stood firm to protect their two-goal lead going into interval.

Mohammedan Sporting Club made a double substitution at the start of the second half, introducing Md. Fardin Ali Molla for Israfil Dewan and Thokchom Addison Singh in place of Yash Chickro. Samaleswari Sporting also refreshed their lineup, with Veer Arjun Joshi replacing Gnohere Krizo and Aravindraj Rajan coming on for William Pauliankhum.



# Mirabai Chanu says Asian Games medal next target

SUMAN RAY  
■ New Delhi

Olympic silver medallist and three-time consecutive CWG gold medallist Mirabai Chanu acknowledged the pressure of high expectations, saying her next target is an elusive Asian Games medal. Chanu began her ascent at the 2014 Glasgow CWG with a silver medal before winning three consecutive golds in her weight category in Gold Coast in 2018, Birmingham in 2022 and Glasgow again in 2026. She also won the World Championships gold in 2017 and silver medals in 2022 and 2025, besides medals at

the Asian and Common wealth Champion ships. "Winning a medal makes you very happy, but it is also very difficult. You have more responsibilities and have to give your best in upcoming competitions. There is a lot of pressure. An Asian Games medal will be very important for me. "I will try my best because I have to win where I have never won a medal before. So, the Asian Games is very important for me. Yes, I am aiming for an Asian Games medal next, for which there is pressure," Chanu told PTI in an interview here on Sunday after returning from her successful CWG cam-



paign in Glasgow. "Some athletes are very happy when they win a medal. But for me, winning a medal gives me strength. I think I have to work even harder to win the next medal," she added. Recalling her happiest and saddest career moments -- both at different Olympics - Chanu said regrouping and competing at her best again was difficult. "There is a lot of pressure in every competition that I have to win this medal. That has been the story. Every athlete wants to participate in the Olympics. Getting a medal there was a dream, but I felt very sad when I

missed it by a whisker in the Paris Olympics. "It was very difficult to regroup and compete at the highest level. I had to plan ahead and work very hard," she said. Summarising her journey, Chanu said she had tried to live up to the responsibility and expectations placed on her. "I was very happy when I won the silver medal for India in 2014 in Glasgow. After that, I was given more responsibility for weightlifting. I had to decide what I wanted to do and how far I wanted to go. "Gradually, I learned about international weightlifting and how much effort I had to put in. I tried

my best to do what I wanted for Indian weightlifting. Gradually, I got support from everyone. I am very happy that I was able to achieve all this with the support of my coach Vijay Sharma sir," she said. Chanu said there would be no special training ahead of the Asian Games and she would continue with her normal schedule. "The key will be to remain injury-free leading up to the Games. No special training will be required; just the usual stuff," she signed off, adding that she would be happy to receive her childhood dream of an Arjuna Award despite already holding Khel Ratna. (PTI)

## Glasgow restaurant to correct India map after Lovlina flags omission of Northeast: BFI



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Boxing Federation of India (BFI) president Ajay Singh on Sunday said a popular Indian restaurant in Glasgow has assured the Indian contingent that it will correct a map of India displayed on its premises after boxer Lovlina Borgohain pointed out that the Northeast was missing from it. Singh said there was "no confrontation" with the restaurant management during the team's celebratory dinner following India's historic haul of 10 boxing medals -- seven gold and three silver -- at the ongoing Commonwealth Games. "There was no confrontation. It was an aberration and we pointed that out, me and Lovlina. They accepted their mistake and assured us that it will be corrected," Singh told PTI. The Indian contingent had visited Mister Singh's India,

The Home of Curry in Glasgow on Saturday to celebrate its unprecedented performance at the Games. The issue came to light after Lovlina, the Olympic medallist from Assam who won a silver, noticed that the map of India printed on the restaurant's napkins and displayed outside its premises omitted the Northeast. "Please don't take this the wrong way. I felt a little hurt by this. In the map of India, our North East is missing. Yes, even outside, the map that's displayed has cut off the North East. As someone from the North East, that really hurts us. That's all I wanted to say. Please keep this in mind next time. Thank you so much," Lovlina said in a video shared on social media. The restaurant is a well-known Indian dining destination in Glasgow and has hosted several touring sports teams and dignitaries over the years.

## CWG: Judoka Ishroop loses bronze medal bout

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Glasgow

Judoka Ishroop Narang gave her all in the bronze medal play-off but lost to Canadian Coralie Godbout by yuko as India's judo campaign ended at the Commonwealth Games without any medal on the concluding day of the quadrennial event here Sunday. The hopes to add one more medal in the Indian tally were riding on Ishroop after she jumped into medal contention following her tremendous win over Cameroon's stronger and taller Georgika Wesly Djengue Moune in the repechage round of women's -78 kg. The 19-year-old won by



waza-ari after her opponent scored two yukos. However, an aggressive Godbout proved a tough nut to crack for Ishroop, who received two shidos in the regulation time and eventually lost in the golden score time. Yash Ghangas and Avtar Singh, the other Indian judokas in the fray on the

bronze. Earlier in the day, Ishroop lost by Ippon to England's Emma Reid in the quarterfinal. She received two shido penalties while Emma secured two waza-ari scores during the four-minute contest to complete the victory. The Indian had registered a win by a yuko in the golden score period against Nicole Wood of Scotland in the round of 16 match. The match remained deadlocked at the end of regulation time, with both judokas picking up a shido each. Ishroop finally broke the stalemate one minute and 40 seconds into the golden score, scoring a decisive yuko to seal the contest after five minutes and 40 seconds.

## Nadeem cops criticism for poor show in Glasgow CWG

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Lahore

Pakistan's Olympic gold medallist javelin thrower Arshad Nadeem has come in for criticism after his disappointing in the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. Nadeem finished ninth with a sub-80 effort in Glasgow with Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirage winning gold and India's Neeraj Chopra and Yashvir Singh finishing second and third respectively. The outcome was not unexpected keeping in mind Arshad took part in only one preparatory event in Switzerland in 2026 for the CWG and that he spent all his time training in the hot

weather in Lahore without working with any foreign coaches or trainers in person. Arshad, who has previously trained under South African caoch, Terseus Liebenberg trained with his local coach, Salman Butt and local trainers. Ironically the weather conditions in Lahore and Glasgow were the opposite. Now compare this with how Arshad's arch rival, Neeraj Chopra and other Indian javelin throwers trained for the CWG. While Neeraj had his final preparation and rehabilitation camp at his training camp ion Biene in Switzerland his teammates like Rohit Yadav and Yashvir Singh trained in Spala, Poland with foreign coaches



and trainers. The result India won the silver and bronze medals in the CWG Javelin throw events. Arshad, who was the defending champion in the Commonwealth Games after winning the gold in the last CWG in Birmingham in 2022 with a best of 90.12 metres was

unable to even cross the 80 metres mark in the finals in Glasgow. He failed to qualify for the final round of eight due to his poor performance dashing Pakistan's hopes of another medal in the games. For his fans it was a big letdown to see him struggling to even get past the 80

metres mark as he had also won the Olympic Gold Medal with a record throw of 92.97. Arshad's long serving coach, Salman Butt admitted that Arshad was nowhere his best in the CWG and was under prepared. While Arshad is also to partially blame for his fall from grace as he clearly didn't look 100 percent fit in the finals, he has also had to battle many issues off the track. The biggest one being the Pakistan Amateur Athletics Federation totally disowned him after a feud over the retention of Salman Butt as coach last year. A reliable source close to Arshad said that since late last year the PAAF and even the Pakistan Sports Board have not made life easy for

## Bumrah ruled out Sri Lanka Test series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Premier pacer Jasprit Bumrah is set to miss India's two-Test tour of Sri Lanka as he is yet to recover from his knee injury. The swelling in his knee seems to be more serious than it initially looked and the Sports Science team at Bengaluru's Centre of Excellence doesn't want to rush the seasoned pacer to the grind of international cricket, keeping in mind a packed calendar ahead. The Sri Lanka series begins August 15 in Galle. The 32 year old had missed out on the third ODI against England at Lord's after sustaining an impact



injury. He recently reported at the Centre Of Excellence in Bengaluru and was expected to be match-fit by the time series begins in two weeks. However it has been learnt that Bumrah is still feeling some discomfort and even if he gets fit before August 15 or the second Test starting August 23, the medical team isn't sure if Test match is correct format

due to a massive workload on the docile tracks. It will be interesting to see of selectors pick Jammu and Kashmir pacer Aaquib Nabi or Vidarbha's Yash Thakur as Bumrah's replacement. India are already without Nitish Kumar Reddy (hamstring), Harshit Rana (hamstring) and Washington Sundar (hamstring) will miss at least the first Test.

## BFI hopeful of similar show at Asian Games

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ New Delhi

Boxing Federation of India president Ajay Singh on Sunday lauded the Indian pugilists for their remarkable 10-medal show at the Commonwealth Games and urged them to work even harder to repeat the exceptional performance at the Asian Games in Japan next month. Indian boxers returned with a record haul of 10 medals from the CWG, including seven gold and three silver, a first in the history of the Games for the country. "We had an exceptional and historic last two days. Winning seven gold and three silver in boxing is the



biggest performance in the last 100 years history of Commonwealth Games," Singh said. "This is also a preparation for future events, the Asian Games and 2028 Olympics. We can replicate such a performance in Asian Games, we are top 3 in Asia in boxing but for that we need to prepare hard from now and be focussed to produce strong performance."

## Ronaldo 20th in time trial, India sign off from CWG cycling

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA  
■ Glasgow

Ronaldo Singh Laitonjam finished 20th in the men's 1000m time trial while Harshveer Singh Sekhon and Dinesh Kumar were eliminated from the men's 40km points race in Heats as the country's cycling campaign came to an end at the Commonwealth Games here on Sunday. While Sekhon could not finish the race in Heat 1 of the points race qualifiers, Dinesh ended 11th among 12 riders at the Chris Hoy Velodrome in the qualifying round. The last three riders from each



heat were eliminated. Later in the day, Ronaldo clocked 1:04.191 to finish 20th in the men's 1000m time trial. Only three riders went under the one-minute mark, with Australia's Leigh Hofmann taking the gold in

58.530 seconds, ahead of England's Joseph Truman (59.525) and Australia's Tayte Ryan (59.684), who claimed silver and bronze respectively. The result brought the curtains down on India's cycling campaign at the Games.

## Shrug off jersey issue, focus on ending 50-year WC medal drought: Sreejesh

MONA PARTHSARATHI  
■ New Delhi

The legendary P R Sreejesh has advised the Indian men's hockey team to leave behind the unnecessary jersey controversy and off-field noises and focus on ending the country's 50-year World Cup medal drought in next month's quadrennial event in the Netherlands and Belgium. The two-time Olympic bronze medallist said there was nothing unusual about

changing jersey colours, noting that India had worn different kits at the 2014 and 2018 World Cups. While he questioned the reasoning that blue jerseys hamper visibility on blue turfs, Sreejesh stressed that if the players had approved the decision, the debate should end there. "To be honest, I didn't initially understand what the issue was because the jersey colour had changed for the 2014 and 2018 World Cups as well. Even one of our training



kits was orange. Why is there so much discussion before the World Cup this time? Is it because of the saffron colour or simply because the colour changed?" Sreejesh told PTI. The Indian men and women teams will wear saffron jerseys instead of their traditional blue as the primary kit at the World Cup beginning on August 15, a move that has drawn criticism from several former captains, including Viren Rasquinha, Dhanraj Pillay, Ajit Pal Singh,

Vasudevan Baskaran and Pargat Singh. Sreejesh, however, said he had no objection regarding the change of jersey colour but found the explanation that blue jerseys affected visibility on blue turfs difficult to understand. "If the controversy is about the colour change, then it should have happened in 2014 and 2018 too, when we wore yellow and light blue jerseys. "I have no issue with changing the jersey colour, but the reason being cited is

strange. If the colour is being changed due to visibility issues during play, then the blue jersey should never be worn again," he said. The former goalkeeper, who represented India in 339 international matches and later coached the junior team to a bronze medal at last year's Junior World Cup in Chennai, acknowledged that identical colours could marginally affect visibility but said it had never been considered a major concern despite blue turfs being in use since

the 2012 London Olympics. "It is true that having the same colour makes visibility a bit difficult, but in the 14 years since the blue turf was introduced, the jersey colour has changed only twice. We have played in blue in almost every major tournament, including the Tokyo and Paris Olympics." Sreejesh maintained that if the players had endorsed the decision, there was little reason for further debate. "From what I have seen in the media, the colour change

was made with the players consent. Hockey India must have obtained permission from the FIH for the saffron jersey. Since orange is also the colour of the Netherlands' jersey, we can wear our alternate white jersey when playing against them," he said. "If the players have approved this decision, the matter ends there, because ultimately it is the players who have to perform on the field." With the controversy taking political overtones, Sreejesh was categorical. (PTI)